VERIFIED NEPAL · PUBLIC-SITE AUDIT

How Nepal reads, and whether Verified Nepal meets it

Three reports on how Nepali audiences consume news and civic information online, what an ideal Nepali public-information portal looks like, and how the public side of verifiednepal.com measures up. The admin and moderator tools are out of scope.

DATE	14 October 2026
SUBJECT	verifiednepal.com, public pages only
METHOD	Six web-research tracks and a code and live-site inventory, then a five-advisor review council with anonymised peer review and a chairman verdict
STATUS	Draft for independent review

In this document

Part 1	**Audience research.** Who reads what in Nepal, on which device and platform, whom they trust, what annoys them, how portals gain traction, and the pain points and open questions of nine personas. 165 numbered references.
Part 2	**The ideal portal.** Design principles and twelve layers, with a persona scorecard and a list of what the ideal deliberately does not do.
Part 3	**Verified Nepal today.** A layer-by-layer alignment audit with file and live-site evidence, a screenshot gallery, quick wins and legal notes.
Appendix A	**Council verdict.** Where five independent advisors agreed, clashed and caught blind spots.

Reference numbers in square brackets are local to each part: Part 1 has 165 references and Part 2 has its own list. Part 3 cites repository files and live checks.



The short version

56%
of Nepalis are online, and growth has stalled

62%
use Facebook for news

3% / 8%
trust social media / online portals

0
published articles, stories or ledger rows on the live site, 14 October

The audience

About 16.6 million Nepalis are online. Facebook is the news layer for 62% of them, and for 82.6% of 16 to 24 year olds. Only 3% trust social media and 8% trust online portals. When something goes viral, people wait for a radio or TV bulletin to check it. PART 1

The open role

Facebook already owns discovery. The open seat is verification: fast, sourced, light enough for a mid-range Android on evening 4G, and honest about what is still unconfirmed. PARTS 1 AND 2

The ideal

A Nepali-first checked record: short items that are dated, placed down to the ward and linked to their source, with a permanent address, two clear status labels, and share cards built for Facebook, Viber and WhatsApp. Not a 101st news portal. PART 2

What Verified Nepal already has

A trust skeleton that is rarer than the gaps: no ads, no login to read, hotlines on every page, mandatory source lines, a public ledger, audit log and 3W export, a stated no-money principle, matching English and Nepali strings, and large touch targets. PART 3

Where it falls short

On 14 October the live site had no published articles, stories, projects, centres, incidents, ledger rows or audit entries. The home page is still built around the August 2026 flood and shows a six-week-old snapshot under a “Live” label. It is English by default, has no Bikram Sambat date, no RSS feed and no Viber share, and uses “verified” in five senses. PART 3

The one thing to do first

Replace the hard-wired August block on the home page with a dated, sourced “Now” strip, fed from what the site already ingests, one row per item with place, source link and relative time. APPENDIX A

Limits of the evidence. Reddit blocked the research environment, so the Reddit sample is nine threads taken from an archive. The ward-level relief hook rests on one Kathmandu Post report. No national media survey after September 2025 was found. Registration, advertising and legal points come from news reports and law-firm summaries, not official texts, and should be confirmed with the Department of Information and Broadcasting.

Contents

Part 1 Nepalis read on Facebook, trust the radio, and verify elsewhere 4

Half of Nepal is online, nearly all of it on a cheap Android in the evening 5

Platforms carry discovery; radio and TV still carry belief 6

Readers want Mukta at 17 px, a BS date, dark mode, search, and no GIF ads 8

Portals win by habit, Facebook and crisis spikes, and lose on ads 10

In disasters the first verified voice arrives late, and AI fills the gap 12

Nine personas, their pain points, and the questions they would ask 14

What the evidence cannot yet say 21

Conclusion 21

References 22

Part 2 What an ideal Nepali online public-information portal must look like 28

1. Executive summary 28

2. Design principles 29

3. The ideal, by layer 31

4. Persona scorecard 38

5. What the ideal deliberately does not do 39

6. Open questions and evidence gaps 40

7. References 41

Part 3 How far Verified Nepal's public site is aligned with the ideal Nepali public-information portal 45

1. Executive summary 45

2. Scorecard by layer 47

3. What is already right and should be protected 53

4. The reader's-eye walkthrough (360 px Android, first visit) 54

5. Persona-by-persona alignment 57

6. The council's recommended sequence, and where it differs from the owner's build order 57

7. Quick wins 59

8. Risks, legal notes and evidence caveats 61

9. Appendix 62

Appendix A Council verdict: the public side of Verified Nepal (2026-10-14) 65

Where the Council Agrees 65

Where the Council Clashes 66

Blind Spots the Council Caught 66

The Recommendation 67

The One Thing to Do First 68

Factual corrections to carry into the reports 68

PART 1 OF 3

Nepalis read on Facebook, trust the radio, and verify elsewhere

Research report, 14 October 2026. Synthesised from six research notes in `research_notes/Nepali online news audience/` (audience habits, Reddit/forum/app-review pain points, disaster and civic information-seeking, UI/UX conventions, portal traction and business models, publisher/journalist/moderator side). Citations are bracketed numbers that resolve to the reference list at the end; every number, quotation and named incident in this report carries one. Claims the notes could not source are omitted.

Nepal's online news audience in 2024-2026 is large, saturated, mobile, video-first and deeply distrustful of everything it reads online. About **16.6 million Nepalis (56%) are online and growth has stalled at +0.3% a year**, so reach now comes from deeper use, not new users [1]. **Facebook is the universal layer (62% use it for news; 82.6% of 16-24s call it their primary source), YouTube second (44.4%)**, and TikTok, Instagram and Discord carried the September 2025 Gen Z uprising while legacy outlets were being burned [8][17][20]. Yet only **3% trust social-media content and 8% trust online portals**, against roughly a third who trust TV, radio and print; the verification reflex when something goes viral is to wait for the radio or TV bulletin, not to open a portal [9][10][11]. The portals themselves win traffic by habit (69-83% "direct" desktop traffic), Facebook referrals and crisis spikes, and they monetise almost entirely through site-served banner ads that readers describe as "news between ads"; no paywall worked until Kantipur's diaspora-priced subscription of August 2026 [25][27][40][48]. In disasters the pattern repeats at higher stakes: the August 2026 Bhote Koshi flood saw the state alert arrive 38 minutes after the glacier collapse, a 7-million-view AI video fill the gap, families searching for the missing across police Facebook lists, hospital walls and a civil servant's overnight GitHub portal, and remote wards still hungry 24 days later while the CDO insisted relief "had already been sent" [61][82][90][93][97]. The opening for a new civic-information portal is therefore not discovery, which Facebook owns, but the verification role that radio and TV currently play: fast, provenance-stamped, light enough for a 4 GB Android on congested evening 4G, free of animated ads, and honest about what is still unconfirmed. The evidence base has real holes, flagged throughout: the Reddit sample is nine threads (Reddit blocked the research environment), there is no 2025/26 national media survey, no Reuters Institute chapter for Nepal, and no usability study of any Nepali portal.

Figure 1. Nepalis discover on Facebook and verify on radio and TV, so verification is the open seat



Parts 1 and 2. Shares of news use: Nepal Media Survey 2024; direct-traffic range: Similarweb; trust: Nepal Media Survey 2022.

Half of Nepal is online, nearly all of it on a cheap Android in the evening

Figure 2. **Nepal online in six numbers**

16.6M
internet users, 56% of the population, up only 0.3% in a year

75%
of phones run Android; budget models have 4 GB of memory

62%
use Facebook for news, rising to 82.6% of 16 to 24 year olds

44.9%
have Nepali as their mother tongue

69.4%
of women can read, against 83.6% of men

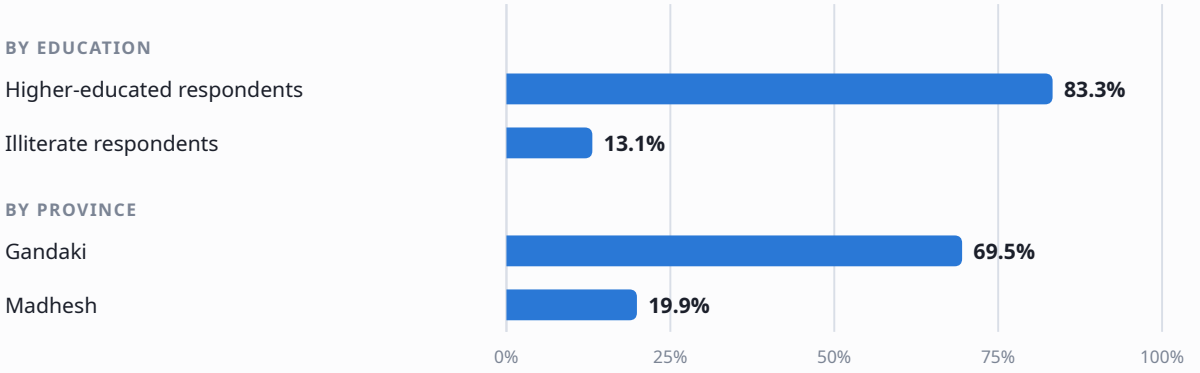
3.8M
Nepalis work abroad, 85% in Malaysia and the Gulf

DataReportal 2026, Nepal Media Survey 2024, 2021 census, Department of Foreign Employment figures. Part 1, references 1, 8, 14, 145 and 146.

The numbers that frame everything else are these. Nepal has **29.6 million people, median age 25.3**, and **16.6 million internet users (56.0%) as of October 2025**, up just 42,000 in a year, while **cellular connections run at 109% of population**; DataReportal warns that many of those connections are voice or SMS only [1]. The regulator's SIM-based figures (mobile broadband "93.85%" of population) therefore overstate real users by roughly 40 points, a gap NepaliTelecom attributes to multiple SIMs, eSIMs and home Wi-Fi [2]. The device base is **75% Android and 25% iOS**, with Android versions spread from 11 to 16 and only about a quarter on the newest release; Chrome holds ~80% of browsing and Safari ~14% [3][4][5]. The budget tier that sells at NPR 13,000-15,000 ships **4 GB of RAM** and HD+ screens, and the commonest viewports are **414×896 and 360×800** [6][7]. Data is cheap by volume (Ncell sells 1.1 GB for Rs 50, roughly Rs 45/GB) [81], so the constraint on page weight is congested hill-district 4G in the evening peak, not the per-gigabyte bill: ISP and exchange traffic peaks between 8 and 11 pm, NTA's peak-hour rule targets 6-10 pm, and the national exchange hit 109 Gbps around 10 pm on a 2026 World Cup night and fell below 50 Gbps by morning [149][150].

Who reads is as uneven as where. The 2021 census puts literacy at **76.2% (men 83.6%, women 69.4%)** and Nepali as mother tongue of only **44.9%**, with Maithili, Bhojpuri, Tharu and Tamang following [14]. The Nepal Media Survey 2024 shows the education gradient directly: **83.3% of higher-educated respondents consume news digitally against 13.1% of illiterate respondents**, and only **19.9% of Madhesh internet users read news on a device versus 69.5% in Gandaki** [8]. The online news reader who finishes a long Devanagari article is therefore an educated, urban, Bagmati/Gandaki/Koshi person; everyone else is reached by video, audio and Facebook, where use is near-identical in rural and urban Nepal (88.6% vs 87.5% in 2020) [12]. Romanized Nepali "prevails in Nepali online exchanges" according to NLP researchers who had to curate 6,500 such comments to train classifiers, and 84 of 108 urban TikTok users answered a survey in English when offered the choice, while a 2019 column already complained of "mangled Nepali" among millennials [15][16][162]. No survey quantifies what share of readers prefer Devanagari, Romanized Nepali or English for news; that is a gap, not a finding.

Figure 3. The online news reader is educated and urban; everyone else is reached by video and audio



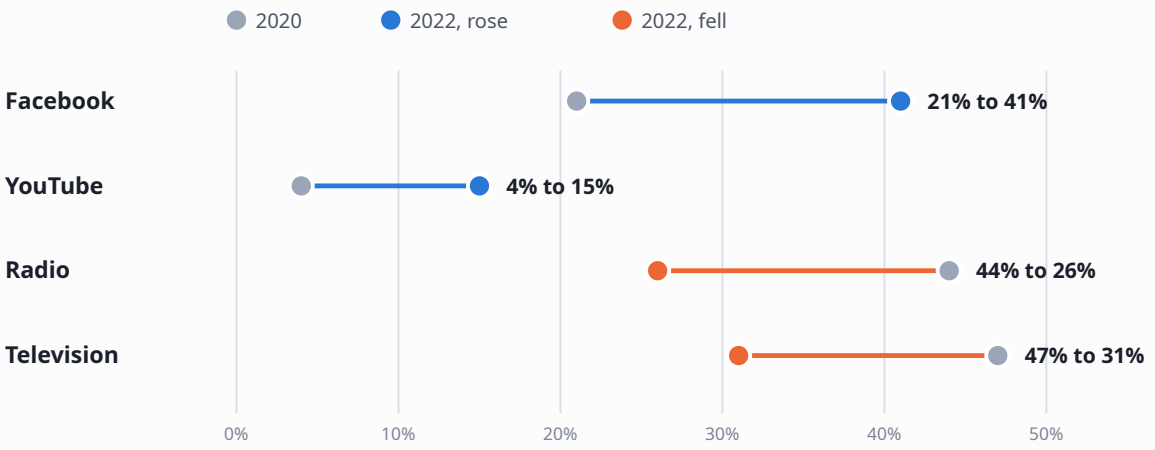
Share who consume news digitally (education) or read news on a device among internet users (province). Nepal Media Survey 2024. Part 1, reference 8.

Attention is also gendered and skewed. The Facebook audience is **56% male**, Instagram 60% male, X 83% male, against a 52.3% female population [1]; women are under-represented online in a country where one in three (2018) to one in two (later headline) households has a member working abroad [160]. The diaspora is large and remits more than the national budget, **Rs 2.36 trillion (~US$16.2B) in FY2025/26**, with ~3.8 million workers outside India, 85% of them in Malaysia and the Gulf [145][146]. Their media habits are known only from a 281-person MIDEQ survey in Malaysia (Facebook, Messenger, WhatsApp and YouTube are daily go-tos for over three quarters) and from embassy practice: the Nepal Embassy in Malaysia's weekly Facebook sessions draw "hundreds of thousands" of viewers [143][144]. Onlinekhabar's non-Nepal traffic comes chiefly from the United States and Australia, and Kantipur priced its first digital subscription for "the Gulf, US, UK and Australia" [24][40].

Platforms carry discovery; radio and TV still carry belief

Where Nepalis get news moved faster between 2020 and 2024 than in the previous decade. Facebook as primary source of local news went from **21% (2020) to 41% (2022)**, YouTube from 4% to 15%, while radio fell from 44% to 26% and TV from 47% to 31% [9]. By 2024 **62.0% used Facebook for news and 44.4% YouTube**; among 16-24s **82.6% rely on Facebook and 51.5% on YouTube** as primary sources, while over-60s split evenly between radio and TV; and when asked what "media" means, respondents named TV (21.5%), radio (20.6%), Facebook (19.9%) and YouTube (16.9%) in near-equal measure [8]. Two anomalies in that survey matter for product design: **Hamro Patro, a calendar app, is the "go-to" news source for 6.2%**, more than print (5.3%) or TikTok (1.4%), so a daily utility with a news tab outperforms dedicated news apps; and X is marginal (342,000 users, 83% male, shrinking 19% a year), useful for sourcing journalists but not for reaching the public [1][8].

Figure 4. Facebook doubled as the main source of local news in two years while radio and TV lost ground

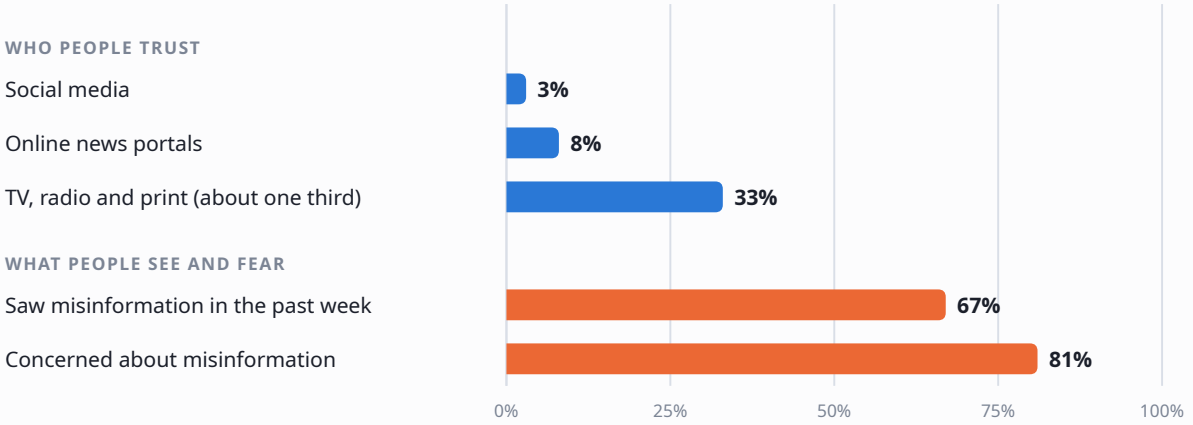


Share of people naming each as their main source of local news. Nepal Media Survey, 2020 and 2022 rounds. Part 1, reference 9.

The September 2025 crisis showed what the youth stack actually is. When the government blocked 26 unregistered platforms on 4 September 2025 (TikTok and Viber stayed up because they had registered), VPN downloads rose 8,000%, protests were organised on Instagram accounts and a Discord server with more than 160,000 members, a Facebook Live stream carried the Discord leadership debate, and legacy newsrooms "failed to decode" TikTok's political grammar [17][19][20]. On 9 September protesters torched Annapurna Post, stormed and partly burned Kantipur, and vandalised Nepal Television and Radio Nepal; the Kantipur and Kathmandu Post websites went down, cutting online news access nationally, while NTV's 8 pm bulletin stayed on air through a regional link [18][151]. Kantipur's editorial director later said Gen Z "mostly got news from Instagram, TikTok, YouTube, and a narrow set of online outlets", naming RONB and In-Depth Story as the social-native brands they trust, outlets that "are not full newsrooms and often rely on mainstream reporters or hearsay" [37]. The TikTok ban of November 2023 to August 2024 had already trained a minority to use VPNs; 13.9% of one sample kept using TikTok through the ban and 36.4% stopped [16][141]. Any distribution plan for Nepal must assume that Meta and Google can go dark for days while TikTok and Viber stay reachable; Nepal Telecom itself opened a Viber community for customer grievances during the block [142].

Trust runs in the opposite direction from use. The NMS rounds give **2% trust in social media (2020), 3% social media and 8% online portals (2022)**, and in 2018 under 2% for online information against about a third for TV and radio [11][12][160]. The survey authors are explicit that audiences "still relied on legacy media, mainly radio and TV news bulletins, to verify information" and that "radio listenership spikes during socio-political events and natural calamities" [10]. Press Council Nepal's own small 2020 survey found online media the top daily source (31.8%) yet trusted by only 13.1%, with more than 90% saying portals violated the code of conduct [23]. Exposure to falsehood is near-universal: **67% witnessed misinformation in the previous week and 81% are concerned (CMR Nepal 2024)**; 95.5% of internet users had been exposed in 2020 [22]. The 2024 survey adds a nuance a product team should hold onto: trust is highest among the educated (55.4%) and in Bagmati, 16-24s show the highest trust in digital platforms, and 45.2% of illiterate respondents are simply "uncertain" [8]. The audience that will adopt a new verified source first is young, urban and educated; the audience that most needs it is older, rural and reached by audio.

Figure 5. Almost nobody trusts what they read online, yet two thirds saw misinformation last week



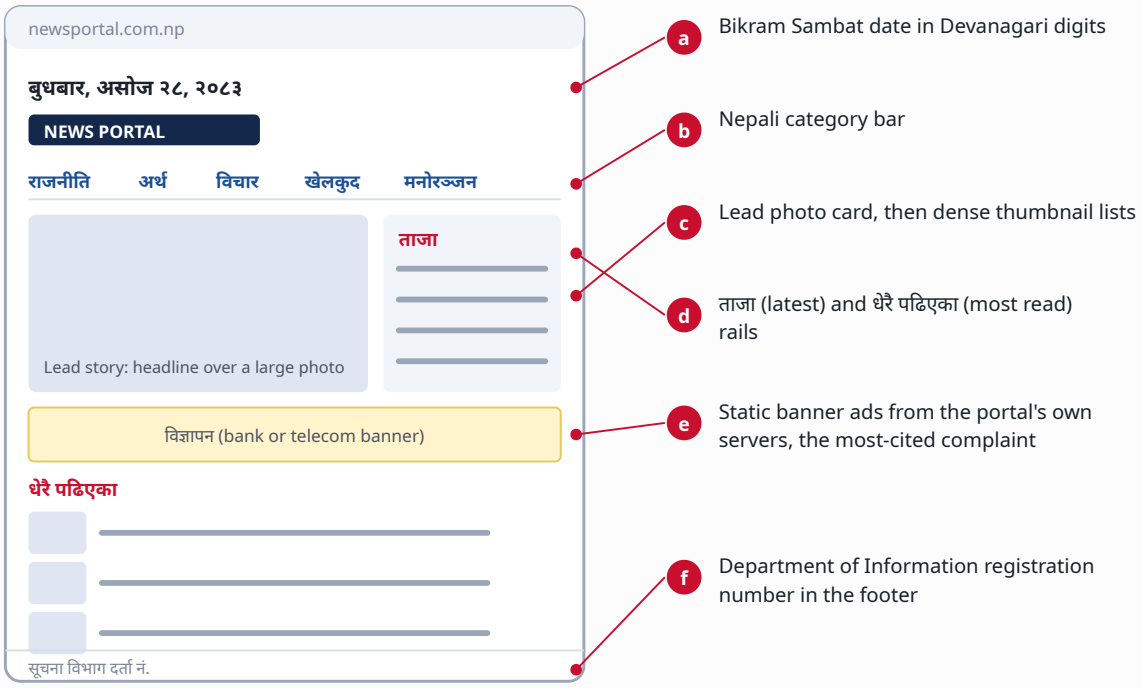
Trust: Nepal Media Survey 2022 (social media 3%, online portals 8%, legacy media about one third). Misinformation: CMR Nepal 2024. Part 1, references 11 and 22.

Consumption is event-driven. Onlinekhabar's estimated monthly visits went from **6.39 million in September 2025 (the protest month) to 3.27 million by November** [24], which fits a pattern in which people go to portals during crises and return to the Facebook feed as default. Attention peaks in the evening (86-91% of TV viewing; traffic peaks 8-11 pm) with a secondary 6-9 am radio-bulletin habit among older and rural listeners, 54% of whom tune in for two daily bulletins [13][149][160]. For the Gulf diaspora, which is 2h45m behind Nepal, the same evening publishing window lands in the late afternoon after shifts.

Readers want Mukta at 17 px, a BS date, dark mode, search, and no GIF ads

The visible grammar of a Nepali news site is stable across the three largest Nepali-language portals, measured live on 14 October 2026: a Bikram Sambat masthead in Devanagari digits (Setopati "बुधबार, असोज २८, २०८३"; eKantipur "२८ आश्विन २०८३, बुधबार"), a horizontal category bar (राजनीति, अर्थ, विचार, खेलकुद, मनोरञ्जन, फिचर, कभर स्टोरी, ब्लग), a lead image-card block followed by dense thumbnail lists, "ताजा"/"भर्खरैको खबर" and "धेरै पढिएका" rails, reporter bylines with "तस्बिर : ..." photo credits, Ncell and bank ad slots, a small "EN" link to a separate English property, and the Department of Information registration number in the footer (Setopati: "सूचना विभाग दर्ता नं: १४१७/०७६-२०७७") [68][69][70]. Onlinekhabar shows no absolute date at all and uses relative Nepali-digit times ("११ घण्टा अगाडि"); URLs and machine metadata stay Gregorian everywhere [70]. ICU has no Bikram Sambat calendar, so BS display needs a library, and `ne-NP` formatting defaults to Devanagari digits with lakh/crore grouping (१,२३,४५,६७८) and the नेरू currency symbol [69]. These are trust and familiarity cues as much as layout, and a civic site that omits the BS date or the registration footer will read as foreign to a Setopati reader.

Figure 6. What a typical Nepali news front page looks like (schematic)



Redrawn from live observation of Setopati, eKantipur and Onlinekhabar on 14 October 2026. Part 1, references 68 to 70.

Typography is the first thing that breaks on cheap phones. **Mukta is the de-facto house font** (Setopati loads weights 400 and 700; Ratopati loads six weights, roughly 370 KB of Devanagari woff2 before any Latin), eKantipur uses the serif Martel, and Onlinekhabar pairs Inter for Latin with an undeclared Devanagari face [68][69][70][71]. A single Devanagari weight costs **38-62 KB woff2** (Hind lightest, Mukta heaviest; Noto Sans Devanagari ~50 KB), so two weights plus Latin is a realistic 100-150 KB floor [67]. The one Nepali agency guide on the subject recommends **17-18 px body text at 1.7-1.8 line-height**, no letter-spacing inside words because it "breaks the shirorekha", sparing bold because heavy weights "look muddy on low-end phone screens", `font-display: swap`, and checking क्ष and ज्ञ first because conjuncts "break first when a font stack is faulty" [66]. The W3C Indic layout draft adds that a line must not begin with danda (।) and numeric strings like "10,000" must not break [72]. None of the served Google families carries a true Devanagari italic, so emphasis should use weight or colour rather than `<em>`. Legacy Preeti/Kantipur-encoded text is Latin ASCII that only looks Nepali with the font installed; it is invisible to search engines and screen readers and must be converted to Unicode before publication [66]. App reviews confirm the stakes: Onlinekhabar's app drew "news texts are awfully messed up and completely unreadable" (+45 helpful) and "some portion of the contents is truncated toward right side of the screen" (2024) [54].

Input and search have their own Nepali rules. Incumbents run English as a separate property rather than a per-article toggle, so a site that offers "EN"/"नेपाली" on the same item is unusual and should keep the reader on that item [68][69][70]. Hamro Patro's keyboard offers Unicode transliteration, an MPP Romanized layout and a traditional layout, and Romanized typing is the common path, so search must accept Romanized input and normalise Devanagari spelling variants (ि/ी, ु/ू, nukta, ligatured versus unligatured forms), because ICANN's Devanagari LGR group explicitly refused to define Nepali spelling norms as they "vary a great deal across the community" [73][74].

What readers complain about is remarkably consistent, with the caveat that the Reddit sample is nine threads, all about Onlinekhabar or ad-blocking, retrieved through an archive because Reddit blocked the research environment. **Ad load is the single most-recurring complaint**: four separate threads from 2020-2022 exist solely to find or build ad blockers for Nepali news sites ("this onlinekhabar, setopati, ratopati is pure ad rape"; "Its not ad between news but news between ads"), and users correctly diagnosed why uBlock fails: "most of the nepali websites use static banner ads instead of Ads network like Google Ads" served from the portal's own CDN, so on Ratopati blocking the ad host also blocks news images [46][47][48][49]. A cottage industry followed: a GitHub filter list targeting 19 portals, a "Swaccha" filter, and Chrome extensions built to strip "glittering gif ads" [49][53]. Google Play reviews add the cheap, explicit asks the market leader still has not met: **no dark mode** ("This app's developers need to get out of the cave", +23), **no search** ("y'all didn't add a 'search' tab?"), an app that lags the website by ten minutes and then lands users on the ad-laden web, forced Google/Facebook login that does not work, and a wrong Nepali calendar date [54]. Hamro Patro's 154,000 reviews are dominated by **ads delivered as push notifications** ("a serious misuse of the notification permission", +55), unskippable video ads that keep playing after the app is closed (+468), notification spam, and bloat that makes it "the only software installed in my mobile that doesn't respond often" (+104) [55]. Kantipur TV's app is panned because "live video never loads" while the channel's content is praised [56]. The one published Nepali news-portal UX case study (Koshionline, 2021) recorded the same themes from users: colours "too heavy on the eyes", flashy hover effects, "no distinct buttons for navigating", "too much information on a single page", and no clear category distinction, while the client asked for more ad space [57]. Raw HTML alone runs 128 KB (Setopati) to 234 KB (Onlinekhabar article) and 1.72 MB for the Hamro Patro homepage, so a 1-1.5 MB first load would be competitive with incumbents [80].

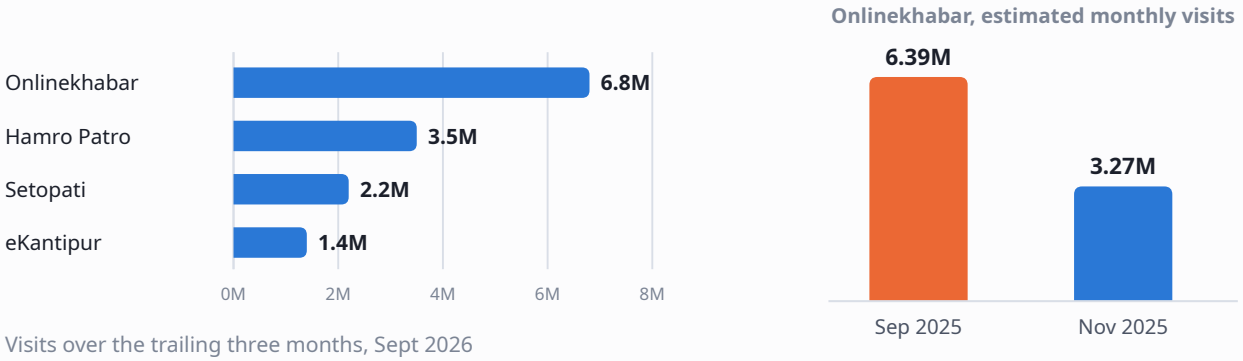
Accessibility is legislated and unpractised. Nepal's Disability Rights Act 2017 grants a right to information and the 2021 MoCIT directive requires responsive, disability-friendly government sites in Nepali Unicode "and, as far as possible, English" [78]; a 2026 audit of the DoIT portal against WCAG 2.2 AA found no skip links, mouse-only menus, PDF-only content and unlabelled forms, and eight health-ministry homepages averaged 30 WAVE errors and 23 contrast failures each [76][77]. Nepali screen-reader speech only became realistic with the open-source **Dina (दिना) voice launched by UNICEF and ATscale on 3 December 2024** for TalkBack and NVDA, so `lang="ne"` on Nepali content now has a practical payoff [75]. With a quarter of adults and 31% of women unable to read, audio versions, icon-plus-label controls and 44 px targets serve the low-literacy and older-reader segments at once [14][76]. Flag-derived crimson and blue are the documented "national" palette (NEPALPAY's brand guide draws them from the flag), and no Nepal-specific data exists on dark-mode demand, PWA installs or push opt-in rates [79]; `prefers-color-scheme` costs nothing and answers the most-repeated app review.

Portals win by habit, Facebook and crisis spikes, and lose on ads

The traffic hierarchy is clear and the gap between first and second is wide. Similarweb's September 2026 free tier ranks **onlinekhabar.com #7 in Nepal with 6.8 million visits in the trailing three months**, hamropatro.com #11 (3.5 million), setopati.com #21 (2.2 million) and ekantipur.com #46 (1.4 million); Ahrefs puts Onlinekhabar's organic search at ~500-600K monthly visits against ~58K for Setopati and ~47K for Ratopati [25][26][27][28][29]. Onlinekhabar's own About page claims 700,000 daily uniques and 2.5 million daily page views, unaudited [30]. The channel mix is the more useful signal: **69-83% of desktop visits to the three big news portals are "direct"**, organic search second, Facebook the dominant social

referrer, and "Paid Social" the third channel for Setopati and eKantipur, which implies both buy Facebook boosts [25][27][28]. Hamro Patro's web property is the exception at 49% organic search, because dates, horoscopes and forex rank for evergreen Nepali queries while news does not [26]. Dwell times of 1:26 to 3:47 and 2-3 pages per visit say portals are consumed as a homepage-refresh habit rather than through deep search [25][28]. A realistic yardstick follows: a mid-tier portal does roughly 0.7 million visits a month, the leader ~2.3 million, and a civic site at 50-100K monthly visits would already be a visible niche player.

Figure 7. A handful of portals dominate, and traffic doubles in a crisis month



Visits over the trailing three months, Sept 2026

Similarweb free-tier estimates. Between 69% and 83% of desktop visits to the three big news portals arrive as 'direct', not from search or social. Part 1, references 24 to 28.

The two case studies the notes could document in depth show how traction is built from a utility, not from news. **Routine of Nepal Banda** started in 2011 as a student's Facebook page posting banda, load-shedding and traffic notices, grew to 2.3 million Facebook likes, 978K Instagram and 196K Twitter followers by April 2021 (Nepal's most-followed page) and to a reported 9.5 million followers across platforms by 2026, on a formula of 6-7 line posts in simple Nepali or Roman Nepali, volunteer citizen-sourcing, verification "via local authorities, residents and other outlets", and advertising from films and events [33][35]. Readers describe the result in trust terms: news is "kind of 'confirmed'" once RONB posts it; "For the past ten years, I have associated Routine of Nepal Banda with factual news" (an engineering student in the UAE); admins writing in Roman Nepali make users "feel they are receiving information from someone who is like their friend" [33][34][36]. The criticism is equally specific: "the practice of critically examining and verifying information appears extremely weak", paid posts are hard to tell from organic ones, sources go uncredited, and a 2026 academic warned that "incomplete information presented without context is, in a way, a form of misinformation" [35]. RONB's own app had only ~10,000 downloads in 2020; its moat is brand, habit and brevity, not reporting, and being a Facebook page first made it hostage to the September 2025 block.

Hamro Patro is the other model: a calendar launched on iOS in 2010 that by June 2022 had **1.7 million daily and 11 million monthly active users and more than 10 million downloads**, and whose remittance feature passed Rs 100 million in a single month about seven months after launch [31]. It relaunched zero-fee US remittance inside the app in October 2025, with Japan, South Korea and Australia to follow, and is the only Nepali information brand monetising transactions rather than ads [32]. The lesson for a civic portal is that a small thing Nepalis check daily (dates, alerts, a status board) is the proven habit hook in this market, and the diaspora is the segment that pays.

The business model underneath is in crisis. Freedom Forum's report on 2023 counted **100 media outlets closed and 243 journalists quitting** in a year of advertising slump [39]. Platform payouts now rival independent portals' income: Nepal Rastra Bank recorded **Rs 3.53 billion (~US$23 million) flowing to Nepal from digital platforms in FY2024-25, 67% of it from Google/YouTube**, Meta launched view-based monetisation in Nepal in September 2025, and a ten-person YouTube commentary team earns Rs 300-400K a month against ~Rs 350K costs, with CPM for a viewer in Jumla around Rs 50 against far more for one in London [38]. On the publisher side, April 2026 reporting found journalists at Avenues TV, Ukaalo, Nagarik, Kantipur, Rajdhani and Annapurna owed two to twelve months' pay, Kantipur Media Group's revenue down 70% over a decade, and the Prime Minister's Office directing all official advertising exclusively to state media on 2 April 2026 (a "one-door" policy the Supreme Court struck down in July) [42] [44]. Government "public welfare" advertising now also requires listing and annual renewal with the Advertisement Board, which grades digital media by "number of viewers and readers" [43]. Paywalls have no track record: as of December 2022 "none has so far put up a paywall", the ad-free, membership-funded The Record went on indefinite hiatus in July 2022 for financial reasons, and Kantipur's August 2026 "Kantipur One" is the first digital subscription in its history, justified because "advertising alone can no longer carry the weight" [40][41][45]. Press Council Nepal's journal confirms that "conventional static banner ads dominate" as the revenue model, which is precisely the format readers build extensions to remove [165]. There are now **5,126 registered online outlets** competing for that money, up from 2,325 in early 2021, and the growth "has led to more violations of journalistic ethics" [147][148].

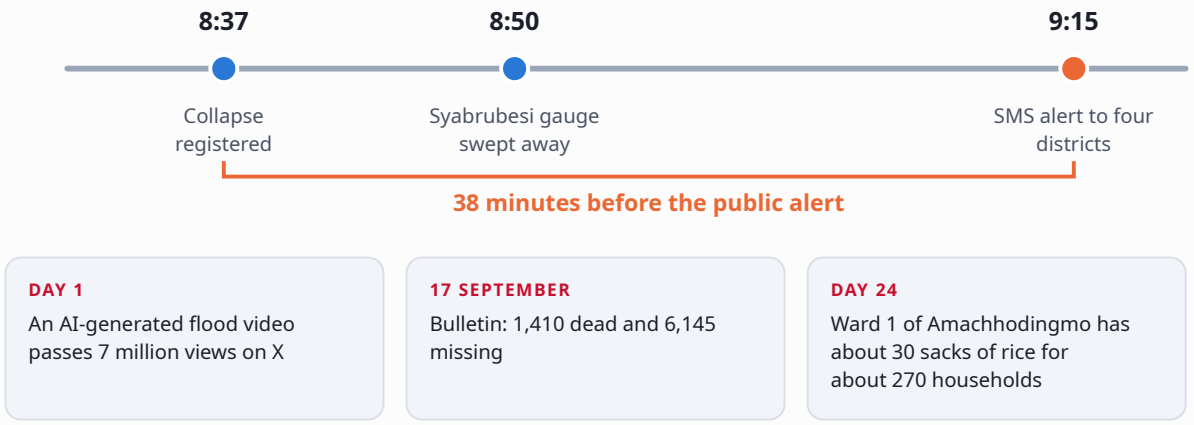
In disasters the first verified voice arrives late, and AI fills the gap

Five events between 2015 and 2026 trace a consistent arc. In 2015 rumours of a "NASA-predicted magnitude 8" quake moved by word of mouth and were countered by Open Mic Nepal's 400 journalists and 18 community radios texting in rumours for verification [157]. In 2021 Radio Melamchi relayed a flood warning "as soon as a government official informed us", saving lives in the town while a resident downstream said "we neither received any early warning nor had any idea how to respond" [154]. In September 2024 the heaviest rain since 1970 killed at least 226 despite DHM advisories and nearly a million warning SMS, a Kathmandu resident reported "we didn't even get a warning... not even from the ward office", and WMO's review demanded "understandable, actionable impact-based early warnings that reach the most vulnerable" [111][153]. By October 2025 DHM could push **5 million flood SMS in a single day** [152].

The 26 August 2026 Bhote Koshi glacier-collapse flood is the best-documented case and the most damning. The collapse registered at 8:37; the Department of Mines and Geology "did not alert the public like we usually do"; the Syabrubesi gauge was swept away at 8:50; and the SMS alert to four districts went out at **9:15, 38 minutes after the event**, by which time the water was inside Nepal. The former NDRRMA chief's verdict: "There is no such thing as an early warning system in Nepal... It comes down to the subjective judgement of individuals in authority" [82]. RSF tied the "unconfirmed death tolls and contradictory information" on social media directly to "the initial delay in official crisis communications", with at least nine media offices hit and radio stations off air from power cuts [83]. Into that gap flowed an **AI-generated flood video with more than 7 million views on X** (Hive Moderation: 97.2% AI-likely), a Facebook page named "Dudhauli FM" captioning Uttarakhand rescue footage as the Home Minister in a tunnel, Alaska glacier footage labelled Rasuwa, fabricated before-and-after photos, and a Vietnamese clip, all debunked by Nepal Fact Check, Newschecker Nepal, AAP, BBC Verify and BOOM rather than by

government [61][84][88]. The rumour repertoire is stable from 2015 to 2026: a bigger disaster coming, relief hoarded or diverted (Nepal Police called the 2026 version "false and baseless"), recycled footage, inflated death tolls [85]. Police logged 173 pieces of rumour content, 168 of them on Facebook, and arrested a 24-year-old over Reels; Press Council Nepal opened a special complaints portal that received 101 complaints by the Saturday, 67 of them about personal accounts posting gruesome scenes, and ordered more than 100 accounts to take content down [61][86][87]. The official figures themselves moved bulletin by bulletin (359 dead/910 missing on 27 August; 626/2,400 on 29 August; 1,410/6,145 by 17 September), which is why "as of bulletin N" matters more than any single number [61][92].

Figure 8. On 26 August 2026 the public alert arrived 38 minutes after the glacier collapse



Times are 26 August 2026, Nepal time. Death and missing figures carry the date of the bulletin they come from. Part 1, references 61, 82, 88 and 97.

Finding the missing was multi-channel and duplicative by default. Nepal Police posted lists of names, dates of birth and nationality on Facebook and a QR code linking to a gallery of unidentified bodies; families pinned photos along a 25-metre "wall of the missing" outside TU Teaching Hospital and watched "grisly images of mangled corpses on a screen" at Bharatpur; Nepal Red Cross registered 116 tracing requests through its hotline and social media; district police published phone numbers; and a volunteer wrote that "there was no centralized database of people reported missing" [89][90][91][92][94]. A Ministry of Finance IT officer, Niraj Bhusal, built overnight a portal pulling NDRRMA, Police, Army, DAO and Copernicus data with a Google Form for missing-person reports cross-referenced against rescue lists; "a few days after Bhusal's bulletin went live, the government launched its own" [93]. Quakemap.org in 2015 offers the only verification benchmarks: **2,035 reports, 978 verified (48%), 551 requiring action, 309 fully closed**, and Kathmandu Living Labs' lesson that pre-disaster mapping and an on-the-ground coordinating organisation were decisive [95][96].

Relief matching failed geographically rather than through duplication. In Jajarkot (2023) relief went "only in the settlements closer to the roads" and renters "initially considered eligible were later excluded" [99]; in Saptari (2024) a ward chair returned UNICEF's Rs 6.87 million rather than "single out 457 families" from 1,470 affected [98]; in Rasuwa (2026), 24 days on, ward 1 of Amachhodingmo had received ~30 sacks of rice for ~270 households, the ward 2 chair was told by the CDO that relief "had already been sent" when nothing had arrived, and the CDO then stopped answering calls [97]. Fraud appeared within 48 hours: fake "Prime Minister's Disaster Relief Fund" QR codes copying official logos, fake pages on Facebook, WhatsApp, TikTok, Instagram and Viber, OTP phishing and "I'm safe but need money" messages; Nepal

Rastra Bank told donors the account details exist only on NRB, OPMCM and MoF sites and never to scan QR codes received through messaging apps [100][101]. Donors complied: more than 25 UK diaspora organisations deposited mostly into the PM fund, NRNA chapters routed GoFundMe proceeds there, and one organiser admitted "it is hard to know exactly how much has reached Nepal" [103][104], this despite the 2015 PM-fund episode being "a public relations disaster" in which ministries would not disclose spending [102]. The domestic critique landed on the same point: publish "ward-level damage and relief lists" [109].

The state's own platforms are institution-facing. BIPAD is the official disaster information system, now what TikTok's monsoon banner points users to, but assessments cite unclear indicator terminology, missing metadata and inconsistent data, and "not all municipal staff at grassroots levels are aware of the portal" [105][106][107]. NDRRMA's Facebook page functioned as the de facto bulletin board, and the citizen-built Nagarik Alert already claims to supply ward-tagged "verified data to government and non-government organizations" [108]. Trust markers that evidently work are provenance (link to the original upload or bulletin with timestamp), institutional domain (gov.np, verified account) and named local officials; logos and official formats are actively forged and therefore weak on their own [61][100]. Climate-compensation framing ("loss and damage") is embraced by officials and the diaspora and "widely appreciated at home", but only 49% of households had heard of climate change in 2016 and critics warn the fund risks becoming "rhetorical cover" for warning and zoning failures [109][110].

Nine personas, their pain points, and the questions they would ask

Each persona below is drawn from the evidence above. The pain points are those the notes could source; where the only evidence is thin (the diaspora, ward officials) that is said. Each section closes with the open questions that person would put to a new civic-information portal before trusting or using it.

Figure 9. Nine personas, and the first question each would ask a new civic-information portal

News consumer 1 “Who is behind this, who pays for it, and where is the registration number?”	**Diaspora reader** 2 “Can I read a summary in Nepali or Roman Nepali, and the English of the same item?”	**Disaster-affected person** 3 “Is my relative on any list, which is the latest, and whom do I call?”
Volunteer or donor 4 “Which bank account is the real one?”	**NGO or local government** 5 “Does your data map to BIPAD's fields or will we re-key everything?”	**Publisher or maintainer** 6 “Are you 'online journalism' under the 2017 Directive and 2025 Rules?”
Journalist or correspondent 7 “Will I be paid on time, through a bank, and get a press card?”	**Moderator or fact-checker** 8 “What is the checklist for a user-submitted item?”	**Advertiser or regulator** 9 “What are your audited visitors, and the Nepal versus diaspora split?”

First question from each persona section below; the full lists follow each persona.

1. News consumer in Nepal

The typical reader is on a 4 GB Android over Chrome, most active between 6 and 11 pm, and arrives from Facebook, a push notification or a link a friend pasted into Messenger: of regular portal visitors in 2022, **48% were prompted by push notifications and 57% followed links shared by friends** [11]. Their pain is first visual and mechanical: pages where "half of the page needs to be covered in ads", GIF banners that normal blockers cannot remove, a desktop that "almost freezes" fifteen seconds after opening the leader's homepage, apps without dark mode or search, forced logins, and Nepali text that renders as garbage or truncates on the right [46][51][54]. Their second pain is editorial. Clickbait in Nepal means headline-body incongruity, documented academically ("catchy headlines which, in most of the cases, appears significantly different from the actual content") and in reviews ("news with opposite heading and content, commented about it and got blocked") [54][58]. Copy-paste is "widespread" by a Kantipur editor's own admission and readers notice content "one-two days old" [48][137]. Political ownership, the "12 bhai" cartel charge and "झोले मिडिया" (bag-carrier media) are the most emotionally charged complaints, but the Reddit evidence shows them to be partisan-contested (the sharpest anti-Onlinekhabar comment sat at -11) and better read as "I don't trust any single portal", in one user's words "sabai news portal ko news heavily biased... Idk what to believe" [50]. Coverage is Kathmandu-centric and politics-fixated: **only 38.5% think the media cares about their needs**, and the 2024 survey's own recommendation is "more inclusive, localised content and grassroots storytelling" [8]. What they praise is the mirror image: RONB's speed, brevity and friend-like Roman Nepali voice, Hamro Patro's "everything useful for our daily life" bundle, a well-written Onlinekhabar long-read, and the outlets with the lowest misleading-news rates in the one quantitative study (Himalayan Times 0.05%, Onlinekhabar 0.10%, Kathmandu Post 0.15%, Setopati and Kantipur 0.45%) [33][55][59]. Evidence gap: no retrievable "which Nepali source do you trust" thread, no Lighthouse audit of any portal, no study of Devanagari-versus-Romanized reading preference.

Questions this reader would ask a new portal: 1. Who is behind this, who pays for it, and which party or business owns it? Where is the DoI registration number and the editor's name? 2. Is this verified or just fast? When I see a figure, is it from NDRRMA, the police, or a reporter, and as of when? 3. Will it load on my phone on a bad evening connection, without animated ads, and can I read it at night in dark mode? 4. Can I search it, in Romanized Nepali as well as Devanagari, and does the headline actually match the story? 5. Does it cover my district and my palika, or only Kathmandu politics? 6. Will it still be reachable if Facebook and YouTube are blocked again, and will it push me notifications that are news rather than ads? 7. If I leave a critical comment, will it be published or will I be blocked?

2. Diaspora reader

Roughly 3.8 million Nepalis work outside India, 85% in Malaysia and the Gulf, remitting more than the national budget, and a second, English-leaning and desktop-leaning diaspora in the United States, Australia and the United Kingdom accounts for most of Onlinekhabar's non-Nepal traffic [24][145][146]. Their documented habits are Facebook (including embassy Facebook sessions watched by "hundreds of thousands"), Messenger, IMO and WhatsApp calls, and YouTube, used on cheap data after shifts, 2h45m behind Nepal time in the Gulf [143][144]. Their documented failure mode is being deceived by YouTube "news" channels they cannot cross-check: a 25-year-old in Dubai believed a Trishuli Khabar TV video that the president's convoy had killed someone until friends in Nepal told her no outlet had reported it; "misleading thumbnails have become commonplace among Nepali language channels on YouTube" [60]. They prefer "easy-to-digest snippets", which is why a UAE student trusts RONB, and they are the paying segment: Kantipur's digital-only tier is explicitly for them and Hamro Patro's remittance runs on them [31]

[36][40]. During disasters they are also the donors who route money to the PM fund by default and cannot see where it went (see persona 4). Evidence gap: no survey of Gulf workers' news habits, no complaints found about geo-blocking, time zones or missing English summaries; the Kantipur subscription's price and uptake are unknown.

Questions this reader would ask: 1. Can I read a one-paragraph summary in Nepali or Roman Nepali, and an English version of the same item without being bounced to a different site? 2. Is this video or claim real? Can I send it to you to check, and will you tell me where the original came from? 3. Is my home district or village mentioned, and can I follow just that place? 4. Does the live stream actually work from abroad, and does the page load on Gulf mobile data? 5. If I give money, which account is real, and will I ever see what arrived in the ward? 6. Can I get a daily digest at a time that suits my shift rather than Nepal's evening peak?

3. Disaster-affected person

In Rasuwa in 2026 the affected person had no power for five days until the Red Cross restored a generator so 150 people could charge phones ("We finally got the opportunity to connect with our family members"), roads and towers were destroyed so warnings came door-to-door, and 3,702 households were cut off for up to six days [92]. Their information needs are concrete and official: safe locations, hospital lists, relief centres, hotlines, whether a specific person has been found. Families searched the police Facebook list, the QR-linked gallery of unidentified bodies, hospital walls and LED screens of corpses, and gave DNA at Nepal Police Hospital [89][90][91]. The harms they suffered online were graphic: 67 of 101 Press Council complaints concerned personal accounts posting gruesome scenes without warnings, a woman pleading for her missing husband drew "cruel and mocking comments", and "trapped person" videos kept circulating after the person was rescued [61]. Relief visibility was the second wound: ward chairs could not prove to the CDO that nothing had arrived, renters were struck from eligibility lists, and remote wards waited weeks while roadside settlements were served [97][99]. Early warning reached them after the water or not at all [82][111]. Evidence gap: no Nepali source discusses consent or privacy around publishing names and photos of the missing or dead, in 2015 or 2026, and no data exists on how many people acted on the SMS alerts.

Questions this person would ask: 1. Is my relative on any list, and which list: police, hospital, Red Cross? Which is the latest, and whom do I call? 2. Can I report someone missing from a phone with one bar of signal, and will the entry be removed when they are found? 3. Will you show my family member's face or body? Who gave permission? 4. Where is the nearest relief centre and hospital today, and is the road open? 5. Our ward got 30 sacks of rice for 270 households. Does anyone outside our ward know that? 6. Can I get this by SMS, voice or radio when the data network is down? 7. Will the people mocking us in comments be able to do it here?

4. Volunteer, donor and mutual-aid organiser

Volunteers in 2026 fell back on social-media calls for details because "there was no centralized database of people reported missing", and the first integrated dashboard was one civil servant's GitHub project that consolidated NDRRMA, Police, Army and DAO data because nobody else had [93][94]. Donors, domestic and diaspora, received official instructions within 48 hours to trust only PMO/NRB/MoF-listed accounts and never a QR code from a messaging app, because scammers "copy the logos, names, or formats of official government agencies" [100][101]. They then gave to the PM Disaster Relief Fund despite its 2015 record ("a public relations disaster", undisclosed ministry spending), because it was the only vouched

channel, and admitted they could not tell how much had reached Nepal [102][103]. Every INGO duplicated situation reporting with its own PDF sitrep, and the volunteer-verification benchmark from 2015 remains Quakemap's 48% verified and 56% closed [95]. Volunteer burnout is documented only indirectly, through community-radio dormancy and the finding that 45% of community-media personnel were volunteers [136]. Evidence gap: no survey of Nepali or diaspora donors' trust criteria; duplication of relief to the same household is asserted but never measured; no eSewa/Khalti-specific scam reports.

Questions this person would ask: 1. Which bank account is the real one, and can you link me to the NRB/OPMCM listing rather than showing me a QR code? 2. What arrived where? Can I see a ward-level ledger of needs, deliveries and gaps with a date and a source? 3. If I report a need or a missing person, who verifies it, how long does it take, and what happens to unverified entries? 4. Can my organisation export district, municipality and ward counts, disaggregated by sex and age, in the format our sitreps already use? 5. How do you prevent the same household being counted or served twice, and how do you handle eligibility disputes like renters? 6. Will my volunteers' names and phone numbers be public, and what happens if they are harassed?

5. NGO, INGO and local-government user

The NGO user already works with district, municipality and ward filters, household counts disaggregated by sex and age (NRCS Update 5: 3,702 households; 7,453 male, 7,008 female; 3,650 children; 1,204 elderly), holding-centre counts and bridges destroyed, and tracks need versus distribution the way DPNet tracked 62,012 tarpaulins needed against 41,256 delivered in Jajarkot [92][99]. Coordination runs through CDO/DAO to ward chairs to security forces and clusters, with Parliament criticising army-first, local-government-second response in 2026 [158]. The ward chair is the most motivated local user, because in 2026 ward chairs publicly contested CDO claims and demanded ward-level visibility, and the Annapurna Express called on municipalities to "publish ward-level damage and relief lists" [97][109]. Municipal capacity is the binding constraint: only **54 of 753 local levels** answered Freedom Forum's RTI requests, 147 local representatives, staff, teachers and security personnel themselves went missing in the flood, BIPAD data entry is uneven and grassroots staff often do not know the portal exists [106][132][159]. The state increasingly treats Facebook as an official channel (Hello Sarkar takes complaints by Facebook, X, Viber and WhatsApp) and the one third-party precedent, Nagarik Alert, claims palikas already consume its ward-tagged citizen reports [108][156]. Evidence gap: no interview or survey evidence on ward or municipal officials' willingness to use a third-party platform; no 2026 3W matrix retrieved; no study of palika Facebook pages.

Questions this user would ask: 1. Does your data map to BIPAD's indicators and our cluster sitrep fields, or will we re-key everything? 2. Can a ward chair log "received X, need Y for Z households" from a phone and have it stand as a public record against the CDO's claim? 3. Who owns the data, where is it hosted, and can government and NGOs pull it by API or CSV? 4. How do you reconcile your counts with NDRRMA's provisional bulletins when those change daily? 5. What happens when our palika staff have only Facebook-level skills and one shared phone? 6. Will publishing recipient lists create fairness disputes, and do you publish criteria and counts rather than names?

6. Online-portal publisher and maintainer

Running a portal in Nepal means operating inside a registration regime that moved three times in 2025. Online journalism must register with the Department of Information and Broadcasting; the November 2025 amended Press and Publication Rules set **Rs 5,000 to register and Rs 2,500 a year to renew**, require a company or firm with PAN/VAT, an editor plus at least three employees paid through a bank,

display of the registration number, addresses, editor and journalist names and a privacy policy on the site, and prompt public correction of errors, with a late-renewal surcharge rising to 200% and then cancellation; **5,135 outlets** were registered [116][163]. Press bodies called the fees "double payment" and a barrier to small and alternative outlets [116]. Registration is also the gate to public-welfare advertising, which now additionally requires Advertisement Board listing, and brings the Working Journalists Act minimum wage (last confirmed at **NPR 24,600 a month**, a 2023 proposal to raise it to NPR 34,125 unconfirmed) that the sector openly fails to pay [42][43][135]. Revenue is direct-sold static banners to banks and telcos, the format readers hate; paywalls have no precedent before August 2026; and the one ad-free membership site closed [40][41][165]. The operator is legally responsible for user comments and "must prevent vulgar, dishonest or irrelevant comments", and the Sidhakura contempt ruling jailed a publisher and editor for three months for republishing audio "without fulfilling a minimum responsibility of the media to verify the content's authenticity" even though they had not created it [117][121]. The attack surface is the CMS: Ukeraa's content management system was breached in December 2024 and investigative stories were deleted and replaced, with the editor republishing from archived links [133]. Distribution dependence is structural: Nepali publishers "did not think about establishing themselves as a destination", and Meta and Google went dark for five days in September 2025 [19][134]. The cost side is people, not infrastructure: a 7-10 person digital team runs on Rs 350-500K a month [38]. Evidence gap: no source on any Nepali portal's hosting, CDN or Cloudflare use, DDoS history, Facebook reach throttling, or comment-moderation practice; no official DoIB fee page was located.

Questions this publisher would ask: 1. Are you "online journalism" under the 2017 Directive and 2025 Rules, and if so how do you meet the editor-plus-three-staff and bank-salary requirements as a volunteer operation? 2. What will you display: registration number, editor, addresses, privacy policy, corrections log? 3. How do you make money without site-served GIF banners, and does the diaspora pay? 4. What is your plan for the next platform block: Viber, TikTok, SMS, email, your own domain? 5. Who is liable for a user-submitted missing-person entry or comment that turns out to be false or defamatory, and do you pre-moderate? 6. How are your CMS and admin accounts protected, and can you republish from backup if content is deleted? 7. Will you take Advertisement Board or government money, and what does that do to your independence?

7. Journalist and local correspondent

The reporter outside Kathmandu is the least paid and most exposed node in the system. In 2013 district stringers already reported months of delayed salaries, being told to sell ads or collect debts, partial contracts across several outlets to dodge the minimum wage, and threats from timber smugglers [164]. In April 2026 journalists across major houses were owed two to twelve months' pay and FNJ's professional-insecurity complaints had risen from 11 (2023) to 18 (2025) [42]. Freedom Forum's 2026 report counted **97 violations against 145 media persons, more than half of them working for online portals**, with political leaders, cadres and public officials as the main perpetrators, 35 intimidation cases tied to government coverage and 31 threats tied to corruption reporting [126]. Calendar 2025 was the worst year in five: 114 violations, 139 media persons affected, 68 of them online journalists, 22 media houses attacked, four journalists hit by rubber bullets or gunfire on 8 September, a Kantipur reporter told to remove the company logo from his microphone while evacuating [127][130][131]. Legal exposure is Section 47 of the Electronic Transactions Act (up to five years and a fine for content "contrary to public morality or decent behaviour"), used to arrest two Kanchanpur journalists in February 2024 and to issue warrants against Dil Bhusan Pathak (2025) and Basudev Dhami (2026) after complaints from political families and a

municipal official; a former Rajdhani editor was sentenced to four months for criminal defamation in July 2026 [118][119][120][122]. Information access is poor: only 54 of 753 local levels answered RTI requests and local coverage is "event-based or reliant on official remarks" [132]. Online harassment is pervasive and gendered: about seven in ten of 100 surveyed journalists faced it in 2022, "no action was taken in most digital threat cases", and **29 women journalists left the profession between 2023 and 2024** amid doxxing and threats of sexual violence with "no dedicated response mechanisms" [118][128][129]. Evidence gap: no 2022-2026 survey of stringer pay; no data on citizen-journalism programmes in the period.

Questions this journalist would ask: 1. Will I be paid, on time, through a bank, and will you register me so I can hold a press card? 2. If a local official files a Section 47 complaint over something I file here, who stands behind me legally? 3. Can my byline be a pseudonym where the law allows, and will my phone number and face stay off the page? 4. How do you handle doxxing and threats against your contributors, especially women, when neither the newsroom nor the state has a mechanism? 5. Will you credit my reporting and photos ("तस्बिर :"), or will it be copy-pasted without attribution like everything else? 6. Can I file from a feature phone or by voice when the data network is down in my district? 7. During unrest, will I be identifiable as yours in the field?

8. Moderator and fact-checker

Nepal's fact-checking capacity is two small organisations and donor money. South Asia Check (2015) is the country's only verified IFCN signatory and published **27 fact-checks in 2021**; NepalFactCheck.org (CMR-Nepal and MySansar, April 2020) debunked 5 claims in two days of the September 2025 protests and 60 in the 30 days before the March 2026 election, and said plainly that "with limited resources... it was impossible to fact-check all potential misinformation", so it prioritised content likely to incite violence [21][65][140]. Nepali media "have not invested in fact-checking units" and sustainability is "a big question" [139]. The recurring patterns are catalogued: foreign or old footage misattributed to Nepal, exaggerated casualties, miscontextualised security activity, religious and political falsehoods, and increasingly AI video, with even the National News Agency and a Facebook page named after a local FM station republishing fakes [21][61]. The methods that carried weight were locating the original upload, AI-detection scores, community notes and cross-checks with BBC Verify and AAP [61]. Press Council Nepal's 2083 disaster guidelines (4 September 2026) codify the verification minimum, source, location, time, context and independent evidence before republishing social-media material, ban faces of the dead and gruesome thumbnails or autoplay previews, require AI symbolic images to be labelled "एआईद्वारा सिर्जित सांकेतिक दृश्य", and require immediate correction with an explanation [113]. Moderation workload in a crisis is heavy and state-adjacent: PCN reviewed 207 items and ordered 59 removals in one July 2026 incident, the Cyber Bureau formed a ten-member team to profile abusive commenters after the flood even without complaints, and 163 complaints reached PCN in six months [62][115][138]. The regulator's own legitimacy is contested: Nepal Check's editor said PCN "seems to target outlets seen as opposed to the government", Freedom Forum calls its social-media monitoring "beyond its jurisdiction", and PCN blacklisted four outlets in late 2024 for publishing without fact-checking [63][64][155]. No Nepali-language hate-speech classifier was identified; moderation is manual. Evidence gap: no study of correction practices at Nepali portals; South Asia Check and AFP Nepal outputs were not surfaced.

Questions this moderator would ask: 1. What is the verification checklist for a user-submitted item, and does it match PCN's five points plus reverse image search? 2. How many items a day do you expect, and what is the queue when a flood produces 7-million-view fakes within 24 hours? 3. Where does the public corrections log live, and is every change dated and explained? 4. How do you label "unconfirmed", "official

provisional", "verified" and "AI-generated", in Nepali, so readers can tell them apart? 5. What is the policy on faces of the dead, children, graphic images and consent, and who enforces it at 2 am? 6. Can I pre-moderate comments or turn them off, given the operator is liable for them? 7. Will you refuse politically motivated takedown requests, and on what documented basis? 8. Do you have Nepali-language tooling, or is it all human review?

9. Advertiser and regulator

The advertiser's market is small, direct-sold and migrating to platforms: the only hard turnover figure is from 2010/11, Freedom Forum recorded a 2023 ad slump that closed 100 outlets, and Rs 3.53 billion a year now flows from Google, YouTube and Meta to Nepali creators, with brands such as Ncell and Daraz running influencer programmes and Dashain campaigns [38][39]. On portals the buyer pays the site directly for static or GIF banners, which is why they cannot be blocked and why readers resent them, and why a 2022 case study client wanted a redesign to have "sufficient ad space" [47][57]. The Advertisement Board grades digital media "by number of viewers and readers" on self-submitted rates, and no Nepali portal publishes audited uniques, only self-reported daily figures and Similarweb ranks [30][43]. Readers mock contradictions (an alcohol GIF inside an article on the harms of alcohol, 57 upvotes) and RONB is criticised because "it is hard to tell paid posts from organic ones" [35][52].

The regulator's levers are registration, the Press Council code, the Advertisement Board list, Section 47 and the courts. The Social Media Bill of 2025 (up to five years' prison for content against sovereignty, fines up to NPR 2.5 million for unregistered platforms) was withdrawn by the interim cabinet on 6 February 2026, but the 2023 Social Media Directive that enabled the September 2025 block and the Supreme Court's August 2025 order to register platforms still stand, and the Media Council Act of February 2025 replaces Press Council Nepal with a government-chaired body that Article 19 says undermines its independence [19][118][125]. Press-freedom groups see PCN blocking portals and policing YouTube channels as "the sheer misuse of its authority"; PCN itself handled 163 complaints in six months mostly through rebuttals and corrections and decided in 2025 to develop standards for YouTube journalism [62][64][161]. Privacy law has no journalism carve-out in the sources reviewed: Penal Code sections 295-296 criminalise photographing or publishing a person's image without consent, and the Individual Privacy Act 2018 requires consent to collect personal and family data [123][124]. For disaster content the operative texts are PCN's 2083 guidelines, the Child-Friendly Communication Directive 2073 (parental consent for under-18s, invoked against media that showed flood-affected children) and the UN in Nepal's September 2026 statement that missing-persons photos must be verified before publication and used for humanitarian purposes [112][113][114]. Evidence gap: no post-2011 ad-market total; no Nepali portal's rate card; the exact Section 47 fine conflicts across sources; whether a revised social-media bill was re-tabled after February 2026 is unknown.

Questions the advertiser would ask: 1. What are your audited or at least third-party-verified uniques, and what is the Nepal-versus-diaspora split? 2. Will my placement be a fixed-dimension, non-animated slot that readers do not install extensions to remove? 3. Is sponsored content labelled so it cannot be mistaken for verified civic information? 4. Are you listed with the Advertisement Board, and what is your grade?

Questions the regulator would ask: 1. Are you registered with DoIB and listed with the Press Council, and do you display registration number, editor and addresses? 2. Who is the responsible editor for user-generated content, and how fast can you remove an item on a lawful order? 3. How do you comply with PCN's 2083 disaster guidelines, the Child-Friendly Communication Directive and Penal Code 295-296

when publishing names and photos of the missing? 4. Where is your corrections log and complaints channel, and how many complaints have you resolved? 5. Where is personal data stored, under what privacy policy, and with whose consent?

What the evidence cannot yet say

This report leans on secondary coverage of a handful of primary surveys, and a reviewer should weigh it accordingly. The Nepal Media Survey (Sharecast Initiative) is the only recurring, nationally sampled face-to-face audience survey; the 2024 round is known only through one Nepali Times article that omits sample size and trust-by-medium tables, the 2022 round only second-hand, and no 2025 or 2026 round was found, so nothing quantifies where Nepalis get news after the September 2025 uprising [8][9]. There is no Reuters Institute Digital News Report chapter for Nepal and no 2025/26 national trust survey. Platform reach for YouTube and TikTok in Nepal is unpublished by DataReportal; TikTok's 1.35 million-user figure is a device-data inference [1]. The Reddit evidence is **nine threads**, all about Onlinekhabar or ad-blocking, discovered in a brief DuckDuckGo window before it rate-limited and retrieved from the Arctic Shift archive because Reddit blocked the research environment; nothing retrievable discusses Setopati, Ratopati, Kathmandu Post, RONB or Hamro Patro on their own terms, and no "most trusted source" thread could be found [46]. Google Play reviews cover three apps only. No academic usability study, Lighthouse or Core Web Vitals audit of any Nepali portal exists; the typographic guidance (17-18 px, 1.7-1.8 line-height) rests on one commercial agency article [66]. No survey measures which trust cues (phone number, ward-chair quote, verifier name, Nepali language) persuade a Nepali reader of a relief or missing-person post; the trust-marker findings are inferred from official instructions and fact-checker practice. No Nepali source discusses consent or privacy in publishing names and photos of the missing or dead. Duplication of relief is asserted, never measured. Diaspora media habits rest on a 281-person Malaysia survey and anecdote. Several primary documents could not be opened (Open Mic Nepal's final report, the Nepal Police unidentified-bodies portal, BIPAD, the PCN 2083 guidelines PDF, NTA's MIS), and casualty figures for the 2026 flood should always be cited with their bulletin date because they changed daily.

Conclusion

The defining fact of the Nepali online news audience is the distance between use and belief: a country that gets its news from Facebook and YouTube every evening trusts them at 3% and 8%, and still waits for a radio or TV bulletin to decide what is true. That gap is a product specification. The role worth competing for is not discovery, which Facebook, TikTok and YouTube own and which the state can switch off for a week, but confirmation: the thing RONB became by accident for bandas and load-shedding, that Open Mic Nepal did with radio in 2015, and that in August 2026 nobody did for 38 minutes while a synthetic flood reached seven million people. A portal that publishes "as of bulletin N, source: NDRRMA" rather than a number, links to the original upload rather than reposting it, labels AI imagery in Nepali, shows the lede under the headline, logs corrections in public and keeps faces of the dead and children's names off the page would be doing what the Press Council now asks of everyone and what no Nepali outlet is known to do at scale.

The second implication is that the hardest users are the most valuable. The ward chair who wants a public record that 30 sacks reached 270 households, the Rasuwa family that wants one list instead of five, the diaspora remitter who wants to know what arrived, and the district correspondent who wants to be paid

and not doxxed are each asking for provenance and dignity rather than more content. Meeting them also resolves most of what the Reddit threads and Play reviews complain about, because a page built for a 4 GB Android on evening 4G with Mukta at 17 px, a BS date, dark mode, Romanized search and no site-served GIFs is cheaper to run than the incumbents' ad-stuffed pages, and every one of those features is something readers have asked for by name. What remains unknown is whether palikas will enter data, whether anyone outside the educated urban minority will adopt a text portal rather than a video or audio channel, and how a volunteer operation squares the registration regime's paid-staff requirements with its own model; those three are the questions to answer with fieldwork before the next monsoon.

References

Numbered in order of the citation keys used above. URLs are as recorded in the research notes on 14 October 2026; several pages (noted in the text) could be fetched only partially or via search snippets.

1. DataReportal, Digital 2026: Nepal (8 Nov 2025). https://datareportal.com/reports/digital-2026-nepal
2. NepaliTelecom, 'Only 56 percent use internet in Nepal: sharp reality vs expectation in DataReportal figures' (18 May 2026). https://www.nepalitelecom.com/2026/05/only-56-percent-use-intermet-in-nepal-sharp-reality-vs-expection-in-datareportal-figures.html
3. StatCounter, mobile OS market share, Nepal. https://gs.statcounter.com/os-market-share/mobile/nepal
4. StatCounter, Android version market share, Nepal. https://gs.statcounter.com/android-version-market-share/mobile/nepal
5. StatCounter, browser market share (desktop + mobile), Nepal. https://gs.statcounter.com/browser-market-share/desktop-mobile/nepal
6. StatCounter, mobile screen resolution stats, Nepal. https://gs.statcounter.com/screen-resolution-stats/mobile/nepal
7. NepaliTelecom, 'Best phones under Rs 15,000 in Nepal' (2026). https://nepalitelecom.com/best-phones-under-rs-15000-in-nepal
8. Nepali Times, 'What do Nepalis think of the media' (Nepal Media Survey 2024), 27 Dec 2024. https://nepalitimes.com/what-do-nepalis-think-of-the-media
9. Spotlight Nepal, 'Rethinking formal communications in Nepal's digital era: where should leaders speak?', 1 Aug 2026. https://www.spotlightnepal.com/2026/08/01/rethinking-formal-communications-in-nepals-digital-era-where-should-leaders-speak/
10. Nepali Times, 'Surveying Nepal's digital landscape', 15 Oct 2023. https://nepalitimes.com/surveying-nepal-s-digital-landscape
11. Nepali Times, 'Nepal's interface with information' (Nepal Media Survey 2022). https://nepalitimes.com/nepal-s-interface-with-information
12. Nepali Times, 'Mobile Nepal is hooked on YouTube' (Nepal Media Survey 2020), 5 Mar 2020. https://nepalitimes.com/mobile-nepal-is-hooked-on-youtube
13. Nepali Times, 'Nepalis are drifting to digital media' (Nepal Media Survey 2019), 12 Apr 2019. https://nepalitimes.com/nepalis-are-drifting-to-digital-media
14. Wikipedia, '2021 Nepal census' (literacy, mother tongue, provinces). https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/2021_Nepal_census
15. ACL Anthology, CHiPSAL 2026 paper on Romanized Nepali social-media text. https://aclanthology.org/2026.chipsal-1.12/
16. arXiv 2510.07200, study of 108 Nepali TikTok users (CSCW 2025), Oct 2025. https://arxiv.org/html/2510.07200v1
17. Nieman Reports, 'Nepal Gen Z protests: memes, Discord, revolution', 19 Sep 2025. https://niemanreports.org/nepal-gen-z-protests-memes-discord-revolution-oli-one-piece/
18. Global Voices / Nepali Times (Arun Karki), 'It is hard to feel neutral: how Nepal's media covered the Gen Z uprising', 2 Oct 2025. https://globalvoices.org/2025/10/02/it-is-hard-to-feel-neutral-how-nepals-media-covered-the-gen-z-uprising/
19. TechCrunch, 'Nepal blocks Facebook, Instagram, YouTube, X over rule breach amid censorship concerns', 4 Sep 2025. https://techcrunch.com/2025/09/04/nepal-blocks-facebook-instagram-youtube-x-over-rule-breach-amid-censorship-concerns
20. Al Jazeera, 'More egalitarian: how Nepal's Gen Z used gaming app Discord to pick PM', 15 Sep 2025. https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2025/9/15/more-egalitarian-how-nepals-gen-z-used-gaming-app-discord-to-pick-pm
21. CMR-Nepal / NepalFactCheck.org, 'Misinformation during the Gen Z Uprising in Nepal' (PDF), Oct 2025. https://research.butmedia.org/wp-content/uploads/2025/10/GenZ_Protest_Misinformation_Report.pdf
22. Kathmandu Post (Ujjwal Acharya), 'The challenges of misinformation' (CMR Nepal 2024 survey), 23 Jan 2024. https://kathmandupost.com/columns/2024/01/23/the-challenges-of-misinformation
23. ShareSansar, 'A survey conducted by Press Council Nepal: online media in priority to get daily information', 31 May 2020. https://www.sharesansar.com/newsdetail/a-survey-conducted-by-press-council-nepal-online-media-in-priority-to-get-daily-information

24. Semrush, onlinekhabar.com overview (monthly visits, geography). https://www.semrush.com/website/onlinekhabar.com/overview/
25. Similarweb, onlinekhabar.com (Sept 2026 data). https://www.similarweb.com/website/onlinekhabar.com/
26. Similarweb, hamropatro.com (Sept 2026 data). https://www.similarweb.com/website/hamropatro.com/
27. Similarweb, setopati.com (Sept 2026 data). https://www.similarweb.com/website/setopati.com/
28. Similarweb, ekantipur.com (Sept 2026 data). https://www.similarweb.com/website/ekantipur.com/
29. Ahrefs, onlinekhabar.com competitors (organic search estimates, 2025). https://ahrefs.com/websites/onlinekhabar.com/competitors
30. Onlinekhabar English, 'About us' (self-reported audience). https://english.onlinekhabar.com/about-us
31. Ratopati English, 'Hamro Patro remittance crosses Rs 100 million in one month', 6 Jun 2022. https://english.ratopati.com/story/24734/hamro-patro-remittance-100-million-one-month
32. NepaliTelecom, 'Hamro Patro remittance' (US relaunch), 19 Oct 2025. https://nepalitelecom.com/hamro-patro-remittance
33. The Annapurna Express, 'A peek into the popularity of Routine of Nepal Banda', 27 Jun 2020. https://theannapurnaexpress.com/news/a-peek-into-the-popularity-of-routine-of-nepal-banda-2602
34. Kathmandu Post, 'Here's how the popular Routine of Nepal Banda runs', 19 Feb 2020. https://kathmandupost.com/20/2020/02/19/here-s-how-the-popular-routine-of-nepal-banda-runs
35. Kathmandu Post, 'What Routine of Nepal Banda gets right and what it gets wrong', 16 Feb 2026. https://kathmandupost.com/national/2026/02/16/what-routine-of-nepal-banda-gets-right-and-what-it-gets-wrong
36. Nepali Times, 'RONB's media model, decade in the making', 14 Jul 2022. https://nepalitimes.com/ronbs-media-model-decade-in-the-making
37. Columbia Journalism Review, interview with Anup Kaphle (Kantipur Media Group), 8 Oct 2025. https://www.cjr.org/the-interview/anup-kaphle-nepal-gen-z-protest.php
38. Kathmandu Post via Asia News Network, 'What the Prime Minister's asset disclosure tells us about Nepal's quietly growing influencer economy', 12 May 2026. https://asianews.network/what-the-prime-ministers-asset-disclosure-tells-us-about-nepals-quietly-growing-influencer-economy/
39. The Himalayan Times / RSS, 'Nepali media faces sustainability crisis, says report' (Freedom Forum annual report), 2 Jan 2024. https://thehimalayantimes.com/kathmandu/nepali-media-faces-sustainability-crisis-says-report
40. Kathmandu Post, 'Note from group editorial director' (Kantipur One digital subscription), 25 Aug 2026. https://kathmandupost.com/opinion/2026/08/25/note-from-group-editorial-director
41. The Record, 'A message from the founders of The Record' (hiatus), 2 Jul 2022. https://recordnepal.com/a-message-from-the-founders-of-the-record
42. Kathmandu Post, 'Nepali media is fighting for survival; its journalists are fighting for their paychecks', 15 Apr 2026. https://kathmandupost.com/money/2026/04/15/nepali-media-is-fighting-for-survival-its-journalists-are-fighting-for-their-paychecks
43. Ratopati English, 'Newspapers that do not list and renew with the Advertisement Board will not receive public welfare advertising funds' (2026). https://english.ratopati.com/story/77190/newspapers-that-do-not-list-and-renew-their-advertising-on-the-advertisement-board-will-not-receive-public-welfare-advertising-funds
44. Republica, 'SC strikes down govt's one-door policy for public advertisements', 14 Jul 2026. https://myrepublica.nagariknetwork.com/news/sc-strikes-down-govts-one-door-policy-for-public-advertisements-40-97.html
45. Kathmandu Post (Dharma Adhikari), 'Content was and will remain the king', 10 Dec 2022. https://kathmandupost.com/columns/2022/12/10/content-was-and-will-remain-the-king
46. r/Nepal, 'Block ads on OnlineKhabar' (Jan 2020; retrieved via Arctic Shift archive). https://www.reddit.com/r/Nepal/comments/enmieo/block_ads_on_onlinekhabar/
47. r/Nepal, 'How to block ads on these online news sites like Setopati, Online Khabar, Kantipur and such' (Feb 2020). https://www.reddit.com/r/Nepal/comments/fab18b/how_to_block_ads_on_these_online_news_sites_like/
48. r/technepal, 'Can anyone create adblocker to block ads from Nepali News website?' (Jun 2021). https://www.reddit.com/r/technepal/comments/nr4qq6/can_anyone_create_adblocker_to_block_ads_from/
49. r/Nepal, 'Nepali news website ad remover' (Jun 2022). https://www.reddit.com/r/Nepal/comments/vlyat9/nepali_news_website_ad_remover/
50. r/Nepal, 'Onlinekhabar is plain biased' (Sep 2023). https://www.reddit.com/r/Nepal/comments/168v1a4/onlinekhabar_is_plain_biased/
51. r/technepal, 'Onlinekhabar website issue' (Jun 2024). https://www.reddit.com/r/technepal/comments/1d71yb2/onlinekhabar_website_issue/
52. r/Nepal, 'LOL OnlineKhabar: posts an article talking about the negatives of alcohol, puts alcohol ad in the same article' (Aug 2022). https://www.reddit.com/r/Nepal/comments/wrahwr/lol_onlinekhabar_posts_an_article_talking_about/
53. GitHub, manishgs/nepali-news-portal-ad-blocker. https://github.com/manishgs/nepali-news-portal-ad-blocker
54. Google Play, Onlinekhabar app (com.shirantech.onlinekhabar) user reviews. https://play.google.com/store/apps/details?id=com.shirantech.onlinekhabar&hl=en_US

55. Google Play, Hamro Patro app (com.hamropatro) user reviews. https://play.google.com/store/apps/details?id=com.hamropatro&hl=en_US
56. Google Play, Kantipur TV app (com.ekantipur.ktv) user reviews. https://play.google.com/store/apps/details?id=com.ekantipur.ktv
57. Nikita Chaudhary (Medium), 'Case study: UX/UI redesign of Nepali news portal Koshionline', Jul 2021. https://nikita-design.medium.com/case-study-ux-ui-redesign-of-nepali-news-portal-koshionline-dd5581c22f97
58. Dam et al., Jagriti (Gandaki University), chapter on clickbait in Nepali digital media (PDF), 2024. https://www.gandakiuniversity.edu.np/wp-content/uploads/2024/09/CH6.pdf
59. The Himalayan Times, 'Research finds 3.70 per cent misleading news in Nepali media' (Media Action Nepal), 26 Jan 2021. https://thehimalayantimes.com/kathmandu/research-finds-3-70-per-cent-misleading-news-in-nepali-media
60. Nepal Check, 'How false headlines and thumbnails spread misinformation on YouTube in Nepal', 30 Mar 2023. https://nepalcheck.org/2023/03/30/how-false-headlines-and-thumbnails-spread-misinformation-on-youtube-in-nepal/
61. Kathmandu Post, 'In disaster aftermath, Nepal battles a flood of misinformation', 31 Aug 2026. https://kathmandupost.com/national/2026/08/31/in-disaster-aftermath-nepal-battles-a-flood-of-misinformation
62. eKantipur English, '163 complaints registered with Press Council in 6 months', 22 Jan 2026. https://ekantipur.com/news/2026/01/22/en/163-complaints-registered-with-press-council-in-6-months-48-41.html
63. CSOHate, 'Nepal: misinformation and disinformation' (interview with Deepak Adhikari), 10 Dec 2024. https://www.csohate.org/2024/12/10/nepal-misinformation-disinformation/
64. Freedom Forum, 'FF urges Council to not go beyond its jurisdiction while monitoring content on social media'. https://freedomforum.org.np/ff-urges-council-to-not-go-beyond-its-jurisdiction-while-monitoring-content-on-social-media
65. Poynter / IFCN, 'In the absence of truth, misinformation becomes harmful: Nepal's experience shows why fact-checking matters in crises', 2 Apr 2026. https://www.poynter.org/ifcn/2026/in-the-absence-of-truth-misinformation-becomes-harmful-nepals-experience-shows-why-fact-checking-matters-in-crises/
66. WebsNP, 'Nepali Unicode and Devanagari typography on the web'. https://www.websnp.com/help/nepali-unicode-fonts-website-typography
67. Google Fonts CSS2 API, Noto Sans Devanagari subset sizes (measured 14 Oct 2026). https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Noto+Sans+Devanagari:wght@400&display=swap
68. Setopati homepage (live HTML measured 14 Oct 2026). https://www.setopati.com/
69. eKantipur homepage (live HTML measured 14 Oct 2026). https://ekantipur.com/
70. Onlinekhabar homepage (live HTML measured 14 Oct 2026). https://www.onlinekhabar.com/
71. Ratopati story page (font stack measured 14 Oct 2026). https://www.ratopati.com/story/599484
72. W3C, 'Indic Layout Requirements' (Working Draft, 29 May 2020). https://www.w3.org/TR/ilreq/
73. Hamro Patro, 'Hamro Nepali Keyboard' (layouts). https://www.hamropatro.com/en/apps/nepali-keyboard
74. ICANN neobrahmigp mailing list, Devanagari LGR thread on Nepali spelling norms. https://lists.icann.org/hyperkitty/list/neobrahmigp@icann.org/thread/JRROYZX6VPIMMK4SK6PI6JZ7SNFKE3L6/
75. UNICEF Nepal, 'UNICEF and ATscale launch Nepali text-to-speech digital voice Dina (दिना)', 3 Dec 2024. https://www.unicef.org/nepal/press-releases/unicef-and-atscale-launch-nepali-text-speech-digital-voice-dina-%E0%A4%A6%E0%A4%BF%E0%A4%A8%E0%A4%BE-enhance
76. Internet Society, DoIT portal accessibility audit (WCAG 2.2 AA), c. Jan 2026. https://news.internetsociety.org/?p=37907
77. The Annapurna Express, accessibility of eight Nepali health-ministry websites (WAVE audit). https://theannapurnaexpress.com/story/54873/
78. Republica, 'All govt websites now made accessibility friendly'. https://myrepublica.nagariknetwork.com/news/all-govt-websites-now-made-accessibility-friendly-90-67.html
79. NCHL, NEPALPAY/NPS brand guideline (PDF), Feb 2023. https://nchl.com.np/wp-content/uploads/2023/02/6.pdf
80. Hamro Patro homepage (HTML size measured 14 Oct 2026). https://www.hamropatro.com/
81. NepaliTelecom, 'Ncell 90 unlimited and 50 data pack'. https://www.nepalitelecom.com/ncell-90-unlimited-and-50-data-pack
82. Kathmandu Post, 'Nepal sent its disaster alert 38 minutes after the glacier collapse. It wasn't enough', 2 Sep 2026. https://kathmandupost.com/national/2026/09/02/nepal-sent-its-disaster-alert-38-minutes-after-the-glacier-collapse-it-wasn-t-enough
83. RSF, 'Floods in Nepal and Tibet: restrictions and disinformation are impeding vital news', 2 Sep 2026. https://rsf.org/en/floods-nepal-and-tibet-restrictions-and-disinformation-are-impeding-vital-news
84. AAP FactCheck, 'Fake flood footage inundates social media after Nepal disaster', Aug 2026. https://www.aap.com.au/factcheck/fake-flood-footage-inundates-social-media-after-nepal-disaster/
85. The Himalayan Times, 'Nepal Police warns against rumours over relief supplies after floods', 9 Sep 2026. https://thehimalayantimes.com/nepal/nepal-police-warns-against-rumours-over-relief-supplies-after-floods
86. Onlinekhabar English, 'Police intensify crackdown on social media misinformation and rumours', Sep 2026. https://english.onlinekhabar.com/police-intensify-crackdown-on-social-media-misinformation-and-rumours.html
87. AFP via The Star, 'How China and Nepal are battling flood rumours online', 12 Sep 2026. https://www.thestar.com.my/aseanplus/aseanplus-news/2026/09/12/how-china-and-nepal-are-battling-flood-rumours-online

88. Newschecker Nepal, '2025 video from Uttarakhand falsely shared as recent Bhotekoshi flash flood in Nepal', Aug 2026. https://nepal.newschecker.co/en/english/2025-video-from-uttarakhand-falsely-shared-as-recent-bhotekoshi-flash-flood-in-nepal
89. Bernama, Nepal Police missing-persons list (23 Malaysians), Aug 2026. https://www.bernama.com/en/world/news.php?id=2599969
90. AFP via The Star, 'Nepal's wall of missing offers last hope after Himalayan flood', 1 Sep 2026. https://www.thestar.com.my/aseanplus/aseanplus-news/2026/09/01/nepal039s-wall-of-missing-offers-last-hope-after-himalayan-flood
91. AFP via Tribune.net.ph, 'Morgues overflow, burials begin', 31 Aug 2026. https://tribune.net.ph/2026/08/31/morgues-overflow-burials-begin
92. Nepal Red Cross Society, 'Rasuwa Situation Update 5' (PDF), Sep 2026. https://website-api.nrcs.org/media/highlights/files/Rasuwa_Situation_Update_5.pdf
93. eKantipur English, 'Neeraj creates Bhotekoshi flood portal with the power of AI', 3 Sep 2026. https://ekantipur.com/technology/2026/09/03/en/neeraj-creates-bhotekoshi-flood-portal-with-the-power-of-ai-58-15.html
94. Bishal Khadka, LinkedIn post on volunteer missing-persons coordination, Sep 2026. https://np.linkedin.com/in/bishalkhadka
95. World Bank, 'Harnessing the power of the crowd: reflections six months after the Gorkha earthquake in Nepal' (Quakemap.org figures), 27 Oct 2015. https://www.worldbank.org/en/news/feature/2015/10/27/harnessing-the-power-of-the-crowd-reflections-six-months-after-the-gorkha-earthquake-in-nepal
96. Humanitarian Practice Network, 'Mapping for resilience: crowd-sourced mapping in crises' (Kathmandu Living Labs). https://odihpn.org/magazine/mapping-for-resilience-crowd-sourced-mapping-in-crises/
97. Kathmandu Post, '24 days after flood, hunger grips three Rasuwa wards', 18 Sep 2026. https://kathmandupost.com/health/2026/09/18/24-days-after-flood-hunger-grips-three-rusuwa-wards
98. Kathmandu Post via Asia News Network, 'Over 458 flood-affected families in Nepal's Saptari left without promised aid', Oct 2024. https://asianews.network/over-458-flood-affected-families-in-nepals-saptari-left-without-promised-aid/
99. The Himalayan Times, 'Even after five days since the disaster, earthquake survivors are not receiving tarps', 8 Nov 2023. https://thehimalayantimes.com/nepal/even-after-five-days-since-the-disaster-earthquake-survivors-are-not-receiving-tarps
100. Kathmandu Post, 'Nepal Police warn of scams targeting flood relief donations', 27 Aug 2026. https://kathmandupost.com/national/2026/08/27/nepal-police-warn-of-scams-targeting-flood-relief-donations
101. Onlinekhabar English, Nepal Rastra Bank notice on PM Disaster Relief Fund accounts, Aug 2026. https://english.onlinekhabar.com/nrb-m-disaster-relief-fund.html
102. The New Humanitarian, 'Nepal quake fund move a PR fiasco', 5 May 2015. https://www.thenewhumanitarian.org/analysis/2015/05/05/nepal-quake-fund-move-pr-fiasco
103. Onlinekhabar English, UK diaspora flood-relief collections, 4 Sep 2026. https://english.onlinekhabar.com/?p=588994
104. GoFundMe, 'Help Nepal recover: NRNA Iowa flood relief' (campaign disclosures), 2026. https://www.gofundme.com/f/help-nepal-recover-nrna-iowa-flood-relief
105. PreventionWeb, 'Standardization of loss and damage datasets on BIPAD' (2023). https://www.preventionweb.net/quick/50881
106. The Himalayan Times, 'Vyas Municipality launches BIPAD portal'. https://thehimalayantimes.com/nepal/vyas-municipality-launches-bipad-portal
107. Technology Khabar, TikTok monsoon search-banner guide pointing to BIPAD, Jul 2025. https://www.technologykhabar.com/?p=207589
108. Ratopati English, 'Citizen Alert that covers everything from disasters to government complaints' (Nagarik Alert). https://english.ratopati.com/story/80549/citizen-alert-that-covers-everything-from-disasters-to-government-complaints
109. The Annapurna Express (Prakash Bhattarai), 'Loss and damage is the claim; the agenda is everything before it', 9 Sep 2026. https://theannapurnaexpress.com/story/66973/
110. Open Data Nepal, National Climate Change Impact Survey 2016 (CBS). https://opendatanepal.com/dataset/national-climate-change-impact-survey
111. Kathmandu Post column, 'Nepal floods: a preventable disaster', 5 Aug 2025. https://kathmandupost.com/columns/2025/08/05/nepal-floods-a-preventable-disaster
112. The Himalayan Times, UN in Nepal statement on Rasuwa flood coverage and missing-persons photos, 9 Sep 2026. https://thehimalayantimes.com/ampArticle/1040196
113. eKantipur English, 'Clear disclosure is required when using AI-generated symbolic imagery' (PCN Editorial Guidelines for Humane and Responsible Disaster Reporting, 2083), 4 Sep 2026. https://ekantipur.com/news/2026/09/04/en/clear-disclosure-is-required-when-using-ai-generated-symbolic-imagery-04-46.html
114. Republica, 'Minister Timilsina urges media to protect dignity, privacy of Bhotekoshi flood-affected children', Sep 2026. https://myrepublica.nagariknetwork.com/news/minister-timilsina-urges-media-to-protect-dignity-privacy-of-bhotekoshi-flo-12-87.html
115. Kathmandu Post, 'Nepal moves against online abuse targeting flood victims', 7 Sep 2026. https://kathmandupost.com/national/2026/09/07/nepal-moves-against-online-abuse-targeting-flood-victims
116. eKantipur English (Daya Dudraj), 'Online media registration fees: regulating or curbing freedom?', 9 Nov 2025. https://ekantipur.com/news/2025/11/09/en/online-media-registration-fees-regulating-or-curbing-freedom-15-27.html

117. AHN Legal, 'Online media regulation in Nepal' (Online Media Operation Regulation 2017 summary). https://www.ahnlegal.com/legal-updates/legal/online-media-regulation-in-nepal
118. ARTICLE 19 and Media Action Nepal, UPR submission on Nepal (PDF), Oct 2025. https://www.article19.org/wp-content/uploads/2026/01/UPR-Nepal-7.2025-A19_MAN.pdf
119. CPJ, 'Nepali journalists Aishwarya Kunwar, Puskar Bhatt arrested under cybercrime law', Feb 2024. https://cpj.org/2024/02/nepali-journalists-aishwarya-kunwar-puskar-bhatt-arrested-under-cybercrime-law/
120. FORUM-ASIA, case record on Dil Bhusan Pathak arrest warrant, 2025. https://asianhrds.forum-asia.org/en/entity/btys6a5ndfe
121. Kathmandu Post via Asia News Network, Supreme Court contempt ruling against Sidhakura.com publisher and editor, 30 Sep 2024. https://asianews.network/?p=168780
122. Kathmandu Post, 'Former editor sentenced for defamation as media groups decry ruling as blow to press freedom', 1 Jul 2026. https://kathmandupost.com/national/2026/07/01/former-editor-sentenced-for-defamation-as-media-groups-decry-ruling-as-blow-to-press-freedom
123. nepallaws.com, National Penal Code 2074, Section 295 (photographs without consent). https://nepallaws.com/Laws/the-national-penal-code-act-2074/part-3-offences-against-individual-privacy-and-prestige/chapter-1-offences-against-privacy/section-295-prohibition-of-taking-or-disfiguring-photograph-of-any-person-without-his-or-her-consent/
124. Pioneer Law, 'Individual Privacy Act 2018 (2075)' summary. https://pioneerlaw.com/individual-privacy-act-2018-2075
125. Kathmandu Post, 'Government moves to withdraw Social Media Bill', 7 Feb 2026. https://kathmandupost.com/national/2026/02/07/government-moves-to-withdraw-social-media-bill
126. Freedom Forum, Annual Press Freedom Report 2026 (May 2025-Apr 2026) summary. https://freedomforum.org.np/news/detail/840
127. Freedom Forum, Annual Media Report 2025 summary. https://freedomforum.org.np/news/detail/826
128. Freedom Forum, online harassment survey of 100 journalists (presented 8 Jul 2022). https://freedomforum.org.np/news/detail/674
129. eKantipur English, 'Female journalists hit by trolling and doxxing', 2 Jan 2026. https://ekantipur.com/news/2026/01/02/en/female-journalists-hit-by-trolling-and-doxxing-06-12.html
130. Freedom Forum, 'Nepali media braves hostility: preliminary report on media status during Gen Z protest' (PDF), Sep 2025. https://freedomforum.org.np/download/nepali-media-braves-hostility-preliminary-report/file
131. CPJ, 'Nepal protests: media outlets torched and journalists injured in deadly unrest', 10 Sep 2025. https://cpj.org/2025/09/nepal-protests-media-outlets-torched-and-journalists-injured-in-deadly-unrest/
132. Republica, 'Complaints filed against 699 officials not providing information' (Freedom Forum RTI requests to 753 local levels). https://myrepublica.nagariknetwork.com/news/complaints-filed-against-699-officials-not-providing-information
133. Freedom Forum, Ukeraa CMS breach and deletion of investigative stories, Dec 2024. https://www.freedomforum.org.np/news/detail/692
134. Nepali Times, 'Monopoly on information' (publishers' dependence on Facebook). https://nepalitimes.com/monopoly-on-information
135. IFJ, 'Nepal: minister to raise journalist minimum wage by 40 per cent', 25 May 2023. https://www.ifj.org/media-centre/news/detail/category/press-releases/article/nepal-minister-to-raise-journalist-minimum-wage-by-40-per-cent
136. Pokharel, PCN Journal Vol 5 (NepJOL), community radio sustainability study, 2025. https://www.nepjol.info/index.php/nmies/article/view/86004
137. IFEX / Freedom Forum, Press Council Nepal asks NTA to block 15 unregistered portals, Apr 2023. https://ifex.org/?p=340846
138. eKantipur English, 'Press Council directs to remove 90 materials that violate journalistic code of conduct', 31 Jul 2026. https://ekantipur.com/news/2026/07/31/en/press-council-directs-to-remove-90-materials-that-violate-journalistic-code-of-conduct-14-24.html
139. Onlinekhabar English, 'Nepal needs more fact-checking institutions, but their sustainability is a big question'. https://english.onlinekhabar.com/nepal-needs-more-fact-checking-institutions-but-their-sustainability-is-a-big-question.html
140. IFCN Code of Principles, South Asia Check assessment (27 fact-checks in 2021). https://mail.ifcncodeofprinciples.poynter.org/application/public/south-asia-check/40E853D2-2EE5-00AC-0224-D3A409CAD984
141. Kathmandu Post, 'Nepal lifts its ban on TikTok', 23 Aug 2024. https://kathmandupost.com/national/2024/08/23/nepal-lifts-its-ban-on-tiktok
142. NepaliTelecom, 'Nepal Telecom opens Viber community for grievances', Sep 2025. https://www.nepalitelecom.com/2025/09/nepal-telecom-viber-community-contact-for-grievances.html
143. MIDEQ, 'Uses of digital technologies: Nepali migrants in Malaysia' (281-respondent survey). https://www.mideq.org/en/resources-index-page/uses-digital-technologies-nepali-migrants-malaysia/
144. Nepali Times (Upasana Khadka), 'From letters to landlines, phones to Facebook', 17 Aug 2020. https://nepalitimes.com/from-letters-to-landlines-phones-to-facebook
145. B360 Nepal, 'Remittance inflows to Nepal surge 37.1 pc to over Rs 2,363bn in FY 2025/26: NRB'. https://www.b360nepal.com/detail/29887/remittance-inflows-to-nepal-surge-371-pc-to-over-rs-2363bn-in-fy-202526-nrb
146. Onlinekhabar English, remittances and labour approvals FY2025/26 (2026). https://english.onlinekhabar.com/remittances-nepal-2026.html

147. Onlinekhabar English, 'Nepal has over 2,325 online news portals now', Feb 2021. https://english.onlinekhabar.com/nepal-has-over-2325-online-news-portals-now.html
148. NepJOL, 'News media in Nepal 2024/25' (5,126 registered online outlets). https://www.nepjol.info/index.php/nmies/article/view/86001
149. NepaliTelecom, 'Nepal's internet traffic peaked at 109 Gbps during FIFA World Cup 2026 opener', Jun 2026. https://www.nepalitelecom.com/2026/06/nepals-internet-traffic-peaked-109-gbps-during-fifa-world-cup-2026-opener.html
150. NepaliTelecom, 'Internet speed at peak hours' (NTA peak-hour rule), Feb 2023. https://www.nepalitelecom.com/internet-speed-at-peak-hours
151. The Tribune (India), 'Gutted, vandalised: Nepal's biggest media house building lies in shambles as aftermath of Gen Z protests surfaces', Sep 2025. https://www.tribuneindia.com/news/world/gutted-vandalised-nepals-biggest-media-house-building-lies-in-shambles-as-aftermath-of-gen-z-protests-surfaces
152. NepaliTelecom, 'Nepal government sent 50 lakh flood/landslide awareness messages on a single day on Ashoj 18, 2082', Oct 2025. https://www.nepalitelecom.com/2025/10/nepal-government-sent-50-lakh-flood-landslide-awareness-messages-on-a-single-day-on-ashoj-18-2082.html
153. WMO, 'Improved flood preparedness and community-based early warnings needed: Nepal', 20 Dec 2024. https://wmo.int/resources/meteoworld/meteoworld-december-2024/improved-flood-preparedness-and-community-based-early-warnings-needed-nepal
154. UNDRR / PreventionWeb (Roshan Sedhai), Radio Melamchi flood warning, 2021. https://undrr.org/quick/66278
155. Freedom Forum, Press Council Nepal blacklists four outlets for publishing without fact-checking, late 2024. https://freedomforum.org.np/news/detail/774
156. Onlinekhabar English (opinion), 'Balen government's miss-communication' (2026). https://english.onlinekhabar.com/balen-governments-miss-communication.html
157. Internews, 'Nepal earthquake response' project page (Open Mic Nepal). https://internews.org/areas-of-expertise/humanitarian/projects/natural-disaster-projects/nepal-earthquake-response/
158. Kathmandu Post, 'PM Shah addresses five queries over government's handling of Bhotekoshi floods', 2 Sep 2026. https://kathmandupost.com/national/2026/09/02/pm-shah-addresses-five-queries-over-government-s-handling-of-bhotekoshi-floods
159. Kathmandu Post, '147 local representatives, government staff, teachers and security personnel missing after Bhotekoshi floods', 2 Sep 2026. https://kathmandupost.com/national/2026/09/02/147-local-representatives-government-staff-teachers-and-security-personnel-missing-after-bhotekoshi-floods
160. Nepali Times, 'How Nepal's media landscape is being transformed' (Nepal Media Survey 2018), 13 Apr 2018. https://nepalitimes.com/banner/how-nepals-media-landscape-is-being-transformed/
161. Himal Press, 'Press Council Nepal decides to develop standards for YouTube channels', Jul 2025. https://en.himalpress.com/press-council-nepal-decides-to-develop-standards-for-youtube-channels/
162. Kathmandu Post column, 'Of millennials and mangled Nepali on social media', 2 Dec 2019. https://kathmandupost.com/columns/2019/12/02/of-millenials-and-mangled-nepali-on-social-media
163. Lawalpine, 'Online media registration in Nepal' (2026 guide). https://lawalpine.com/blog/online-media-registration-in-nepal
164. Nepali Times, 'Periphery of news' (district correspondents' pay and threats), 2013. https://nepalitimes.com/periphery-of-news
165. Press Council Nepal, Nepali Media Journal 2080 (PDF), 2023 (advertising as primary revenue model; static banners dominate). https://www.presscouncilnepal.gov.np/np/wp-content/uploads/2023/09/Nepali-Media_Journal-2080_Inside-Final-1-1.pdf

PART 2 OF 3

What an ideal Nepali online public-information portal must look like

Audit of Verified Nepal, October 2026. Report 2 of 3. Written 2026-10-14 for the owner; to be reviewed by a second AI agent.

Sources: the six research notes in `research_notes/Nepali online news audience/` (cited by number below; every number maps to a URL in section 7), the LLM council transcripts (`council-question.md`, `council-advisors.md`, `council-reviews.md`, `council-verdict.md`) and the owner's decisions in `docs/NEWS-PORTAL-DECISIONS.md` (updated 2026-10-14), which are treated as authoritative where they settle a point. Report 1 (audience research) did not exist when this was written, so the reference numbering here is self-contained. Where the evidence is one source, one anecdote or an inference, the text says so.

Scope: this report describes the ideal. It does not grade Verified Nepal's current site (Report 3; inventory in [97]) except where the council's reframe depends on it.

---

1. Executive summary

The ideal Nepali public-information portal is not a 101st news portal. Nepal has 5,135 registered online outlets [64], roughly 8% of surveyed Nepalis trust online portals and 2-3% trust social media [4][2], and 67% say they saw misinformation in the past week [7]. Readers discover on Facebook (primary news source for 62% overall and 82.6% of 16-24s [2]) and then verify on radio and TV bulletins [3][5]. The verification seat is therefore open and nobody online holds it. The council's reframe, which this report adopts, is that the ideal is a **checked record**: a Nepali-first status board of short, dated, located, sourced items, each with a permanent URL that a Facebook post, a Viber forward or an FM host can cite, backed by a ward-level needs-to-delivery ledger for disasters, and distributed as share cards into the feeds where Nepalis already are [96]. It competes for the verification role currently held by radio/TV and by two tiny fact-checking organisations [25][60], not with Facebook for discovery and not with Onlinekhabar for page views. Its success metric is how often it is cited, not how often it is visited. The two Nepali brands readers actually praise, Routine of Nepal Banda and Hamro Patro, both won a narrow daily-checked utility first and broadened later [22][57]; neither is a newsroom. The ideal copies that shape, adds provenance on every item (because logos and official formats are forged [27]), stays inside the legal posture a small operator can sustain (pre-moderated, non-commercial, no comments) until a registered entity exists [64][95], and never shows an empty page or a stale "live" number.

Figure 10. What the ideal home screen looks like on a phone (illustration)



1. **The date readers expect**
   Bikram Sambat in Devanagari digits at the top, and relative times such as ११ घण्टा अगाडि on every item (layers 3a and 3e).
2. **Hotlines never leave the screen**
   Keep what already works on Verified Nepal today: the emergency number stays visible (layer 3i).
3. **Place first**
   Choose a place once. Items show for the ward, then the municipality, district and Nepal, and empty tiers collapse (layers 3a and 3b).
4. **Two labels, in words**
   आधिकारिक स्रोत: an official source posted it. जाँच गरिएको: a volunteer moderator checked it has a source, a place and a date. Neither means 'true' (layer 3c).
5. **Every item shows its source**
   Place, time, a link to the original, and an EN or ने chip for the language it was written in (layer 3b).
6. **Built to be shared**
   One tap sends a card, with its label baked in, to Facebook, Viber or WhatsApp (layer 3g).

Layout illustration for Part 2. Placeholder items are invented and are not real reports.

2. Design principles

Each principle is traced to the pain point it answers and the evidence for that pain point. Confidence is stated where the evidence is thin.

#	Principle	Pain point it answers, with evidence	Confidence
P1	**Provenance over logos.** Every item carries a link to the original source, the source's own timestamp and, for official figures, the bulletin number ("NDRRMA bulletin, 17 Sept, 1,410 dead / 6,145 missing, provisional").	Scammers copy "the logos, names, or formats of official government agencies" within 48 hours of a disaster [27]; official counts changed bulletin to bulletin in Aug-Sept 2026 [26][35]; fact-checkers won trust by locating the original upload and date, not by branding [26].	High (consistent across 2015-2026 events)
P2	**Nepali-first, with an EN chip.** Default to Devanagari Nepali on first visit; each item shows in the language it was written in with a two-letter EN / ने chip; the toggle changes chrome only. No machine-translated copies.	Nepali portals treat English as a separate property, not a per-article toggle [45][46][47]; the owner has already decided per-item language with a chip [95]. 55% of Nepalis have a non-Nepali mother tongue [6], so Nepali-first is necessary but not sufficient (see P11).	High on default; the chip pattern is an inference from incumbents' "EN" affordance

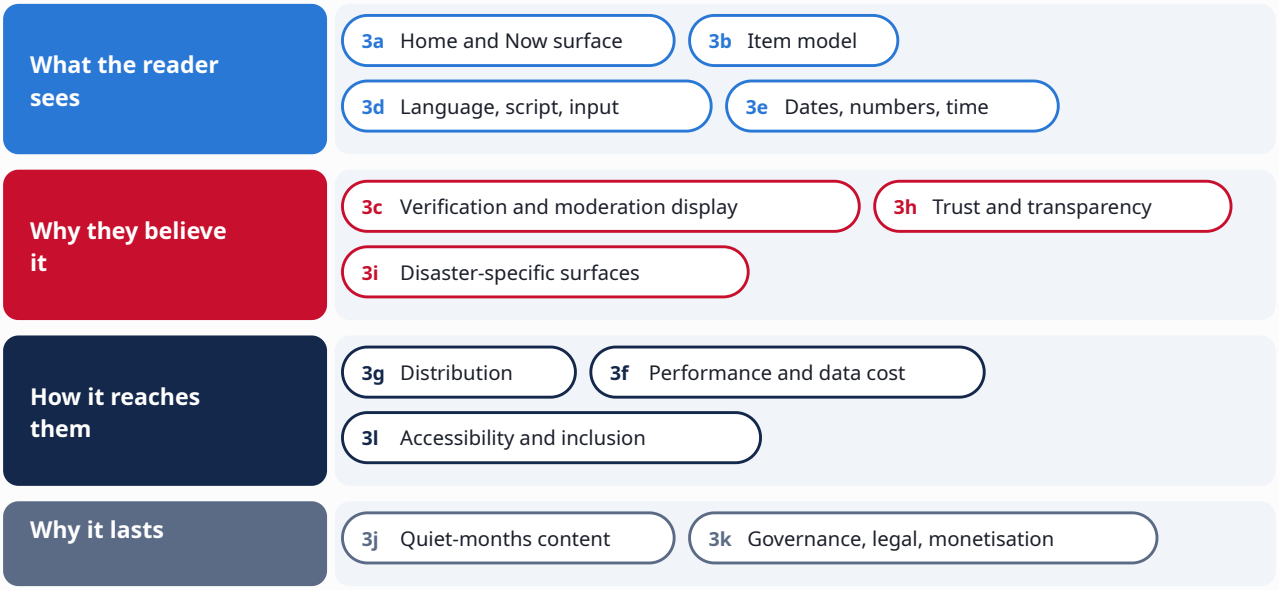
#	Principle	Pain point it answers, with evidence	Confidence
P3	**Every item is dated, located and sourced, or it does not publish.** Place to ward/palika, `happenedAt`, source link. The Desk rule is already "Reject if no source, no place, or no date" [95].	"Incomplete information presented without context is, in a way, a form of misinformation" (Ujjwal Acharya on RONB-style snippets) [23]; copy-paste wire content "one-two days old" [15]; local news is the gap the national survey's authors name [2].	High
P4	**No clutter, no ads that readers block.** No animated/GIF creatives, no interstitials, no ads in notifications, nothing above the fold on disaster items.	Ad load is the single most recurring Reddit complaint; four threads exist solely to build blockers because Nepali portals serve static banners that uBlock cannot catch [13][14][15][16]; Hamro Patro's reviews are dominated by unskippable video ads and ads pushed as notifications [18].	High (pervasive), though the Reddit sample is nine threads skewed to Onlinekhabar [13]
P5	**Speed on a 360 px Android on congested evening 4G.** Light first load, no map or large JSON before the reader asks for it.	75% Android [11] and many mobile connections are voice/SMS-only [94]; top viewports 414x896 and 360x800 [10]; NPR 13-15k phones ship 4 GB RAM [12]; traffic peaks 8-11 pm when ISPs share lines among 4-8 subscribers [8][9]; "news loads slower" is a top Play complaint [17].	High on constraints; no Nepal study defines "fast" [research gap]
P6	**One meaning of "verified".** Two labels only: "आधिकारिक स्रोत / Official source" for items relayed from OPMCM, NDRRMA, DHM, Nepal Police; "जाँच गरिएको / Checked" for anything a volunteer moderator approved. Nothing else is called verified.	The council found five senses of "Verified" on the current site [96]; readers' trust problem is that "verified" claims are made by everyone, including a Facebook page named like a radio station that posted recycled footage [26].	High
P7	**Honesty about staleness.** Relative time on every item ("११ घण्टा अगाडि"), an absolute BS + AD date on the item page, "last verified" on every centre or ledger row, and a snapshot label whenever data is not live.	A "Live" label over a snapshot from 2026-08-29 is the single most damaging credibility leak the council found [96]; NDRRMA itself marks figures "provisional and subject to change with each bulletin" [35].	High
P8	**Safe by default for the dead, the missing and children.** No faces of the dead, no gruesome thumbnails or autoplay previews, AI images labelled "एआईद्वारा सिर्जित सांकेतिक दृश्य", family consent before a missing-person listing, parental consent for under-18s, listings pulled on resolution.	Press Council Nepal's Editorial Guidelines for Humane and Responsible Disaster Reporting, 2083 (4 Sept 2026) [72]; the Minister's direction on children's dignity under the Child-Friendly Communication Directive 2073 [73]; UN Nepal's statement on verifying missing-person photos [74]; Penal Code ss.295-296 on photographs without consent [75]; 67 of 101 PCN complaints after the flood were about gruesome personal-account posts [26].	High on the rules; no Nepali source discusses consent for missing lists specifically [research gap]
P9	**A public corrections log.** Every edit after publish is visible, dated and explained; retractions keep the URL and say why.	The 2025 Press and Publication Rules require errors corrected "promptly and publicly" [64]; PCN 2083 requires immediate correction with explanation [72]; PCN's own remedy ladder starts with rectify-and-republish and ends with removal and blacklisting [77]; Sidhakura's editors were jailed for repeated republication of unverified audio [71].	High
P10	**Accessible to TalkBack users and to people who do not read well.** `lang="ne"` markup so the Dina Nepali TTS voice is selected, WCAG 2.2 AA, 44 px targets, icon + label buttons, short sentences.	Dina (दिना) launched Dec 2024 as the first realistic Nepali screen-reader voice [52]; the 2026 DoIT audit used WCAG 2.2 AA and found skip links, contrast and PDF-only content failing [53]; MoCIT's 2021 directive requires responsive, disability-friendly sites in Nepali Unicode and English [54]; literacy is 76% overall and 69% for women [6]; only 13.1% of illiterate respondents consume news digitally [2].	High on rules; no Dina adoption numbers exist [research gap]

#	Principle	Pain point it answers, with evidence	Confidence
P11	**Room for Madhesh and non-Nepali mother tongues.** Item language is a field, not a site setting; Maithili and Bhojpuri items are possible later without redesign; place names accept Hindi/Maithili spellings.	Madhesh is 21% of the population and reads online news at 19.9% vs 69.5% in Gandaki [2][6]; Maithili 11.1%, Bhojpuri 6.2% mother tongue [6].	Medium: the need is well evidenced, the design response is untested

3. The ideal, by layer

Each layer lists concrete requirements (numbered for the scorecard in section 4) and a short "what good looks like".

Figure 11. Twelve layers make up the ideal portal, in four groups



Layer numbers match section 3 of this report. The grouping is a reading aid.

3a. Home / "Now" surface

Requirements:

- **H1** Masthead shows today's BS date in Devanagari digits in the incumbents' form ("बुधबार, असोज २८, २०८३"), with the AD date in metadata and in a smaller line [45][46]. Month naming is a style choice; the colloquial असोज (Setopati) reads more spoken than आश्विन (eKantipur) [46].
- **H2** A "Now" strip of 3-5 items is the first block. Each row: place, what, relative time ("२ घण्टा अगाडि"), label (P6), source link, EN/ने chip. The strip is fed from whatever the site already ingests (official notices, centre verifications, ledger deliveries, published local updates), so it is never empty even when no volunteer writes [96].
- **H3** The first interactive element after the strip is a locality question, not a category bar: "तपाईंको पालिका?" with a picker that accepts Nepali, English, Roman-Nepali and old VDC names [95]. The reader's intent is a question ("does my palika have X?"), not a feed [96].
- **H4** A hotline bar on every page (the state's own alert SMS lists hotlines [30]); numbers tappable.

- **H5** No empty states, ever. A chosen locality with nothing collapses to the next tier (Municipality, District, Nepal) so no heading renders over nothing [95]. Surfaces whose API returns zero are not linked from navigation.
- **H6** Navigation is six items or fewer, in words a shopkeeper uses: अहिले (Now), सहयोग चाहियो (Get help), सहयोग दिन्छु (Give help), मानिस खोज्नुहोस् (Find someone), राहत केन्द्र (Drop centres), खाता (Ledger) [96]. Acronyms (OPMCM, NDRRMA, NPT) are expanded on first use.

What good looks like: a Hetauda shopkeeper opens the site at 8 pm on a 360 px phone, sees today's BS date, three dated items with places and sources, a box asking for her palika, and the hotline bar, all in Nepali, in under two seconds on 4G. Nothing says "Live" unless it is.

3b. Item model

Requirements:

- **I1** An item is short: 6-7 lines, the RONB length that readers call "easy-to-digest snippets" [22][24]. Long-form survives only as evergreen explainers (3j).
- **I2** Required fields: `lang`, `scope` (Ward/Municipality/District/Province/Nepal), `locality`, `happenedAt`, `sourceUrls[]`, `expiresAt` where relevant, label. These are the fields the owner has already decided [95].
- **I3** Headline and body agree. The first line is the fact, not a tease; "यस्तो छ.../हेर्नुहोस्" constructions are rejected at moderation. Headline-body mismatch is the measured Nepali form of clickbait [19][20].
- **I4** Status label vocabulary is exactly two values (P6): "आधिकारिक स्रोत / Official source" and "जाँच गरिएको / Checked". The label states who checked (role, not personal name, see 3h) and when.
- **I5** Permanent URL that survives edits and retractions, with `datePublished` / `dateModified` in machine-readable form and an `article:published_time` tag, so the item is a citation target for fact-checkers and journalists.
- **I6** Byline shows the contributor's public profile (locality, published count) and "तस्बिर :" photo credits, the incumbents' trust cue [45][46].
- **I7** Each item renders as a PNG share card with the label, place, date and URL baked in, for Facebook, WhatsApp and Viber (3g).

What good looks like: "रसुवा, उत्तरगया-३ · ४० त्रिपाल पुगे · २ घण्टा अगाडि · जाँच गरिएको · स्रोत: वडा कार्यालय" with a tap to the source and a tap to share.

3c. Verification and moderation display

Requirements:

- **V1** Pre-moderation for everything public (owner decision [95]). Readers never see an unreviewed item. This is also the lower-risk legal posture: the 2017 directive and its 2025 successor make the operator "fully responsible" for content and comments [65][64].
- **V2** The mark asserts only what it asserts. A short "what this label means" line is one tap from every label: "Checked" means a volunteer moderator confirmed the item has a named source, a place and a date and that the source says what the item says. It does not mean the site witnessed the event, and it does not mean a government body endorsed it.
- **V3** Reviewer rules are published: a reporter never reviews their own post; Ward/Municipality scope may be approved by a same-district moderator (audit entry records `localReview: true`); District scope

needs a moderator outside the reporter's home district; Province/Nepal scope needs a national moderator; 5 submissions per 24 h per reporter; three rejections in 90 days flag the account [95].

- **V4** The Desk rule card carries the PCN 2083 five-point check for social-media material (source, location, time, context, independent evidence), a reverse-image-search step, and the no-faces-of-the-dead and AI-labelling rules [72]. The recurring Nepali failure is republishing viral material, not fabrication [60][26].
- **V5** Corrections and retractions are a visible log (P9). A corrected item shows "सच्याइयो" with date and a one-line reason; a retracted item keeps its URL and shows what was wrong.
- **V6** Public flag mechanism on every published item (one tap, reason list, no account needed), routed to the existing flagged queue [95]. Flags are not comments and are not displayed.
- **V7** Moderator capacity is a published number, not a promise: "N moderators active this week in M districts", so readers can judge coverage honestly. (Inference: no Nepali site does this; it follows from P7.)

What good looks like: a reader taps "जाँच गरिएको", reads two sentences on what was checked and by what role, sees the source link, and can flag it in one tap if the source does not say that.

3d. Language, script and input

Requirements:

- **L1** Devanagari typography: body 17-18 px, line-height 1.7-1.8, no letter-spacing inside words (it breaks the shirorekha), emphasis by weight or colour rather than synthesised italics, conjuncts (क्ष, ज्ञ) tested on a cheap Android and on iOS [43][51]. These sizes come from a single Nepali agency article and should be treated as a starting point, not a standard [43].
- **L2** Two self-hosted Devanagari weights (400 and one heavier), `font-display: swap`, preload the body weight. One Devanagari weight costs 38-62 KB woff2, so two weights plus Latin is roughly 100-150 KB; Ratopati's six Mukta weights cost ~370 KB [44]. Mukta reads "native" to Setopati/Ratopati readers; Noto Sans Devanagari has safer conjunct coverage [43][44].
- **L3** Devanagari digits in Nepali chrome and dates; ICU `ne-NP` already produces them with lakh/crore grouping (१,२३,४५,६७८) [research note measurement]. Latin digits in URLs and machine metadata.
- **L4** Roman-Nepali input everywhere a reader types: the locality picker and search transliterate "ram bahadur" or "hetauda" server-side to Devanagari before matching [48][50]. Search normalises NFC, folds ि/ी and ु/ू, folds nukta, and accepts loanword spelling variants, because Nepali has no enforced spelling norm [49].
- **L5** Separate-language items, not machine translation. An item exists in the language it was written in; a second-language version is a second item written by a person. Moderators declare the languages they review and the queue filters by it [95].
- **L6** Room for Maithili and Bhojpuri: `lang` is per item, place names carry alternates, and fonts cover the Devanagari range those languages use (P11).
- **L7** Legacy Preeti/Kantipur-encoded text is converted to Unicode before publishing; search engines and screen readers see gibberish otherwise [43].

What good looks like: a Gulf worker types "nuwakot" on an English keyboard and lands on नुवाकोट; the page reads in Mukta at 17 px with nothing letter-spaced; TalkBack reads it in a Nepali voice.

3e. Dates, numbers, time

Requirements:

- **D1** BS and AD both shown on item pages; BS primary in Nepali chrome, AD in metadata and URLs, matching incumbent practice [45][46][47]. There is no ICU Bikram Sambat calendar, so BS needs a conversion table [research note measurement].
- **D2** Relative times ("११ घण्टा अगाडि") on lists, the Onlinekhabar convention [47], always with the absolute timestamp one tap away.
- **D3** All times in NPT (UTC+05:45), labelled "नेपाली समय" or "NPT" on first use. For diaspora readers, the item page shows the local time of the device in a smaller line, because Gulf readers are 2h45m behind Nepal and read after shifts [85].
- **D4** Numbers in lakh/crore in Nepali text (५० लाख) and with a Western grouping in the EN view; relief sums carry the currency symbol रु.
- **D5** Casualty and relief figures always carry "as of [bulletin time], source" (P1), never a bare number [35].

What good looks like: "१,४१० मृत्यु · ६,१४५ बेपत्ता · NDRRMA बुलेटिन, १ असोज २०८३ १८:०० · प्रारम्भिक" above "1,410 dead · 6,145 missing · as of 17 Sept 2026 18:00 NPT".

Evidence gap: no reader study on BS vs AD or Devanagari vs Latin digit preference exists [research gap]; the recommendation follows incumbent practice.

3f. Performance and data cost budget

Requirements:

- **F1** First load of the Now surface under 300 KB transferred, including fonts, on a 360 px device; total page under 1 MB with images. Nepali portals' raw HTML alone runs 60-234 KB, and Hamro Patro's homepage HTML is 1.72 MB [measured in research note]; a 1 MB page is competitive, 300 KB is a lead.
- **F2** No map library, no satellite tiles and no large JSON on first load. Maps and person-search data load only when the reader asks. The council flagged a 1.5 MB JSON precached on first visit and a map on home as the current anti-pattern [96].
- **F3** Service worker caches the shell and the last Now strip so a reader with a dropped connection still sees the last-known items, each stamped with its fetch time (P7). Do not precache content the reader has not requested.
- **F4** Cache honesty: every cached item shows when it was fetched; nothing cached is labelled live.
- **F5** No third-party scripts, no analytics beacons that a Nepali ad blocker list would strip anyway [16]; first-party page-reach counts only.
- **F6** Images: one width per breakpoint, modern formats, lazy below the fold; thumbnails never autoplay (also a PCN 2083 rule [72]).

What good looks like: at 9 pm on a shared fibre line in a hill district, the strip renders before the font swaps in, and the map on the flood page is a button, not a default.

Evidence gap: per-GB data is cheap (roughly Rs 45/GB on small packs [12]), so the budget is about latency on congested links, not cost; no Nepal-specific "what counts as fast" study exists.

3g. Distribution

Requirements:

- **X1** The site is the citation target; the feed is the channel. Facebook reaches ~90% of Nepali internet users [1] and is the primary news source for 62% [2]; incumbent portals get 69-83% "direct" traffic that includes app and dark-social pastes [55]. Design every item to be pasted, not browsed to.
- **X2** An owned Facebook page posts the share cards daily in the 6-9 pm window, the evening peak [8][9]; a Viber community is the fallback because Viber and TikTok stayed up when 26 platforms were blocked on 4-9 Sept 2025 [58][59]. `Organization.sameAs` lists these.
- **X3** Share cards (I7) carry the label, place, date and permanent URL baked into the PNG, so a forward stripped of context still shows provenance; WhatsApp and Viber share buttons alongside Facebook. No Nepal data exists on Viber/WhatsApp news sharing [research gap]; the choice follows the 2025 block.
- **X4** RSS and a JSON feed of published items, for aggregators (Hamro Patro republishes portal content [research note]), FM stations and fact-checkers. 48% of regular portal visitors in 2022 arrived via push and 57% via friends' links [4]; RSS is how third parties build those pushes without the site running a notification channel itself.
- **X5** Cadence: one daily "आजको जाँच गरिएको" bulletin at 6-9 pm NPT, plus a 6-9 am item for the radio-habit audience and Gulf workers before shifts [88][85]. During a disaster, the first checked item matters more than completeness: AI footage reached 7 million views in the gap before official voices in Aug 2026 [26].
- **X6** Diaspora: the EN chip, device-local time (D3), and the ledger (3i) as the thing NRNA chapters cite when asking "what reached Nepal" [40]. US and Australia are the largest overseas sources of portal traffic [87]; Gulf and Malaysia hold 85% of labour migrants [86].
- **X7** Short vertical video with Nepali captions is the native format for under-35s [89]; the ideal publishes the daily bulletin as a captioned 30-second card-video to the owned pages when capacity allows. This is a distribution requirement, not a reason to host video.

What good looks like: an FM host in Dhunche reads the 6 pm card on air and says the URL; a cousin in Doha forwards it on Viber; both arrive at the same permanent page with the same label and date.

3h. Trust and transparency surfaces

Requirements:

- **T1** "Who runs this" page: the operating entity, its governance document and its moderation guidelines linked from the footer of every page. The council found these exist but are unlinked [96].
- **T2** DoIB registration number in the footer once registered, in the incumbents' form ("सूचना विभाग दर्ता नं …") [45]; until then, a one-line honest statement of status and the words "local updates / local correspondents" rather than "news / reporters" [95].
- **T3** Public audit log of moderation actions (approve, reject, correct, retract) by role and time, without personal names.
- **T4** Ledger of needs, offers and deliveries at ward level (3i), public and masked.
- **T5** "हामी पैसा लिँदैनौं / We never handle money" on every donation-adjacent surface, with deep links only to accounts listed on NRB, OPMCM or MoF sites, never a QR code or wallet number rendered by the site. Fake PM-fund QR codes appeared within 48 hours of the flood [27][28].
- **T6** Fake-QR and scam warning as a standing item during disasters, quoting the Police and NRB advice [27][28].
- **T7** A named contact that is safe to publish: a role address and phone for the entity (not a private individual's), and an in-page flag/correction form. Named volunteers, particularly women, face doxxing and threats with no state response mechanism [79][68][93]; the 2025 protests made outlet identification a

physical liability [78]. Public bylines use the contributor's chosen public profile; home address and personal phone never appear.

- **T8** Privacy policy in both languages, with the consent rules for missing-person and photo content stated plainly (P8).

What good looks like: the footer reads, in Nepali, who operates the site, its registration number, a link to how items are checked, a link to the corrections log, and "we never handle money", and every one of those links opens a real page.

3i. Disaster-specific surfaces

Requirements:

- **S1** Missing-person search with a consent-and-privacy posture: family-initiated entries, verification against official lists (Nepal Police, NRCS Restoring Family Links), no photos of the dead, children's identifying details off the public page, listings pulled on reunification, and the page kept out of search indexes [72][74][75][76]. Volunteers in 2026 said "there was no centralized database" [32] and a civil servant's overnight dashboard preceded the government's own missing-persons search by days [31]; the state's own practice (names and DOBs on Facebook, QR-linked body photos, LED screens of corpses [33][34]) is permissive, so dignity is the differentiator, not compliance. Cross-script name search must work (L4).
- **S2** Relief ledger: needs, offers and deliveries at ward level, with household counts and criteria, not recipient names (eligibility lists caused disputes in Saptari 2024 and Jajarkot 2023 [39]). Record deliveries as facts with source and date; never editorialise absence, because "Ward 3 was not reached" names a CDO and is defamation and ETA s.47 bait [67][82]. The adoption hook, ward chairs wanting a public record that relief had not arrived, rests on one Kathmandu Post report and is marked as inference in the research [29]; treat it as a hypothesis to test with two or three ward chairs.
- **S3** 3W export (who does what where) as CSV/GeoJSON with district, municipality, ward, household counts disaggregated by sex and age, matching the fields NGOs already publish in sitreps [35]. Each INGO currently duplicates situation reporting [research note KQ7].
- **S4** Drop centres with "last verified" date and time on every row, a phone number, and automatic demotion of centres unverified for more than N days (P7).
- **S5** Early-warning links: DHM bulletins, the PrakopAlert app, BIPAD, with the honest note that alerts have arrived after the water (38 minutes after the 2026 collapse [30]; "there is no such thing as an early warning system in Nepal" [30]; 2022 SMS alerts reached only areas already affected [90]; seconds matter on the Bhote Koshi [91]). Linking BIPAD confers legitimacy; TikTok already does [38].
- **S6** A pre-templated rumour tracker: the repertoire is stable across 2015-2026 ("bigger disaster coming", "relief hoarded", recycled footage, fake death tolls, fake fund appeals) [26][36]; each entry links the fact-checker's debunk.
- **S7** Multi-disaster model: nothing on the home page is hard-wired to one event; the current disaster is a selectable context with its own bulletin source.

What good looks like: in the first hour of the next flood, the Now strip shows the DHM alert with its SMS time, the official hotline, a "do not trust QR codes" card, and the first checked local item; by day three, the ledger shows deliveries per ward with sources, and an INGO downloads the 3W without asking.

3j. Quiet-months content

The research is clear that relief delivery is not a daily beat and that no Nepali survey covers what readers want from a civic site in Falgun [96]. The ideal's quiet-months answer is drawn from what earns daily habit in this market, utility and evergreen search [56][57], and from what the national survey's authors asked for, localised grassroots content [2].

- **Q1** Evergreen explainers in plain Nepali: how relief works, how to read an NDRRMA bulletin, what a ward office can and cannot do, how to prepare a household for monsoon, what "loss and damage" means (only 49% of households had heard of climate change in 2016 [42]), paired with what wards needed and did not get, the pairing domestic critics ask for [41]. Owner-written explainers carry no news exposure and are the only long-form the ideal keeps.
- **Q2** Local updates (pre-moderated, as decided [95]) as the human layer: a road reopened, a health post's hours, a school closure. This is the content shift from macro-politics that readers and the survey's authors name [2][23].
- **Q3** Ledger and centre status as standing items: "N centres verified this week", "last delivery logged", so the record is seen to be maintained.
- **Q4** Preparedness-season cadence: a weekly card in Jestha-Asar (pre-monsoon) on alerts, hotlines and evacuation routes per district.
- **Q5** What the ideal does not do in quiet months: fill the strip with national politics or wire copy. If there is nothing checked today, the strip says so with yesterday's items and their dates (P7).

Evidence gap: whether a civic record earns a daily check outside disasters is untested in Nepal; RONB's beat (bandas, power cuts) was daily by nature [22]. This is the largest open question in section 6.

3k. Governance, legal posture and monetisation

Requirements:

- **G1** Registration path, as decided: the entity registers with DoIB as the online media outlet; contributors publish under it [95]. The 2025 Press and Publication Rules require a company or firm with PAN/VAT, a named editor with journalism qualification or experience, at least three employees with a written commitment to bank-paid salaries, Rs 5,000 registration and Rs 2,500 annual renewal, and display of registration number, addresses, editor and journalist names and a privacy policy [64][66]. These figures come from eKantipur's reading of the rules and law-firm summaries, not the official text; the decisions doc already says confirm with DoIB directly [95]. Registration is a legal entity and a payroll, not a form [96].
- **G2** Until registered, the public posture is pre-moderated, non-commercial "local updates / local correspondents", with no ads on news-like items [95][96].
- **G3** Press Council jurisdiction follows registration and is, on balance, protective: Freedom Forum argues complaints should go to PCN rather than police under s.47 [78]; PCN's 2026 remedies were mostly rebuttals and corrections [77]. The ideal publishes PCN's code and the 2083 disaster guidelines as its own moderation checklist (V4).
- **G4** ETA Section 47 awareness: electronic publication "contrary to public morality" or spreading hatred by caste/community carries up to 5 years and a fine [67]; it has been used against journalists after complaints from local officials in 2024-2026 [69][68]; the 2025 Social Media Bill was withdrawn in Feb 2026 but the 2023 directive that enabled the platform block still stands [70]. Design consequence: no

user comments, no anonymous public posting, moderation of anything naming an official, and a documented incident procedure.

- **G5** No comments. The 2017 directive makes the operator responsible for comments and obliges it to prevent "vulgar, dishonest or irrelevant" ones [65]; no Nepali-language automated moderation tool exists [research gap]; the Cyber Bureau profiled abusive commenters after the 2026 flood [82]. Public flags (V6) replace comments.
- **G6** Ads only after registration; two labelled slots ("विज्ञापन / Sponsored"), admin-placed image-link items with dates and area [95]; never on disaster items, never animated, never in notifications (P4). Government public-welfare ads additionally require Advertisement Board listing [80]. Readers' sharpest content complaint about RONB is paid posts indistinguishable from news [23].
- **G7** Donations off-site only (T5). The sole ad-free membership experiment in Nepal, The Record, went on extended hiatus in 2022 for financial reasons [63]; Kantipur launched its first digital subscription in Aug 2026, aimed at diaspora [62]. The ideal does not assume reader payment; if diaspora or NGO revenue is ever pursued, it is for the ledger/3W data layer, not for reading.
- **G8** Operational security: CMS and admin accounts are the attack surface (the Ukeraa breach replaced investigative stories with unrelated content [83]); backups allow republication; two-factor on every editor account.
- **G9** Contributor safety: no personal contact details published, pseudonymous public profiles permitted where lawful, no outlet branding on field volunteers during unrest [78].

3l. Accessibility and inclusion

- **A1** WCAG 2.2 AA, the benchmark Nepali auditors now use [53]: skip links, keyboard-operable menus, 4.5:1 contrast, visible focus, 44 px touch targets, labelled forms, HTML-first (no PDF-only notices).
- **A2** `lang="ne"` on Nepali content and `lang="en"` on English so TalkBack selects Dina [52]; government accessibility pages already direct users to install it [research note].
- **A3** Captions on any video; alt text on every image; the hotline bar as real text, not an image.
- **A4** Plain language and audio: 24% of adults and 31% of women cannot read [6]; the daily bulletin is also published as a captioned audio/video card (X7) and every item is TTS-clean (no ASCII art, no Preeti).
- **A5** Madhesh and non-Nepali mother tongues: item-level language (L5/L6), place-name alternates, and a stated intention to add Maithili/Bhojpuri contributors when moderators exist for those languages.
- **A6** Low-end device testing as a release gate: one NPR 13-15k Android (4 GB RAM) and one iPhone, on 4G, for every typography or layout change [12][43].

---

4. Persona scorecard

Personas follow the research notes. The rightmost column lists the requirement IDs from section 3 that answer each pain point.

Persona	Top pain points (evidence)	Ideal-layer requirements that answer them
Consumer (in Nepal, mobile, Facebook-first)	Ads covering half the page, unblockable [13][14]; clickbait headline-body mismatch [19]; nothing local [2]; slow load on cheap Android [17][12]; "which portal to believe" fatigue [21]	P4, F1-F6 (no clutter, fast); I3 (headline = fact); H3, Q2 (locality first, local updates); P1, I4, V2 (provenance and one label)

Persona	Top pain points (evidence)	Ideal-layer requirements that answer them
Diaspora reader (Gulf/Malaysia worker; US/UK/Australia family)	Deceived by YouTube "news" with no way to cross-check locally [25]; wants bite-sized, cross-checkable snippets [24]; reads after shifts in a different time zone [85]; types in Roman Nepali	I1, I5 (short, permanent, citable); D3 (device-local time); L4 (Roman input); X3, X6 (share cards, EN chip); S1 (missing-person search that works cross-script)
Disaster-affected person or family	No centralised missing database [32]; graphic images of the dead shared without warning [26]; relief claimed sent but not arrived [29]; alerts after the water [30]; fake fund appeals and OTP scams [27]	S1 (consent-first missing search), P8 (safe by default), S2 (ward ledger as facts), S5 (early-warning links, honest), T5-T6 (no money, scam warnings), H4 (hotlines everywhere)
Volunteer / donor (incl. NRNA chapters)	Cannot tell which appeal is real [27][28]; cannot see what reached Nepal [40]; 2015 PM-fund opacity remembered [research note KQ3]	T5 (deep-link only to NRB/OPMCM-listed accounts), S2-S3 (ledger and 3W), T3 (audit log), X6 (diaspora distribution)
NGO / local government (ward chair, palika staff, INGO cluster)	Each agency duplicates sitreps [35]; needs ward/household/sex/age fields and export [35]; BIPAD is institution-facing with terminology and metadata gaps [37]; palika staff have phone-and-Facebook skills only [research note KQ8]; only 54 of 753 local levels answered RTI requests [84]; ward chairs contest CDO claims [29]	S3 (3W export in their fields), S2 (ward-level record of deliveries), H3 (palika picker), L4 (Roman input), A1 (works on any phone); the ward-chair hook stays a hypothesis
Publisher / maintainer (one owner plus volunteers)	Zero supply at peak demand [96]; registration needs entity and payroll [64]; sector-wide arrears and closures (2023: 100 outlets closed, 243 journalists quit, all media) [61][81]; dependence on Facebook referrals that vanished for five days in 2025 [58]	H2 (strip fed from ingested data, not prose), G1-G2 (posture until registered), G6-G7 (no revenue assumptions), X2, X4 (owned page, Viber fallback, RSS), G8 (CMS security)
Journalist / correspondent (district stringer, FM host, national desk)	Needs a citable permalink with date and source to confirm a claim [26]; copy-paste culture [research note KQ4]; local officials hostile to accountability reporting, online journalists over half of victims [78]; unpaid for months [81]	I5 (permanent URL, machine-readable dates), V5 (corrections log), X4 (RSS), T7, G9 (safety; no personal details), I6 (byline credit)
Moderator / fact-checker (volunteer; NepalFactCheck, Nepal Check)	Overwhelmed in crises, dozens of checks a year against thousands of claims [60]; recurring repertoire of recycled footage and AI video [26]; friend-approves-friend risk; liability for what passes [71]	V1, V3 (pre-moderation, reviewer rules), V4 (PCN 2083 five-point check on the rule card), S6 (rumour tracker linking debunks), V7 (published capacity), X4 (feed for fact-checkers)
Regulator (DoIB, Press Council, Cyber Bureau)	Unregistered outlets ordered to remove content [77]; gruesome visuals and children's identities after the flood [26] [73]; uncorrected errors [64]; comments and user content as the practical reach of enforcement [82]	G1-G3 (registration path, PCN code as own checklist), P8, V4 (humane-reporting rules built in), P9, V5 (public corrections), G5 (no comments), T2 (registration number displayed)

5. What the ideal deliberately does not do

Not done	Why
Comments	Operator is liable for them under the 2017 directive and must prevent vulgar or dishonest ones [65]; no Nepali-language moderation tooling exists; the Cyber Bureau profiled commenters in 2026 [82]; readers already read comment moderation as censorship [17]. Flags replace comments.
Push notifications and notification ads	Hamro Patro's most-upvoted complaints are ads as push and "constant barrage of irrelevant notifications" [18]. Distribution runs through RSS, the owned page and cards; third parties may build pushes from the feed.

Not done	Why
Dark mode first	Requested in Play reviews [17] but no Nepal evidence it drives trust or return; the council deprioritised it [96]. Honour `prefers-color-scheme` if it costs nothing; do not design for it before the strip, the ledger and the picker exist.
Autoplay video and gruesome thumbnails	Prohibited by PCN 2083 on websites and all platforms [72]; heavy on congested links (F1).
Clickbait and teaser headlines	The measured Nepali complaint [19]; rejected at moderation (I3).
Machine-translated copies	Each item exists in the language it was written in [95]; a machine copy would carry the "Checked" label on words no one checked.
753 empty locality pages	Only localities with a published item are listed anywhere [95]; an empty heading falsifies "verified" on first visit [96].
A national politics feed or wire copy	The complaint readers and survey authors make about incumbents [2][23]; it would also make the site a news portal in substance before registration.
Collecting donations, showing QR codes or wallet numbers	QR codes copying official logos were the main scam vector [27]; deep links to NRB/OPMCM-listed accounts only.
Publishing recipient name lists	Eligibility disputes in Saptari and Jajarkot [39]; publish criteria and counts.
Editorialising about officials or absence of relief	ETA s.47 and criminal defamation have been used after local officials' complaints [69][67]; the ledger records deliveries as facts with sources.
A heavy map, satellite tiles or large JSON on first load	F2; the current site's anti-pattern per the council [96].
Six font weights, Google-hosted	~370 KB of Devanagari before Latin [44]; two self-hosted weights.
Ads before registration, or on disaster items	G6 [95][96].
An AI writer, condolences, an ad-manager role, SSR, Nepali URLs with hreflang	Deferred by the owner or the council until there is content to index and a second person to run ads [95][96].
Owner-authored news	One anonymous person writing news is online journalism with no community check; owner-written evergreen explainers are fine [96].

6. Open questions and evidence gaps

Where the evidence behind this report is thin, the ideal is a hypothesis. In rough order of strategic weight:

1. **The ledger adoption hook rests on one anecdote.** Ward chairs in Amachhodingmo contesting the CDO's "relief already sent" is one Kathmandu Post report [29], and the research note marks "ward chairs would log deliveries" as inference. No interview or survey of ward or municipal officials on using a third-party platform exists. Test with two or three ward chairs before building field workflows.
2. **No post-September-2025 audience survey.** The latest Nepal Media Survey figures reachable are 2024 [2]; nothing quantifies where Nepalis got news after the platform block, the protests and the 2026 flood. The "verify on radio/TV" finding is from 2022 commentary [3].
3. **Reddit evidence is nine threads**, all about Onlinekhabar or ad blocking, retrieved from an archive because Reddit blocks the research environment [13]. Praise for RONB and Hamro Patro comes from

press coverage and Play reviews, not from a representative sample [22][24][18].

4. **No reader data on BS vs AD or Devanagari vs Latin digits.** The recommendation follows what Setopati, eKantipur and Onlinekhabar do [45][46][47]. A plugin vendor's claim that Press Council rules require BS dates is unverified.
5. **Typography numbers come from one agency article** (17-18 px, 1.7-1.8 line height) [43]; no Nepal-specific study of FOUT or line-height preference exists.
6. **Quiet-months demand is untested.** RONB's daily beat was daily by nature; whether a civic record earns a 6-11 pm check in Falgun is unknown (3j).
7. **Trust cues are inferred, not measured.** No experiment shows which visual cue (phone number, ward-chair quote, Nepali language, verifier role) increases belief among Nepali readers; "provenance beats logos" is inferred from fact-checker practice and from scammers' behaviour [26][27].
8. **Registration rules are second-hand.** Fees, editor qualification and the three-employee rule come from eKantipur and law-firm summaries [64][65][66]; the official DoIB schedule was not retrieved; the exact ETA s.47 fine conflicts across sources [67]. Confirm directly, as the decisions doc already says [95].
9. **No Nepali source on consent for missing-person listings or survivors' phone numbers.** P8 and S1 derive from PCN 2083, the UN statement and the Penal Code [72][74][75], not from documented Nepali practice.
10. **Distribution channels lack Nepali data.** No figures on Viber/WhatsApp news sharing, Google Discover share, push opt-in, RSS use or Nepali-language SEO [research note KQ2 gaps]. The Viber fallback follows the 2025 block [58][59], not measured usage.
11. **Diaspora media habits are thin.** A 281-respondent COVID-era Malaysia survey and traffic estimates [85][87]; nothing on Gulf workers' news habits specifically.
12. **Dina TTS adoption and Nepali hate-speech tooling** are undocumented [52]; accessibility requirements rest on law and audits, not on user counts.
13. **No usability study of any Nepali news portal exists** beyond two practitioner case studies [92]; a small structured test of the ideal's Now strip and picker with ten readers (including Madhesh and Gulf participants) would be new evidence.

---

7. References

Research-note URLs are reused verbatim. Local documents are listed at the end.

1. DataReportal, Digital 2026: Nepal (8 Nov 2025). https://datareportal.com/reports/digital-2026-nepal
2. Nepali Times, "What do Nepalis think of the media" (Nepal Media Survey 2024), 27 Dec 2024. https://nepalitimes.com/what-do-nepalis-think-of-the-media
3. Nepali Times, "Surveying Nepal's digital landscape" (NMS 2022), 15 Oct 2023. https://nepalitimes.com/surveying-nepal-s-digital-landscape
4. Nepali Times, "Nepal's interface with information" (NMS 2022 trust and referral figures). https://nepalitimes.com/nepal-s-interface-with-information
5. Spotlight Nepal, "Rethinking formal communications in Nepal's digital era", 1 Aug 2026. https://www.spotlightnepal.com/2026/08/01/rethinking-formal-communications-in-nepals-digital-era-where-should-leaders-speak/
6. Wikipedia, 2021 Nepal census (mother tongue, literacy, province shares). https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/2021_Nepal_census
7. Kathmandu Post (Ujjwal Acharya), "The challenges of misinformation" (CMR Nepal 2024), 23 Jan 2024. https://kathmandupost.com/columns/2024/01/23/the-challenges-of-misinformation
8. NepaliTelecom, internet speed at peak hours (NTA 6-10 pm window). https://www.nepalitelecom.com/internet-speed-at-peak-hours

9. NepaliTelecom, NPIX traffic peaked at 109 Gbps, June 2026. https://www.nepalitelecom.com/2026/06/nepals-internet-traffic-peaked-109-gbps-during-fifa-world-cup-2026-opener.html
10. Statcounter, mobile screen resolution, Nepal. https://gs.statcounter.com/screen-resolution-stats/mobile/nepal
11. Statcounter, mobile OS share, Nepal. https://gs.statcounter.com/os-market-share/mobile/nepal
12. NepaliTelecom, best phones under Rs 15,000 (2026). https://nepalitelecom.com/best-phones-under-rs-15000-in-nepal
13. r/Nepal, "Block ads on OnlineKhabar", Jan 2020. https://www.reddit.com/r/Nepal/comments/enmieo/block_ads_on_onlinekhabar/
14. r/Nepal, "Nepali news website ad remover", Jun 2022. https://www.reddit.com/r/Nepal/comments/vlyat9/nepali_news_website_ad_remover/
15. r/technepal, "Can anyone create adblocker to block ads from Nepali News website", Jun 2021. https://www.reddit.com/r/technepal/comments/nr4qq6/can_anyone_create_adblocker_to_block_ads_from/
16. GitHub, manishgs/nepali-news-portal-ad-blocker. https://github.com/manishgs/nepali-news-portal-ad-blocker
17. Google Play, Onlinekhabar app reviews. https://play.google.com/store/apps/details?id=com.shirantech.onlinekhabar&hl=en_US
18. Google Play, Hamro Patro app reviews. https://play.google.com/store/apps/details?id=com.hamropatro&hl=en_US
19. Dam et al., Gandaki University, Jagriti 2024, clickbait in Nepali digital media (PDF). https://www.gandakiuniversity.edu.np/wp-content/uploads/2024/09/CH6.pdf
20. The Himalayan Times, "Research finds 3.70 per cent misleading news in Nepali media", 26 Jan 2021. https://thehimalayantimes.com/kathmandu/research-finds-3-70-per-cent-misleading-news-in-nepali-media
21. r/Nepal, "Onlinekhabar is plain biased", Sep 2023. https://www.reddit.com/r/Nepal/comments/168v1a4/onlinekhabar_is_plain_biased/
22. Kathmandu Post, "Here's how the popular Routine of Nepal Banda runs", 19 Feb 2020. https://kathmandupost.com/20/2020/02/19/here-s-how-the-popular-routine-of-nepal-banda-runs
23. Kathmandu Post, "What Routine of Nepal Banda gets right and what it gets wrong", 16 Feb 2026. https://kathmandupost.com/national/2026/02/16/what-routine-of-nepal-banda-gets-right-and-what-it-gets-wrong
24. Nepali Times, "RONB's media model, decade in the making", Jul 2022. https://nepalitimes.com/ronbs-media-model-decade-in-the-making
25. Nepal Check, "How false headlines and thumbnails spread misinformation on YouTube in Nepal", 30 Mar 2023. https://nepalcheck.org/2023/03/30/how-false-headlines-and-thumbnails-spread-misinformation-on-youtube-in-nepal/
26. Kathmandu Post, "In disaster aftermath, Nepal battles a flood of misinformation", 31 Aug 2026. https://kathmandupost.com/national/2026/08/31/in-disaster-aftermath-nepal-battles-a-flood-of-misinformation
27. Kathmandu Post, "Nepal Police warn of scams targeting flood relief donations", 27 Aug 2026. https://kathmandupost.com/national/2026/08/27/nepal-police-warn-of-scams-targeting-flood-relief-donations
28. Onlinekhabar English, NRB notice on PM Disaster Relief Fund accounts. https://english.onlinekhabar.com/nrb-m-disaster-relief-fund.html
29. Kathmandu Post, "24 days after flood, hunger grips three Rasuwa wards", 18 Sept 2026. https://kathmandupost.com/health/2026/09/18/24-days-after-flood-hunger-grips-three-rusuwa-wards
30. Kathmandu Post, "Nepal sent its disaster alert 38 minutes after the glacier collapse. It wasn't enough", 2 Sept 2026. https://kathmandupost.com/national/2026/09/02/nepal-sent-its-disaster-alert-38-minutes-after-the-glacier-collapse-it-wasn-t-enough
31. eKantipur, "Neeraj creates Bhotekoshi flood portal with the power of AI", 3 Sept 2026. https://ekantipur.com/technology/2026/09/03/en/neeraj-creates-bhotekoshi-flood-portal-with-the-power-of-ai-58-15.html
32. LinkedIn, Bishal Khadka (volunteer: "no centralized database of people reported missing"). https://np.linkedin.com/in/bishalkhadka
33. Bernama, Nepal Police missing-person lists, Aug 2026. https://www.bernama.com/en/world/news.php?id=2599969
34. AFP via The Star, "Nepal's wall of missing offers last hope after Himalayan flood", 1 Sept 2026. https://www.thestar.com.my/aseanplus/aseanplus-news/2026/09/01/nepal039s-wall-of-missing-offers-last-hope-after-himalayan-flood
35. Nepal Red Cross Society, Rasuwa Situation Update 5 (PDF). https://website-api.nrcs.org/media/highlights/files/Rasuwa_Situation_Update_5.pdf
36. World Bank, "Harnessing the power of the crowd" (QuakeMap figures), 27 Oct 2015. https://www.worldbank.org/en/news/feature/2015/10/27/harnessing-the-power-of-the-crowd-reflections-six-months-after-the-gorkha-earthquake-in-nepal
37. PreventionWeb, "Standardization of loss and damage datasets on BIPAD". https://www.preventionweb.net/quick/50881
38. Technology Khabar, TikTok monsoon guide linking BIPAD, July 2025. https://www.technologykhabar.com/?p=207589
39. Kathmandu Post via Asia News Network, "Over 458 flood-affected families in Nepal's Saptari left without promised aid", Oct 2024. https://asianews.network/over-458-flood-affected-families-in-nepals-saptari-left-without-promised-aid/
40. Onlinekhabar English, UK diaspora relief collections, 4 Sept 2026. https://english.onlinekhabar.com/?p=588994
41. Annapurna Express (Prakash Bhattarai), loss and damage and ward-level lists, 9 Sept 2026. https://theannapurnaexpress.com/story/66973/

42. Open Data Nepal, National Climate Change Impact Survey 2016. https://opendatanepal.com/dataset/national-climate-change-impact-survey
43. WebsNP, "Nepali Unicode and Devanagari Typography on the Web". https://www.websnp.com/help/nepali-unicode-fonts-website-typography
44. Google Fonts CSS2 API, Devanagari subset sizes (measured 2026-10-14). https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Noto+Sans+Devanagari:wght@400&display=swap
45. Setopati homepage (BS masthead, DoI registration number; measured 2026-10-14). https://www.setopati.com/
46. eKantipur homepage (BS masthead, "धेरै पढिएका"; measured 2026-10-14). https://ekantipur.com/
47. Onlinekhabar homepage (relative times "११ घण्टा अगाडि"; measured 2026-10-14). https://www.onlinekhabar.com/
48. Hamro Patro, Nepali Keyboard (Romanized transliteration layouts). https://www.hamropatro.com/en/apps/nepali-keyboard
49. ICANN neobrahmigp list, Nepali/Newar LGR and spelling norms. https://lists.icann.org/hyperkitty/list/neobrahmigp@icann.org/thread/JRROYZX6VPIMMK4SK6PI6JZ7SNFKE3L6/
50. ACL Anthology, CHiPSAL 2026, Romanized Nepali prevalence online. https://aclanthology.org/2026.chipsal-1.12/
51. W3C, Indic Layout Requirements (Working Draft). https://www.w3.org/TR/ilreq/
52. UNICEF Nepal, launch of Dina (दिना) Nepali text-to-speech voice, 3 Dec 2024. https://www.unicef.org/nepal/press-releases/unicef-and-atscale-launch-nepali-text-speech-digital-voice-dina-%E0%A4%A6%E0%A4%BF%E0%A4%A8%E0%A4%BE-enhance
53. Internet Society, DoIT portal accessibility audit (WCAG 2.2 AA), 2026. https://news.internetsociety.org/?p=37907
54. Republica, government websites and the MoCIT accessibility directive. https://myrepublica.nagariknetwork.com/news/all-govt-websites-now-made-accessibility-friendly-90-67.html
55. Similarweb, onlinekhabar.com (Sept 2026 data). https://www.similarweb.com/website/onlinekhabar.com/
56. Similarweb, hamropatro.com (Sept 2026 data). https://www.similarweb.com/website/hamropatro.com/
57. Ratopati English, Hamro Patro remittance passes Rs 100 million in a month, 6 Jun 2022. https://english.ratopati.com/story/24734/hamro-patro-remittance-100-million-one-month
58. TechCrunch, "Nepal blocks Facebook, Instagram, YouTube, X over rule breach", 4 Sept 2025. https://techcrunch.com/2025/09/04/nepal-blocks-facebook-instagram-youtube-x-over-rule-breach-amid-censorship-concerns
59. NepaliTelecom, Nepal Telecom Viber community during the block, Sept 2025. https://www.nepalitelecom.com/2025/09/nepal-telecom-viber-community-contact-for-grievances.html
60. CMR-Nepal / NepalFactCheck.org, "Misinformation during the Gen Z Uprising in Nepal" (PDF), Oct 2025. https://research.butmedia.org/wp-content/uploads/2025/10/GenZ_Protest_Misinformation_Report.pdf
61. The Himalayan Times, "Nepali media faces sustainability crisis, says report" (Freedom Forum 2023 data), 2 Jan 2024. https://thehimalayantimes.com/kathmandu/nepali-media-faces-sustainability-crisis-says-report
62. Kathmandu Post, "Note from Group Editorial Director" (Kantipur One subscription), 25 Aug 2026. https://kathmandupost.com/opinion/2026/08/25/note-from-group-editorial-director
63. The Record, "A message from the founders" (extended hiatus), Jul 2022. https://recordnepal.com/a-message-from-the-founders-of-the-record
64. eKantipur, "Online media registration fees: regulating or curbing freedom" (2025 Press and Publication Rules), 9 Nov 2025. https://ekantipur.com/news/2025/11/09/en/online-media-registration-fees-regulating-or-curbing-freedom-15-27.html
65. AHN Legal, "Online media regulation in Nepal" (2017 Directive summary). https://www.ahnlegal.com/legal-updates/legal/online-media-regulation-in-nepal
66. Lawalpine, "Online media registration in Nepal" (2026). https://lawalpine.com/blog/online-media-registration-in-nepal
67. Setopati English, Electronic Transactions Act Section 47 text and penalties. https://en.setopati.com/political/165095
68. Article 19 / Media Action Nepal, UPR submission on Nepal (PDF), 2025. https://www.article19.org/wp-content/uploads/2026/01/UPR-Nepal-7.2025-A19_MAN.pdf
69. CPJ, Nepali journalists Aishwarya Kunwar and Puskar Bhatt arrested under cybercrime law, Feb 2024. https://cpj.org/2024/02/nepali-journalists-aishwarya-kunwar-puskar-bhatt-arrested-under-cybercrime-law/
70. Kathmandu Post, "Government moves to withdraw Social Media Bill", 7 Feb 2026. https://kathmandupost.com/national/2026/02/07/government-moves-to-withdraw-social-media-bill
71. Asia News Network / Kathmandu Post, Sidhakura contempt sentences, Sept 2024. https://asianews.network/?p=168780
72. eKantipur, Press Council Nepal "Editorial Guidelines for Humane and Responsible Disaster Reporting, 2083" (English summary), 4 Sept 2026. https://ekantipur.com/news/2026/09/04/en/clear-disclosure-is-required-when-using-ai-generated-symbolic-imagery-04-46.html
73. Republica, Minister Timilsina urges media to protect dignity and privacy of Bhotekoshi flood-affected children. https://myrepublica.nagariknetwork.com/news/minister-timilsina-urges-media-to-protect-dignity-privacy-of-bhotekoshi-flo-12-87.html
74. The Himalayan Times, UN in Nepal statement on Rasuwa flood coverage and missing-person photos, Sept 2026. https://thehimalayantimes.com/ampArticle/1040196
75. National Penal Code 2074, Section 295 (photographs without consent). https://nepallaws.com/Laws/the-national-penal-code-act-2074/part-3-offences-against-individual-privacy-and-prestige/chapter-1-offences-against-privacy/section-295-prohibition-of-taking-or-disfiguring-photograph-of-any-person-without-his-or-her-consent/

76. Pioneer Law, Individual Privacy Act 2018 (2075). https://pioneerlaw.com/individual-privacy-act-2018-2075
77. eKantipur, "163 complaints registered with Press Council in 6 months", 22 Jan 2026. https://ekantipur.com/news/2026/01/22/en/163-complaints-registered-with-press-council-in-6-months-48-41.html
78. Freedom Forum, Annual Press Freedom Report 2026 (news 840). https://freedomforum.org.np/news/detail/840
79. Freedom Forum, online harassment survey of 100 journalists (news 674), Jul 2022. https://freedomforum.org.np/news/detail/674
80. Ratopati English, Advertisement Board listing required for public-welfare ads, 2026. https://english.ratopati.com/story/77190/newspapers-that-do-not-list-and-renew-their-advertising-on-the-advertisement-board-will-not-receive-public-welfare-advertising-funds
81. Kathmandu Post, "Nepali media is fighting for survival; its journalists are fighting for their paychecks", 15 Apr 2026. https://kathmandupost.com/money/2026/04/15/nepali-media-is-fighting-for-survival-its-journalists-are-fighting-for-their-paychecks
82. Kathmandu Post, "Nepal moves against online abuse targeting flood victims", 7 Sept 2026. https://kathmandupost.com/national/2026/09/07/nepal-moves-against-online-abuse-targeting-flood-victims
83. Freedom Forum, Ukeraa CMS breach (news 692), Dec 2024. https://www.freedomforum.org.np/news/detail/692
84. Republica, complaints filed against 699 information officers (RTI, 54 of 753 local levels responded). https://myrepublica.nagariknetwork.com/news/complaints-filed-against-699-officials-not-providing-information
85. Nepali Times (Upasana Khadka), "From letters to landlines, phones to Facebook", 17 Aug 2020. https://nepalitimes.com/from-letters-to-landlines-phones-to-facebook
86. B360 Nepal, remittance inflows FY 2025/26 (NRB). https://www.b360nepal.com/detail/29887/remittance-inflows-to-nepal-surge-371-pc-to-over-rs-2363bn-in-fy-202526-nrb
87. Semrush, onlinekhabar.com overview (traffic by country). https://www.semrush.com/website/onlinekhabar.com/overview/
88. Nepali Times, "Nepalis are drifting to digital media" (NMS 2019; radio bulletin habit), 12 Apr 2019. https://nepalitimes.com/nepalis-are-drifting-to-digital-media
89. Nieman Reports, "Nepal's Gen Z protests", 19 Sept 2025. https://niemanreports.org/nepal-gen-z-protests-memes-discord-revolution-oli-one-piece/
90. Kathmandu Post column, "Nepal floods: a preventable disaster", 5 Aug 2025. https://kathmandupost.com/columns/2025/08/05/nepal-floods-a-preventable-disaster
91. PreventionWeb, "Nepal's devastating floods: 10 seconds could save lives". https://www.preventionweb.net/news/nepals-devastating-floods-10-seconds-could-save-lives
92. Nikita Chaudhary, Medium, Koshionline UX/UI redesign case study, Jul 2021. https://nikita-design.medium.com/case-study-ux-ui-redesign-of-nepali-news-portal-koshionline-dd5581c22f97
93. eKantipur, "Female journalists hit by trolling and doxxing", 2 Jan 2026. https://ekantipur.com/news/2026/01/02/en/female-journalists-hit-by-trolling-and-doxxing-06-12.html
94. NepaliTelecom, commentary on DataReportal 2026 (voice/SMS-only connections), May 2026. https://www.nepalitelecom.com/2026/05/only-56-percent-use-intermet-in-nepal-sharp-reality-vs-expection-in-datareportal-figures.html

Local documents:

95. `docs/NEWS-PORTAL-DECISIONS.md` (owner decisions, updated 2026-10-14): storage, scope, pre-moderation, per-item language, reporter role, public naming, display tiers, ads, rollout, empty localities, build order, DoIB note.
96. `docs/public-audit-2026-10/council-verdict.md` (2026-10-14), with `council-question.md`, `council-advisors.md`, `council-reviews.md`: the "checked record" reframe, Phase 0-3 sequence, blind spots, and the factual corrections honoured in this report.
97. `docs/public-audit-2026-10/research_notes/Nepali online news audience/verified_nepal_public_site_inventory.md`: current-site inventory, used only as background.

PART 3 OF 3

How far Verified Nepal's public site is aligned with the ideal Nepali public-information portal

Date: 2026-10-14 (असोज २८, २०८३). Scope: the signed-out public surfaces of verifiednepal.com. `/desk`, `/org`, `/me` internals and admin tabs are excluded except where they change what a reader sees. Repo state: `main` at `80b04f2`. Live checks: https://verifiednepal.com and https://api.prod.verifiednepal.com, 2026-10-14 morning NPT.

Primary source: `research_notes/Nepali online news audience/verified_nepal_public_site_inventory.md` (the inventory). Audience and publisher facts come from the other six research notes in the same folder. The "ideal" per layer follows the layer list agreed for this audit (Report 2 had not been written when this report was drafted, so layer definitions are stated inline). The council's position is taken from `council-verdict.md`; the owner's decisions from `docs/NEWS-PORTAL-DECISIONS.md` (2026-10-14).

Reports 1 and 2 did not exist in `reports/` at drafting time; persona names follow the brief.

---

1. Executive summary

Verified Nepal is a well-built bilingual, mobile-first **disaster-response and mutual-aid utility** whose trust skeleton (hotlines on every page, mandatory `Source:` lines, Live/Snapshot badge, public masked ledger, audit log and 3W export, "never handles money", a 23-section bilingual privacy page, an accessibility bar) is better than what the research found on any mainstream Nepali portal. It is **not yet** a public-information portal in the sense the research describes, for three reasons that compound. First, supply is zero: on 2026-10-14 the production API returns `{"items":[]}` for dispatches (articles), stories, projects, centres, incidents **and the ledger**, and the audit log is empty for August, September and October 2026; every reading and transparency surface renders an empty state. Second, the home page is frozen on the 26 August 2026 Rasuwa–Bhote Koshi flood (bundled NDRRMA snapshot `synced_at 2026-08-29`, drop centres `last_verified 2026-09-08`) under a status bar that says "Live · updated 08:23". Third, the site is built as a destination for English-default readers of articles, whereas the Nepali audience discovers on Facebook, verifies on radio/TV, reads in Nepali with Bikram Sambat dates, shares on WhatsApp/Viber, and asks a local question ("does my palika have X?") rather than browsing a feed. None of the three is a design-system or code-quality problem; the code splits routes lazily, enforces EN/NE key parity and ships real 404s. They are positioning, freshness and distribution problems, and they are cheap to start fixing.

Figure 12. What the production site returned on 14 October 2026

0	0	0	0	0	0	0
Articles	Stories	Projects	Drop centres	Incidents	Ledger rows	Audit entries

Production API checks recorded in Part 3. The audit log was empty for August, September and October 2026. Only the article page screenshot in the gallery comes from the development host.

#	Layer	Alignment	One-line reason
1	Home / "Now" surface	**Not aligned**	Task hub hard-wired to one August flood; no dated "latest" at all; "Live" label over a six-week-old snapshot
2	Item model	**Partly**	Articles have byline, place, sources, tags; no `happenedAt`, locality, language chip; article-shaped not item-shaped; zero published
3	Verification and moderation display	**Partly**	Badges exist and say what they mean in code, but "Verified" is used in five senses and articles carry no checked-label
4	Language, script and input	**Partly**	Full EN/NE key parity and `<html lang>`; but English default, English-only raw HTML/OG, no Nepali URL, cross-script search returns nothing
5	Dates, numbers, time	**Not aligned**	Devanagari digits yes; Gregorian only, absolute only, no BS, no relative time
6	Performance and data cost	**Partly**	Good code-splitting and offline shell; 229 KB entry JS, 0.5–0.9 MB Google Fonts, SW precaches 124 files incl. 1.5 MB JSON on first visit
7	Distribution	**Not aligned**	No RSS, no Viber, no owned Facebook page, no `article:published_time`, www not redirected, only home page indexed
8	Trust and transparency	**Partly**	Strong provenance on data; operator is "a single private individual", no masthead, no corrections policy, GOVERNANCE unlinked
9	Disaster-specific surfaces	**Partly**	Best-in-class hotlines, find-person, poster, drop centres, flood explorer; single-flood hard-wiring, stale centres, search contradiction
10	Quiet-months content	**Absent**	Nothing answers "why open this in Falgun"; `/articles` is empty and climate-framed
11	Governance, legal and monetisation	**Partly**	No ads, no money handling, privacy page; no DoIB statement, no corrections log, no public moderation rules, comments wisely absent
12	Accessibility and inclusion	**Aligned** (with gaps)	a11y bar, 44 px targets, focus rings, reduced motion, native selects; English skip link, no TTS/audio, Madhesh languages unaddressed

Figure 13. Alignment by layer: one aligned, seven partly, three not aligned, one absent



* Aligned with gaps: no audio or text-to-speech, an English skip link, Madhesh languages not addressed.

Judgement from the layer-by-layer audit that follows. Colour is paired with a word in every row.

2. Scorecard by layer

2.1 Home / "Now" surface

Ideal requirement. The first screen answers "what is confirmed right now, and what does it mean where I live?": Nepali by default, today's BS date, three to five short dated and sourced items, the hotline bar, one tap to share. The research's praised model is Routine of Nepal Banda (short, verified-before-posting, 6–7 lines) checked at the 6–11 pm peak (audience note Q7; traction note KQ3).

What Verified Nepal does today. `/` is a task hub (`src/pages/home.tsx:51-224`): hero eyebrow "Disaster response across Nepal", h1 "Community-verified disaster response for Nepal", lead "verifiedNepal is a community-verified disaster response coordination platform for Nepal. It is designed to make response information easy to scan while keeping individual records behind an explicit name search." (`src/i18n/shell.ts:11`, Nepali at `:109`: "नेपालका लागि समुदायबाट प्रमाणित विपद् प्रतिक्रिया"). Then five action cards, a blue band "Drop off flood relief goods" with a pulsing live dot and "16 relief centers" from bundled JSON (`:82-125`), a "Satellite view · Trishuli flash flood" CTA, the `SituationBand` of four NDRRMA counters with "Source: NDRRMA — Government of Nepal / Updated ", a district relief map (Leaflet), "Latest official update" (three OPMCM items linked off-site, green "Verified" badge, `:440-466`), a stories strip that renders nothing when empty (`:380`, the prod state), hotlines, PMDRF notice, chat CTA. The only "latest" content is the NDRRMA counters and three external OPMCM links; no article, incident or project headline ever appears on `/` (inventory §2). The status bar reads "Live · updated 08:23" while the bundled snapshot is `public/data/meta.json synced_at 2026-08-29T19:32:46Z`; an `edition.ts` dateline helper exists but is unused on `/`.

Gap. No dated "Now" strip, no BS dateline, no disaster switcher (the multi-disaster model in `src/lib/incidents.ts` drives `/projects`, `/coverage`, `/get-help` but not `/`), English default, and a hero paragraph written for a product reviewer rather than a shopkeeper. The `NEWS-PORTAL-DECISIONS.md` "Now" strip and "Your area" block are decided but unbuilt.

Severity for the Nepali reader: High. The site competes for the verification role; a stale page labelled "Live" is the opposite of the provenance-and-timestamp trust marker the disaster note (KQ4) identifies as what actually persuades.

Evidence. `home-360x740.png`, `home-1280x800.png`; inventory §2; `src/lib/live.ts:130-160`; `public/data/meta.json`.

2.2 Item model

Ideal requirement. The unit of content is a short item with place (down to ward), `happenedAt`, source link, language, author/role, and status; permanent URL so a Facebook post or FM host can cite it (council verdict, "Nepali-first, dated, sourced, short, shareable").

What Verified Nepal does today. Articles (`DISPATCH`) carry `title` / `body` as string or `{en, ne}`, `author.displayName` and `author.place`, up to three of seven fixed tags (climate, mountains, floods, landslides, glaciers, community, story; `src/lib/api.ts:1598`), `publishedAt`, a cover with **required** `source`, and body blocks where every media block requires a `source` (`src/articles/types.ts:9-17`; rendered `src/articles/render.tsx:17-26` as "Source: …", visible in `article-dev-360x740.png`). Detail pages have

real 404s (`functions/articles/[id].ts:20`) and `Article` JSON-LD. Stories are photo/video plus caption, no timestamp, no detail page, home strip only (inventory §3b). Incidents have `startedAt`, districts, optional source attribution and a PNG share card (`src/pages/incidents.tsx:21-105`).

Gap. No `kind`, `locality`, `happenedAt`, `expiresAt`, `sourceUrls[]` or language chip (all specified in `NEWS-PORTAL-DECISIONS.md` build-order step 1, none in `src/lib/api.ts`). The seven tags are a climate-magazine taxonomy, and `/articles` describes itself as "Moderated community writing on mountains and climate — editorial, not a forum." (Nepali: "हिमाल र जलवायुबारे सम्पादित सामुदायिक लेखन — फोरम होइन।"). `inLanguage` is hard-coded `"en"` in the JSON-LD. Zero items published on prod.

Severity: High. The pain-points note (KQ3) names "almost no local (palika) content" as a structural complaint; the article model has no place field finer than a free-text author place.

Evidence. inventory §3a–§3d; `src/lib/api.ts:1609-1634` ; `src/pages/dispatches.tsx:140-180` ; live `GET /dispatches → {"items":[]}` .

2.3 Verification and moderation display

Ideal requirement. One word for "from an official source", one word for "we checked it", shown on every item with a dated provenance line; a public description of how checking works; a corrections notice when something changes (PCN 2083; disaster note KQ4).

What Verified Nepal does today. Each badge is honest in isolation: the green "Verified" on OPMCM items means "official source" (`home.tsx:490`); "Verified records" is NDRRMA's own count; project committees show "Verified"/"Not verified" after a moderator phone call (`project-detail.tsx:131-132`); "Verified incidents" are admin-approved reports; organisations have trust tiers. The reader-facing explanation lives on `/how-to` ("The one rule: verification comes before visibility", `src/i18n/how-to.ts:26`). Articles themselves show no checked-label; the only signal is the list lead "Moderated community writing...".

Gap. Five senses of one word (inventory §8). No per-item "how this was checked" line, no corrections or edit-history line in the UI (only `dateModified` in JSON-LD), no visible link to `docs/MODERATION-GUIDELINES.md` . The owner has since decided pre-moderation with "Checked" semantics for local updates; nothing public reflects it yet.

Severity: High. With ~8% trust in online portals and 67% weekly misinformation exposure (audience note Q5), the brand's single promise must be legible on every item.

Evidence. inventory §8; `docs/DESIGN-GUIDELINES.md` §1.3.

2.4 Language, script and input

Ideal requirement. Nepali first for a 44.9%-Nepali-mother-tongue, 76% literate audience (women 69%); Roman-Nepali input accepted and normalised; language reflected in URL/metadata so shares and search engines see Nepali (UI/UX note §3; audience note Q3).

What Verified Nepal does today. 27 i18n files with enforced key parity (e.g. `src/i18n/index.ts` 655/655), `<html lang>` mirrored to the toggle (`src/App.tsx:181-197`), the header toggle shows the other language's name ("नेपाली"/"English"). Devanagari digits via `Intl.NumberFormat('ne-NP')` . Person search folds diacritics and accepts Devanagari or Latin (`find-person.tsx:21-93`).

Gap. Default language is `en` (`localStorage` default); pre-hydration HTML, server-side titles, descriptions and OG are English-only (`src/lib/og-meta.ts:97-210`); no `/ne/`, `?lang=` or `hreflang`; no Nepali language chip per item; cross-script search returns nothing ("ram bahadur" in Roman does not match a Devanagari record; `docs/CONTRIBUTOR-TODO.md` §2); GOVERNANCE and the five PDF guides are English only; chat widget greeting English only. Nothing addresses Maithili/Bhojpuri/Tharu readers or Madhesh (20% online-news use vs 70% Gandaki).

Severity: High. A Gulf worker typing a relative's name in Roman letters on the one page he needs gets zero results.

Evidence. inventory §4, §9; `src/App.tsx:181-197`; `index.html` `<html lang="en">`.

2.5 Dates, numbers, time

Ideal requirement. BS date in Devanagari digits in the masthead ("बुधबार, असोज २८, २०८३"), relative time on teasers ("११ घण्टा अगाडि"), Gregorian in machine metadata, lakh/crore grouping (UI/UX note §2).

What Verified Nepal does today. `formatDateTime` is a 42-line `Intl.DateTimeFormat('en-GB'|'ne-NP', …, timeZone:'Asia/Kathmandu') + " NPT"` (`src/lib/format-date.ts:16-28`). EN renders "06 Sept 2026, 18:29 NPT"; NE renders Devanagari digits on a Gregorian calendar ("२०२६ अगस्ट ३०, ०१:१७ NPT"). `formatNumber` yields "६,६३३". `<time dateTime>` is used on article lists.

Gap. No Bikram Sambat anywhere (`grep -r "Bikram\|BS " src` → none; the only BS string is inside a data title, "(10 Bhadra 2083)"); no relative time; "NPT" untranslated; `/climate` numbers use the browser locale rather than the site language (`climate.tsx:24-27`).

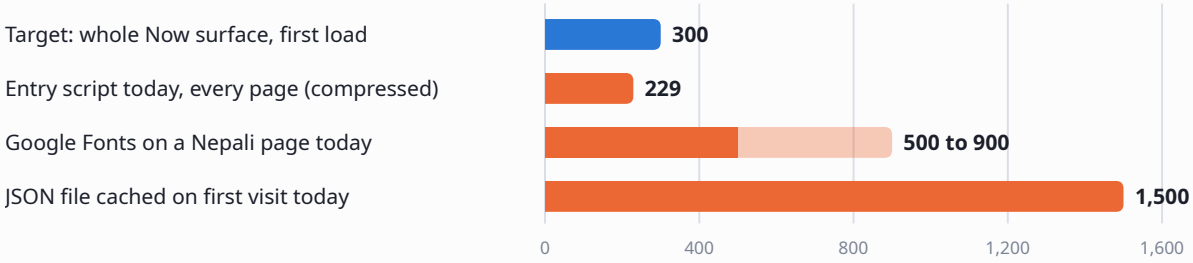
Severity: Medium. It does not block use, but a Nepali page with "२०२६ अगस्ट" reads as a translated English site, and every Nepali portal in the research leads with BS.

Evidence. inventory §3a, §4; `src/lib/format-date.ts`.

2.6 Performance and data cost

Ideal requirement. First paint under a few hundred KB on a 360×800 Android over 4G; one or two Devanagari weights self-hosted (38–62 KB each); nothing heavy downloaded speculatively (UI/UX note §1, §4; pain-points KQ2 "speed").

Figure 14. First-visit weight today against the proposed budget, in kilobytes



Site inventory, 14 October 2026; budget from Part 2, requirement F1. The items are not additive: they arrive at different moments of a first visit.

What Verified Nepal does today. Vite + React 18, every route except `/` lazy (`src/App.tsx:31-63`); MapLibre loaded only on `/flood-impact`; images lazy on lists; no third-party analytics; chat widget deferred and skipped on `saveData`/2G (`chat-widget.ts:261-278`); offline shell with an outbox for need

submissions. Measured: HTML 4.5 KB, entry JS 229 KB brotli on every page, CSS 12 KB, Leaflet ~43 KB gz plus Esri raster tiles on home.

Gap. Google Fonts: Noto Sans and Noto Sans Devanagari at four weights each, up to ~0.5–0.9 MB on a Nepali page, not self-hosted, not precached (`index.html:28-34`). Service worker precaches 124 entries on first visit, including the 1.5 MB `rescued-persons.json` and climate geo/time-series (`vite.config.ts:53` glob `**/*.{js,css,html,svg,png,woff2,json}`). Hashed assets cached only 4 h, not immutable. No `srcset` /image variants (`docs/onlyutils-media-variants-requirement.md`). No Lighthouse/CWV data exists.

Severity: Medium. Data is cheap by volume (1.1 GB/Rs 50) so cost bites less than latency; but a multi-MB background download on first visit, on a 4 GB-RAM phone, is exactly the "slow" complaint in the Onlinekhabar app threads.

Evidence. inventory §5; `dist/` chunk table; live `sw.js` .

2.7 Distribution

Ideal requirement. The site wins as the citation target, not the destination: share cards with the badge baked in, Viber and WhatsApp buttons, an owned Facebook page posting at 6–9 pm, RSS for aggregators and fact-checkers, `article:published_time` / `NewsArticle` for Google, `hreflang` for the Nepali edition (traction note KQ1–KQ2; council "Blind spots").

What Verified Nepal does today. Per-route OG images (`src/lib/og-meta.ts:97-210`), `Article` JSON-LD, WhatsApp + Facebook + Copy + Print on articles (`dispatch-detail.tsx:242-268`), PNG share cards on incidents, climate, our-message and drop centres (`src/components/share-button.tsx`), Web Share for posters with four download formats, canonicals on the apex, real 404s, a sitemap Function with `lastmod` , `robots.txt` , `llms.txt` .

Gap. `/feed.xml` and `/rss.xml` return the SPA shell with HTTP 200 (re-checked 2026-10-14). No Viber, Telegram, X or email share. No `article:published_time` , `article:author` , `NewsArticle` , breadcrumbs, `hreflang` . `Organization.sameAs` lists only GitHub; footer links are GitHub, OnlyUtils and `mailto:verifiednepal01@gmail.com` ; no Facebook page, YouTube or Viber community. `www.verifiednepal.com` serves 200 without redirecting (re-checked). `docs/SEO-ACTION-PLAN.md` records only the home page indexed and the sitemap never submitted. `llms.txt` still describes a single-flood dashboard.

Severity: High. Facebook reaches ~90% of Nepali internet users and 69–83% of big-portal traffic is direct/dark social; a site with no feed, no page and no Viber button is invisible on the surfaces where Nepalis actually find news.

Evidence. inventory §7; `index.html:36-61` ; `functions/sitemap.xml.ts` .

2.8 Trust and transparency

Ideal requirement. Provenance on every claim (original source, timestamp, bulletin number), a named responsible party or legal shell, public moderation rules, a corrections log, registration details where applicable (disaster note KQ4; publisher note KQ1; UI/UX note §8).

What Verified Nepal does today. This is the site's strongest layer on the data side: `SituationBand` "Source: NDRRMA — Government of Nepal · Updated " plus "Figures may change as official records are updated."; `LiveStatusBadge` tooltip "Live data is not available yet; showing the bundled snapshot, which

may be stale."; `/info` note "The timestamp shown on each page is the mirror sync time, not a claim that the source updated at that moment."; drop-centres disclaimer "Independently compiled from Nepali government notices, news reporting and a social-media-organized citizen relief effort. Not an official government source…" (`drop-centers.tsx:132`); climate page with Zenodo DOI and licence; mandatory `Source:` on every article media block; public masked `/ledger` with CSV "for journalists and researchers", `/audit` monthly moderator log, `/coverage` with CSV/GeoJSON 3W export; "VerifiedNepal never handles donations" plus the police fake-QR warning; a 23-section EN/NE `/privacy`.

Gap. `/privacy` §1: "verifiedNepal is a non-commercial, volunteer project maintained by a single private individual (the 'Maintainer')." No masthead, editor, address, phone or legal entity. `docs/GOVERNANCE.md` and `docs/MODERATION-GUIDELINES.md` are not linked or rendered anywhere public (`grep -r` → none outside the Desk). No corrections policy or log, no editorial policy page, no report button on articles/incidents, no DoIB/Press Council statement. And, as of 2026-10-14, the transparency surfaces are themselves empty on prod: `GET /ledger → {"items":[]}`; `GET /audit?month=2026-08|09|10 → {"items":[]}`; `/coverage` requires an incident id and `/incidents` returns none. The ledger is a real asset in code, not yet in public evidence.

Severity: High. "Verified by whom?" is the Outsider's question and the reader's; a Facebook page at least has a name and a comment thread.

Evidence. inventory §8; `src/pages/privacy.tsx:12-16`; live API checks above.

2.9 Disaster-specific surfaces

Ideal requirement. Hotlines always visible; missing-person search with consent and trauma safeguards (no faces of the dead, verified photos, pull resolved listings); relief-point directory with last-verified dates; needs → offers → delivery tracked by ward; multi-disaster from day one; switch disasters without a redeploy (disaster note KQ2–KQ3, KQ8; publisher note KQ2).

What Verified Nepal does today. Emergency bar on every page ("In danger? 1234 · Police 100 · Ambulance 102"), full hotline tiles on `/`, `/info` and `/missing`; `/search` over NDRRMA rescued and missing lists, deliberately `noindex` and robots-disallowed for privacy; `/missing` seven-step family guide; `/poster` builder with tip form; `/drop-centers` with map, filters, directions and "Last verified: 2026-09-08"; `/get-help` and `/give-help` with reference-code status; `/coverage` ward table; `/drones` tasking board; `/flood-impact` MapLibre before/after corridor drive with `?loc=` deep links and imagery credit. This is more than any Nepali portal or the state offered in August (disaster note KQ2: "no centralised missing-persons database at the outset").

Gap. Home is hard-wired to one flood (NDRRMA rescues API, bundled centres event string, flood CTA). Drop-centre API items are empty on prod, so only the 16 bundled centres from 2026-09-08 show. `/search` lead says "verifiedNepal shows aggregate rescue and missing-person status only. To search for a specific person by name, use the official OPMCM lost & found portal…" directly above a "Search by name" box (`find-person-360x740.png`). Cross-script search returns nothing. `src/lib/helplines.ts:1-6` admits Fire 101 "lacked a reachable primary source at verification time".

Severity: High during an event, Medium now. These are the pages a disaster-affected reader opens; a contradiction on the search page and five-week-old centres cost trust at exactly the moment it matters.

Evidence. inventory §1, §3f, §9; `src/pages/find-person.tsx`; `src/data/relief-centers.json`.

2.10 Quiet-months content

Ideal requirement. A reason to open the site in Falgun: evergreen explainers (how relief works, how to read an NDRRMA bulletin, how to use the ledger), the standing status of past disasters' recovery, and a daily or weekly cadence that does not depend on a flood (council "Blind spots"; Review 4).

What Verified Nepal does today. `/how-to` (long illustrated guide), `/missing` guide, `/info`, `/climate` (static dataset, "Nepal didn't heat the planet. Nepal pays for it." / "पृथ्वी नेपालले तताएको होइन। मूल्य भने नेपालले चुकाइरहेको छ।"), `/our-message` (English word cloud of pre-set slogans sent to a chosen country), `/flood-impact` (the only unique, non-empty reading surface).

Gap. Nothing dated, nothing recurring. `/articles` is empty and framed as a climate magazine; `/our-message` has no explanation of why it is on a disaster site and its word cloud is English even in Nepali mode; only ~49% of households had heard of "climate change" as a concept (2016), so the loss-and-damage framing is an elite register (disaster note KQ6). No "what happened to Rasuwa since" page, no recovery tracker, no archive by date.

Severity: Medium. Not fatal today, but it is the difference between a bookmark and a one-time visit; RONB's moat is a daily habit.

Evidence. inventory §3e–§3f; `our-message-360x740.png`; `src/i18n/climate.ts:7`.

2.11 Governance, legal and monetisation

Ideal requirement. A clear legal posture (registered outlet with editor and staff, or explicitly non-journalistic mutual aid), public moderation rules, corrections, no comments without moderator capacity (2017 directive makes the operator liable), labelled ads only after registration, no money handled (publisher note KQ1, KQ6; traction note KQ5, KQ8).

What Verified Nepal does today. No ad slots (`grep -ri "advert\|sponsor\|विज्ञापन" src` → no UI matches); no comments anywhere; all donate CTAs go off-site to the PMDRF gateway; project pages show committee bank/eSewa/Khalti details for direct payment; "Powered by OnlyUtils" is the only sponsor credit; `/privacy` names governing law (Nepal, Individual Privacy Act 2075). The owner has decided (2026-10-14) that VerifiedNepal itself will register with DoIB, that local updates will be pre-moderated, and that ad slots are build-order step 4.

Gap. No DoIB or Press Council statement on the site, no registration number, no editor name (the 2025 rules require these to be displayed once registered). No corrections policy or log, which PCN 2083 and the DoIB display rules both expect. GOVERNANCE and MODERATION-GUIDELINES unlinked. Note that the inventory (§3c, §8) still describes post-moderation labels and "a Nepali media lawyer's opinion"; both are superseded by the decisions doc and should not be relied on.

Severity: Medium today, High once anything called "news" or any ad ships. The current posture (pre-moderated, non-commercial, "local updates", no comments, no money) is the defensible one until the entity exists.

Evidence. inventory §8, §11; `docs/NEWS-PORTAL-DECISIONS.md` "DoIB note"; publisher note KQ1.

2.12 Accessibility and inclusion

Ideal requirement. MoCIT 2021 directive (responsive, disability-friendly, Nepali Unicode + English), WCAG 2.2 AA as referenced in the 2026 DoIT audit, TalkBack-friendly markup now that Dina Nepali TTS exists, plain language and audio for low-literacy readers (UI/UX note §6).

What Verified Nepal does today. "Aa" accessibility bar with five font-size steps and high contrast, applied before first paint (`index.html:63-69`); `prefers-contrast` and `prefers-reduced-motion` honoured; `Button` default `min-h-11` (44 px), icon buttons 44×44, hotline tiles 96–128 px; focus-visible rings everywhere; one `h1` per route; `<main>` focused on route change; native `<select>`; status conveyed by colour plus text; AA-checked ink/secondary tokens; `alt=""` on decorative images.

Gap. Skip link is English only; chat disclaimer English only; mixed-language tokens ("OPMCM", "NPT") have no `lang`; map markers have no keyboard path beyond the list; `color-scheme: only light` blocks OS dark mode (a top app complaint, though the council says do not build it now); no accessibility statement page; nothing for non-Nepali mother tongues; no audio.

Severity: Low for what exists (it is ahead of the state's own portals), **Medium** for the inclusion gaps given women's literacy and Madhesh.

Evidence. inventory §6, §10; `src/components/accessibility-bar.tsx`; `src/components/ui/button.tsx:19-23`.

---

3. What is already right and should be protected

The research found each of these to be rare on Nepali portals. They are the parts of the site that should survive any pivot.

1. **Hotlines on every page**, compact on phones, full tiles on home, `/info` and `/missing` (`emergency-bar.tsx`, `src/lib/helplines.ts`).
2. **No ads, no login to read, no comments.** Ads are the single most-complained-about feature in r/Nepal; comments would make the operator liable under the 2017 directive.
3. **Mandatory `Source:` lines** on every article cover and media block, enforced in the type (`src/articles/types.ts:9-17`), not by policy.
4. **Honest provenance on data**: the Live/Snapshot badge and tooltip, the `/info` mirror-sync note, the drop-centres disclaimer, the Zenodo DOI and licence on `/climate`.
5. **"VerifiedNepal never handles donations"** plus the police fake-QR warning; donate CTAs only to NRB/OPMCM-listed channels, which is exactly the revealed donor behaviour in 2026 (disaster note KQ7).
6. **Public, masked `/ledger`, `/audit` and `/coverage` with CSV/GeoJSON 3W export.** Nobody else in Nepal publishes ward-level needs → delivery; it cannot be forged with a logo.
7. **Real 404s, per-route canonicals on the apex, `Article` JSON-LD, sitemap with `lastmod`, `robots.txt` that protects `/search` and `/data/`.**
8. **`/search` kept `noindex` and robots-disallowed** on purpose: individual records stay behind an explicit name search, consistent with PCN 2083 and consent concerns.

9. **EN/NE key parity enforced by types** across 27 i18n files; `<html lang>` switches; Devanagari digits; tracked-uppercase disabled for Nepali.
10. **Accessibility bar, 44 px targets, focus rings, reduced motion, native selects, one h1 per route**, applied before first paint.
11. **A 23-section bilingual privacy and terms page** naming retention periods, removal rights, children and governing law.
12. `/flood-impact`: a unique, non-empty, credited reading surface with deep links and Web Share.
13. **Performance discipline that exists**: lazy routes, MapLibre only where needed, no third-party analytics, chat widget skipped on save-data/2G, offline shell and outbox.
14. **A hand-rolled design system that is boring in the right way**: crimson/blue flag-derived palette (a documented Nepali trust cue), one font family, no autoplay, no hover gimmicks.

---

4. The reader's-eye walkthrough (360 px Android, first visit)

She opens the link a cousin forwarded. The header reads "Verified Nepal" with a button "नेपाली" (why is it not already Nepali?), a blue bar "Live · updated 08:23", and a crimson strip "In danger? 1234 · Police 100 · Ambulance 102" (`home-360x740.png`). Good: the numbers are the first useful thing. Below, a small blue eyebrow "DISASTER RESPONSE ACROSS NEPAL" and a three-line headline "Community-verified disaster response for Nepal", then a paragraph about "individual records behind an explicit name search". She does not know what an individual record is. A blue card "Find someone — Search official rescued and missing-person records" fills the bottom of the screen; a round chat bubble overlaps its corner.

She taps नेपाली. The chrome changes; the paragraph is now "व्यक्तिगत अभिलेखलाई स्पष्ट नाम खोजी पछाडि राख्छ।", which is the same sentence. She scrolls: a blue band about dropping off flood relief goods with "16 relief centers", a satellite-view card about the Trishuli flood, four big numbers "Source: NDRRMA — Government of Nepal", a map she has to tap to move, three official notices with green "Verified" badges that open a government site. It is 14 October; everything is about 26 August. Nothing says what is happening today or in her district.

She opens the menu: thirteen items. "Articles" shows "ARTICLES / Articles / Moderated community writing on mountains and climate — editorial, not a forum.", a solid blue "Write an article" button, eight tag chips, and a dashed empty box "No articles match this filter. Try another tag or check back later." (`articles-360x740.png`, `articles-1280x800.png`). She did not want to write one. She guesses `/stories` from the "Stories from the ground" heading she saw earlier: "Page not found. The page you requested does not exist or may have moved." (`stories-404-360x740.png`).

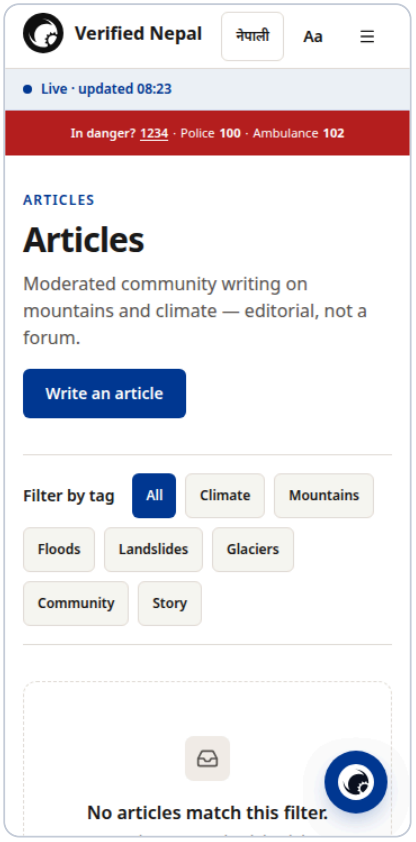
Back to the task that brought her. "Find someone": the page says "verifiedNepal shows aggregate rescue and missing-person status only. To search for a specific person by name, use the official OPMCM lost & found portal...", and then shows "Search by name — Enter a name in English or Nepali" (`find-person-360x740.png`). She types "ram bahadur" in Roman letters, the only way she types. Nothing. "Drop centres" shows the right header, a clear "Call before travelling" line, "Last verified: 2026-09-08", two filters and a Leaflet map with a verifiednepal.com watermark (`drop-centers-360x740.png`). Five weeks old; she would phone first, as the page itself suggests. "Our message" is an English word cloud ("Don't Melt Us", "Justice, Not Charity") under "What Nepal is telling the world", even in Nepali mode (`our-message-360x740.png`). She does not know why it is here.

What she would say afterwards: the numbers were there, it was not full of ads, it did not ask her to log in, and it looked serious; but she could not tell who runs it, it was about August, and the one search she needed did not understand how she spells. She goes back to Facebook. The `/flood-impact` page, which she never reached, is the one thing on the site she would have shown a friend (`flood-impact-360x740.png`: a credited satellite image with the eyebrow "26 AUGUST 2026 · LANGTANG LIRUNG GLACIAL LAKE OUTBURST").

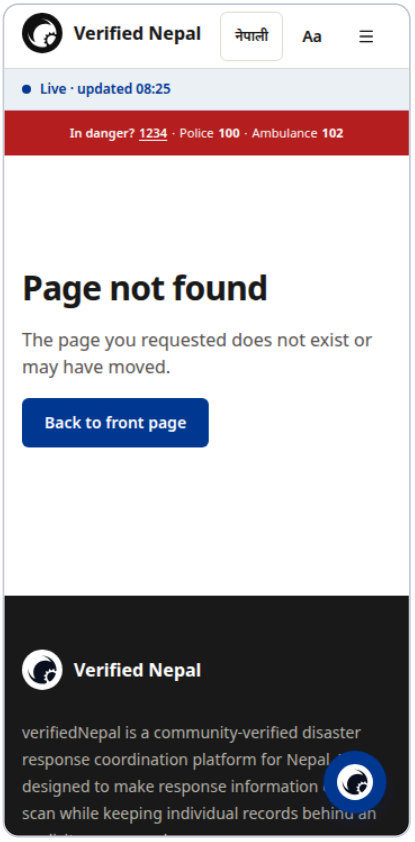
Figure 15. The public site as a first-time visitor sees it on a 360 px phone



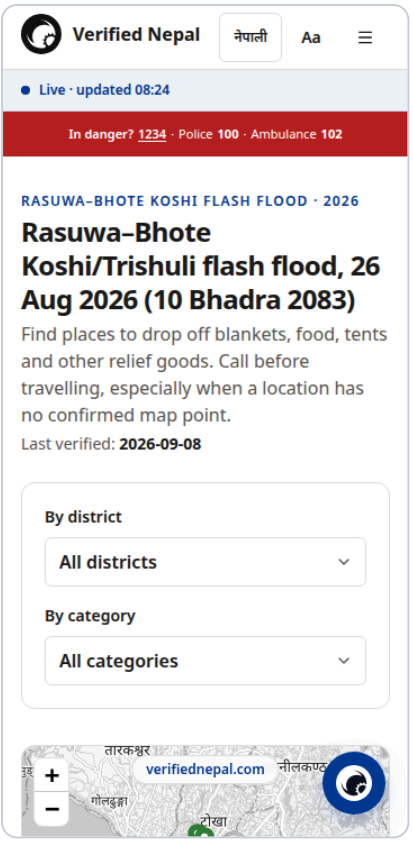
Home page



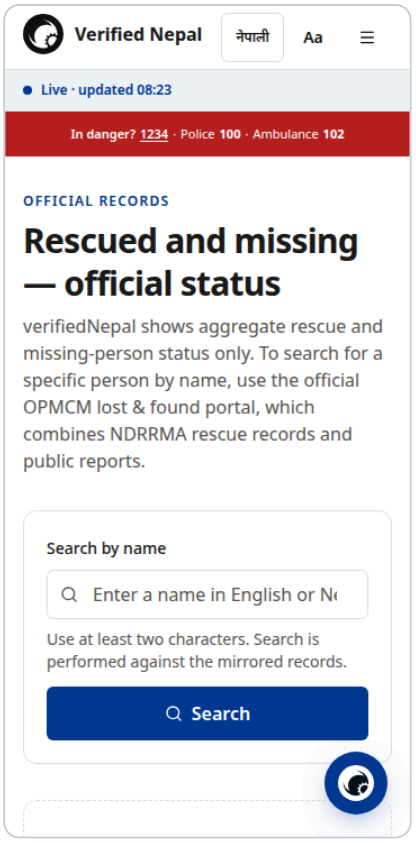
Articles



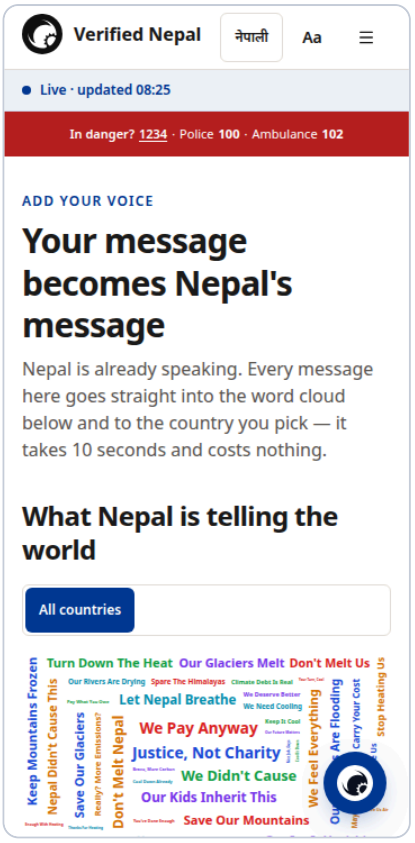
Stories: 404



Drop centres



Find a person



Our message



Flood impact



Article page (development host)

Captured 14 October 2026 at 360 by 740 px. All from production except the article page, which comes from the development host because production had no published articles.

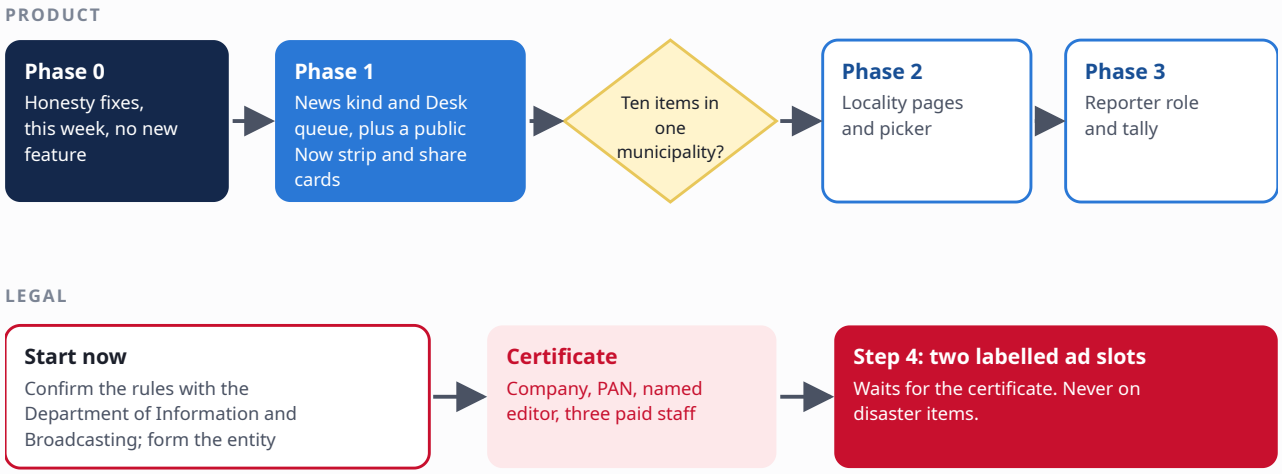
5. Persona-by-persona alignment

Persona	Top need (from research)	Met?	Where it is met or fails
Consumer (general Nepali reader)	Short, Nepali, dated, sourced items she can check at 6–11 pm	**Not met**	No dated items anywhere; English default; `/articles` empty; no BS date
Diaspora (Gulf/Malaysia, Roman-Nepali typist, Nepal-midnight evening)	Find a relative; a shareable "is this true?" card; English summary	**Partly**	`/search` exists and is private; cross-script search fails; share cards exist for incidents/climate but not for anything dated; no Viber
Disaster-affected household	Hotlines, nearest open relief point, register a need, status by code	**Mostly met**	Emergency bar; `/get-help` + `/status/:ref`; `/drop-centers` (but 16 bundled centres, last verified 2026-09-08); no SMS intake (deferred)
Volunteer / donor	Where is help needed, proof it arrived, safe channel to give	**Partly**	`/give-help`, `/ledger`, `/coverage` exist and PMDRF-only donation guidance is right; ledger/coverage empty on prod so no proof is visible yet
NGO / local government	3W data by ward; a record of delivery vs non-delivery	**Partly**	`/coverage` CSV/GeoJSON export is exactly the 3W format; no data in it; no palika author role; ward-chair adoption is a hypothesis, not evidence
Publisher / maintainer (the owner)	A pipeline that produces items without the owner writing them	**Not met**	Articles produced zero items at peak demand; local-updates pipeline decided but unbuilt
Journalist / correspondent	Citable permalink, source link, corrections log, CSV	**Partly**	Real 404s, JSON-LD, ledger CSV "for journalists"; no RSS, no `published_time`, no corrections log, no embed
Moderator / fact-checker	Queue with inline sources, rule card, PCN 2083 checklist, public audit trail	**Partly** (public side)	`/audit` is public and masked (empty on prod); moderation rules not public; PCN checklist not in the rule card yet
Regulator (DoIB / PCN)	Registration number, editor name, address, privacy policy, corrections, humane-reporting compliance	**Partly**	Privacy policy and no-money principle present; no registration, editor, address or corrections; "local updates" wording keeps the site outside "online media" for now

6. The council's recommended sequence, and where it differs from the owner's build order

The council (five advisors, five peer reviews, chairman's synthesis in `council-verdict.md`) agreed on seven points: supply is zero and the empty room falsifies the brand; the home page is frozen on August; the defensible asset is the aid/transparency stack, not prose; "Verified" must collapse to one meaning; do not build the full local-updates spec first; do not build comments, push, dark mode, AI writer, condolences or the ad-manager role now; the ideal item is Nepali-first, dated, sourced, short, shareable. It clashed on magazine-vs-ledger (resolved toward "the unit is the item, articles survive as evergreen explainers"), stop-vs-ship (resolved toward "ship the honest minimum"), and DoIB posture (resolved: the owner's registration path is lawful if the entity and staffing exist; until then the pre-moderated non-commercial posture is the defence, so ads must wait).

Figure 16. Recommended sequence: honesty first, growth gated on real content, ads gated on registration



Stop for now: comments, push alerts, dark mode, AI writer, condolences, ad manager, Nepali URLs, server rendering.

Council sequence summarised from section 6. Dates are not fixed; the gates are.

Its recommendation: Verified Nepal's public side should become **"Nepal's checked record"**: a Nepali-first status board of short, dated, located, sourced items, backed by the ward ledger, distributed as cards into Facebook/WhatsApp/Viber, with local updates as the pre-moderated human layer feeding the same strip. Not a magazine, not a portal.

Sequence as the council stated it:

- **Phase 0, honesty (this week, no new feature).** Un-hardwire `/` from the August flood; show every date as relative time plus BS; label the snapshot as a snapshot. Hide `/articles`, `/projects`, `/incidents` from nav while their API returns zero (keep routes; move "Write an article" behind sign-in). Remove the `/stories` link. Cut the hamburger to six: Now, Get help, Give help, Find someone, Drop centres, Ledger. Default to Nepali on first visit. Rewrite the hero in shopkeeper words; delete the "explicit name search" sentence; fix the `/search` contradiction. Two words only: "Official source / आधिकारिक स्रोत" for OPMCM/NDRRMA items, "Checked / जाँच गरिएको" for anything that passed moderation. Link GOVERNANCE and MODERATION-GUIDELINES; add a corrections line and PCN 2083 checklist to the Desk rule card. Drop `rescued-persons.json` from the SW precache; self-host two Devanagari weights.
- **Phase 1 = build-order step 1 plus its public face.** `kind: news` + validator + Desk queue as decided, **and** a home "Now" strip fed from four sources the site already has: OPMCM items, drop-centre verifications, ledger deliveries, published `kind: news` items. Every row: place, `happenedAt`, source link, relative time, EN/ने chip. Each row renders as a PNG share card via the existing `ShareButton` pipeline, with Viber added. Open an owned Facebook page and post the cards 6–9 pm daily. Promote `/flood-impact` and `/ledger` into the strip as standing entries.
- **Phase 2 = build-order step 2**, gated on one municipality holding ten published items. The picker is where Roman-Nepali input lands.
- **Phase 3 = step 3** (reporter role) as decided.
- **Step 4 (ads) waits for the DoIB certificate.** In parallel, starting now: confirm fees, editor and staffing rules with DoIB directly, and form the entity.

- **Keep:** hotlines, privacy page, no-money principle, `/ledger` `/coverage` `/audit`, `/flood-impact`. **Demote:** `/climate` and `/our-message` out of primary nav (owner to decide retire-or-keep explicitly). **Stop:** volunteer hours on climate-magazine articles; AI writer, condolences, ad manager, comments, push, dark mode, Nepali URLs/hreflang, SSR.
- **The one thing to do first:** replace the hard-wired August block on `/` with a dated, sourced "Now" strip fed from what the site already ingests, one row per item with place, source link and relative time.

Where this differs from `NEWS-PORTAL-DECISIONS.md`, stated neutrally:

Topic	Owner's decisions doc	Council verdict	Nature of the difference
First thing to ship	Build order step 1: `kind: news` + Desk queue (data model and moderation first)	Phase 0 honesty fixes, then step 1 **plus** a public "Now" strip fed from existing data	Council front-loads a public, visible change and a de-staling pass; owner's order starts with the back end. Both end at step 1.
"Now" strip timing	Part of step 2 (with `/local/<municipality>`, picker, GSI)	Pulled forward into Phase 1, fed from OPMCM/centres/ledger before any reporter exists	Sequencing only; the owner's step 2 strip is scoped to local updates, the council's is scoped to all dated items
Step 2 trigger	All 753 local levels available day one; only localities with items are listed	Gate step 2 on one municipality holding ten published items	Owner's rule already avoids empty pages; council adds a go/no-go threshold before building the locality layer
Ads (step 4)	Two labelled slots, after reporter role	Only after the DoIB certificate is issued; entity formation starts now in parallel	Council adds a legal gate, not a different design
Articles / climate / our-message	Not addressed in the decisions doc	Hide empty surfaces from nav; demote climate and our-message; stop volunteer hours on climate articles; keep articles as evergreen explainers	New recommendation for the owner to accept or reject
Distribution (Facebook page, Viber, share cards)	Not addressed	Owned Facebook page with a daily 6–9 pm card; Viber share; cards from the strip	New recommendation
Deferred items (AI writer, condolences, ad manager)	Deferred to step 5	Stop, plus also stop comments, push, dark mode, Nepali URLs/hreflang, SSR	Agreement on deferral; council widens the stop list
DoIB posture	VerifiedNepal registers; confirm fees/editor/renewal with DoIB directly	Same, with the added point that the 2025 rules need a company/firm with PAN, a named editor, three employees and bank-paid salaries, so registration is an entity and a payroll	Council sharpens the owner's own caveat; no disagreement on direction

Nothing in the council's sequence requires reversing a settled owner decision. The two substantive asks are: do Phase 0 before step 1, and do not let step 4 run ahead of the certificate.

---

7. Quick wins

Effort estimates assume one developer who knows the codebase; "d" = working day. No code was written for this report.

#	Change	Files touched	Effort	Gap closed
1	Replace "Live · updated HH:MM" with "Official data snapshot · " whenever the live fetch falls back; add a BS/relative dateline to `/` using the unused `edition.ts`	`src/lib/live.ts`, `src/components/site-status-bar.tsx`, `src/pages/home.tsx`, `src/lib/edition.ts`	0.5 d	2.1, 2.5
2	Hide `/articles`, `/projects`, `/incidents` from header/status-bar nav when their list is empty; drop the dead `/stories` heading link; move "Write an article" behind sign-in	`src/components/site-header.tsx:28-42`, `site-status-bar.tsx:22-31`, `src/pages/dispatches.tsx`	0.5 d	2.1, 2.10
3	Cut the hamburger to six primary items, move the rest under "More"	`src/components/site-header.tsx`	0.25 d	2.1
4	Default language to `ne` on first visit (keep persisted choice)	`src/App.tsx:181-197`	0.1 d	2.4
5	Rewrite hero lead and `/search` lead; delete the "explicit name search" sentence; make the `/search` lead say what the box does	`src/i18n/shell.ts`, `src/i18n/index.ts`, `src/pages/find-person.tsx`	0.25 d	2.1, 2.9
6	One vocabulary: "Official source / आधिकारिक स्रोत" vs "Checked / जाँच गरिएको"; apply to OPMCM badge, incidents lead, project badge	`src/i18n/*.ts`, `src/pages/home.tsx:490`, `project-detail.tsx:131`	0.5 d	2.3
7	Relative time ("११ घण्टा अगाडि") helper and BS date in bylines; keep Gregorian in metadata	`src/lib/format-date.ts`, `dispatch-detail.tsx`, `dispatches.tsx`, `incidents.tsx`	1 d	2.5
8	Self-host two Devanagari weights (400/600) and two Latin, drop the Google Fonts request	`index.html:28-34`, `src/styles.css:102-110`, `public/fonts/`	1 d	2.6
9	Remove `rescued-persons.json` and climate geo files from the SW precache glob (runtime-cache them instead)	`vite.config.ts:53`	0.25 d	2.6
10	Add Viber (`viber://forward?text=`) to the share rows; add `article:published_time` / `article:author` OG tags	`dispatch-detail.tsx:242-268`, `incidents.tsx`, `src/lib/og-meta.ts`, `functions/articles/[id].ts`	0.5 d	2.7
11	`/feed.xml` Function cloned from the sitemap fetch loop	`functions/feed.xml.ts` (new), reuse `functions/sitemap.xml.ts:31` pattern	0.5 d	2.7
12	Render GOVERNANCE and MODERATION-GUIDELINES as public routes; footer links; one-paragraph "how an item gets checked" on `/articles`	`src/App.tsx`, `src/components/site-footer.tsx`, new page(s)	0.5 d	2.8, 2.11
13	www → apex Redirect Rule (infra repo, Terraform `-target` per memory note) and submit the sitemap in Search Console (owner)	`verified-nepal-infra` (not this repo)	0.25 d + owner	2.7
14	`llms.txt` and `/info` copy un-hardwired from the August flood	`public/llms.txt`, `src/pages/info-help.tsx`	0.25 d	2.1, 2.8
15	Add `Organization.sameAs` and footer link for an owned Facebook page once created	`index.html:36-61`, `site-footer.tsx`	0.1 d + owner	2.7
16	Roman-Nepali → Devanagari transliteration for `/search` (table-driven, no library)	`src/pages/find-person.tsx`, new `src/lib/transliterate.ts`	2 d	2.4, 2.9

#	Change	Files touched	Effort	Gap closed
17	Nepali skip link and chat greeting/disclaimer	`src/App.tsx:285-291`, `src/lib/chat-widget.ts:181,224`	0.1 d	2.12

Items 1–6, 9, 14 and 17 together are the council's Phase 0 and total roughly three working days. The "Now" strip (council's "one thing to do first") is not a quick win; it is build-order step 1's public face and is estimated at 2–3 days on top of the step-1 data model.

---

8. Risks, legal notes and evidence caveats

DoIB 2025 rules. Per the publisher note (KQ1), the November 2025 amendment to the Press and Publication Rules sets registration at Rs 5,000 plus Rs 2,500 per year, and requires operating as a company/firm with PAN, a named qualified editor, at least three staff with a written commitment to bank-paid salaries, display of the registration number, addresses, editor/journalist names and a privacy policy, and public corrections. The decisions doc itself says its sources were law-firm summaries and news reports, not the official text, and that fees, editor requirements and renewal must be confirmed with DoIB directly. Until the entity exists, the words "news" and "reporter" in public copy, and any ad slot, are the exposure. The current public naming ("local updates", "local correspondents") is the right interim.

Operator liability for comments. The 2017 Online Media Operation Directive makes the operator responsible for user content including comments (publisher note KQ6). The site has no comments; the council says keep it that way. Public flagging via the existing FLAGGED queue is the safe substitute.

PCN "Humane and Responsible Disaster Reporting Guidelines 2083" (4 Sept 2026). Verify deaths/missing with official sources; verify social-media material on source, location, time and context; no faces of the dead, grieving families or children; no gruesome thumbnails or autoplay; label AI imagery; seek consent; correct immediately with an explanation. The site's mandatory `Source:` line, `noindex` person search and no-autoplay policy already fit; a corrections line and an AI-image label are the missing pieces, and the Desk rule card should carry the checklist.

Penal Code 2074 (ss. 295–296, privacy and photographs) and consent. The research notes raise these in the context of publishing images of identifiable people and of the dead, and of missing-person listings. Keeping `/search` de-indexed, pulling resolved listings, and requiring consent for poster photos of minors (Child-Friendly Communication Directive 2073) are the controls. This report has not read the statute text; it relies on the research notes' reading.

ETA s. 47. Used repeatedly against journalists and online critics 2024–2026 (publisher note KQ1; traction note KQ8). It is the reason Review 5 warned against simply "putting a named person and phone in the footer": the fix for "verified by whom?" is a legal shell (the registered entity the owner has chosen) or syndication to a registered outlet, not a personal name on an unregistered site.

The ledger's own exposure. A public row that says Ward 3 was *not* reached names, by implication, a CDO or ward chair. PCN now reaches non-media accounts via the Cyber Bureau (72 takedown orders cited for Aug 2026). Record deliveries as facts with source and date; never editorialise absence; keep the 3W export as data, not commentary.

Evidence caveats. - The ward-chair "public record proving relief had not arrived" hook rests on one Kathmandu Post report (18 Sept 2026) and the disaster note marks the tool idea as inference. Treat it as a hypothesis to test with one palika, not as demand evidence. - The inventory did not count ledger, coverage or audit rows. This report checked them on 2026-10-14: `/ledger → {"items":[]}`; `/audit?month=2026-08|09|10 → {"items":[]}`; `/coverage` cannot render because it needs an incident id and `/incidents` is empty. Review 4's claim that these surfaces are as empty as `/articles` is therefore confirmed for prod, not just for centres. The code and the exports are real; the public evidence of them is not yet. - The inventory's §3c and §8 predate the owner's 2026-10-14 decisions and still describe post-moderation labels and a lawyer's opinion; both are superseded. - No Lighthouse/CWV run exists; performance figures are build-size and single-sample curl measurements. - The `article-dev-*.png` screenshots are from `dev.verifiednepal.com` with seeded content; prod has no article page to capture. - Audience percentages are national survey figures (NMS 2020/2022/2024, DataReportal 2026, CMR Nepal 2024); none measures Verified Nepal's own readers, of whom Search Console sees too few to report. - Claims the council explicitly corrected are not repeated here: "100 outlets closing per year" (it was one year, all media); "The Record died" (hiatus, archive live); "a volunteer operation cannot legally be a news portal, full stop" (overstated); "spend the Rs 5,000" (registration is an entity and a payroll); "/search beats the state" (it searches NDRRMA's own lists).

9. Appendix

9.1 Inventory cross-reference: public routes and status on 2026-10-14

Route	Purpose	Prod status	In nav?
`/`	Task hub + situation band	Live; content frozen on Aug 2026 flood	—
`/articles`, `/articles/:id`	Moderated articles	List empty (`{"items":[]}`); detail 404s correctly	Hamburger + status bar
`/stories`	(no route)	"Page not found", HTTP 200	Heading only, no link target
`/incidents`	Admin-approved disasters	Empty	Hamburger
`/flood-impact`	Satellite before/after drive	Live, non-empty	Home CTA only
`/climate`	Static climate dataset	Live, non-empty	Hamburger + status bar
`/our-message`	Word cloud + send form	Live; English cloud	Hamburger + status bar
`/projects`, `/projects/:id`, `/register`, `/update`	Rebuild projects	Empty	Hamburger + status bar
`/drop-centers`, `/:id`	Relief drop-off points	16 bundled (2026-09-08); API centres empty	Hamburger + status bar + emergency bar
`/coverage`	Ward coverage + 3W export	Cannot render (no incidents)	Home/footer only
`/ledger`	Masked aid ledger + CSV	Empty	Hamburger + status bar

Route	Purpose	Prod status	In nav?
`/audit`	Masked moderator log	Empty Aug–Oct 2026	Footer only
`/drones`	Drone tasking board	Not checked for rows	Hamburger
`/search`	Person-name search	Live; `noindex`; cross-script fails	Hamburger
`/missing`	Family guide	Live	Footer/raw nav
`/poster`, `/poster/:id`	Poster builder/board	Live	Hamburger + status bar
`/get-help`, `/status/:ref`	Need form + status	Live	Hamburger
`/give-help`	Needs board + offers	Not checked for rows (`/needs` requires incident id)	Hamburger
`/report-incident`	Report a disaster	Live (Google sign-in)	Hamburger (via incidents)
`/register-organization`	Org sign-up	Live	Hamburger
`/donation/:ref`	Donation receipt lookup	Live	Deep link only
`/info`	Hotlines, about, data source	Live; single-flood copy	Hamburger
`/how-to`	Illustrated guide	Live; 4.9 MB images	Footer/raw nav
`/privacy`	Privacy & Terms EN/NE	Live	Footer
`/feed.xml`, `/rss.xml`	—	SPA shell, HTTP 200	—
`www.` host	—	HTTP 200, no redirect	—

9.2 References

Internal (paths relative to `/home/lxu/workspace/laxman/verifiednepal/`):

1. `docs/public-audit-2026-10/research_notes/Nepali online news audience/verified_nepal_public_site_inventory.md` — primary inventory, §1–§12, with `file:line` citations.
2. `docs/public-audit-2026-10/research_notes/Nepali online news audience/screenshots/*.png` — `home-360x740`, `home-1280x800`, `articles-360x740`, `articles-1280x800`, `stories-404-360x740`, `find-person-360x740`, `find-person-1280x800`, `drop-centers-360x740`, `our-message-360x740`, `flood-impact-360x740`, `article-dev-360x740` (dev host).
3. `docs/public-audit-2026-10/council-question.md`, `council-advisors.md`, `council-reviews.md`, `council-verdict.md` — council rounds and chairman's synthesis, including "Factual corrections to carry into the reports".
4. `docs/NEWS-PORTAL-DECISIONS.md` (2026-10-14) — owner decisions: pre-moderation, VerifiedNepal registers with DoIB, build order, deferred items.
5. `docs/SEO-ACTION-PLAN.md`, `docs/CONTRIBUTOR-TODO.md`, `docs/TODO.md`, `docs/GOVERNANCE.md`, `docs/MODERATION-GUIDELINES.md`, `docs/DESIGN-GUIDELINES.md`, `docs/onlyutils-media-variants-requirement.md`.
6. Code cited: `src/pages/home.tsx`, `src/pages/find-person.tsx`, `src/pages/dispatches.tsx`, `src/pages/dispatch-detail.tsx`, `src/pages/incidents.tsx`, `src/pages/privacy.tsx`, `src/pages/coverage.tsx`, `src/pages/ledger.tsx`, `src/lib/api.ts`, `src/lib/format-date.ts`, `src/lib/live.ts`, `src/lib/og-meta.ts`, `src/lib/edition.ts`, `src/lib/helplines.ts`, `src/lib/chat-widget.ts`, `src/articles/types.ts`, `src/articles/render.tsx`, `src/components/site-header.tsx`, `src/components/site-status-bar.tsx`, `src/components/accessibility-bar.tsx`, `src/components/ui/button.tsx`, `src/i18n/shell.ts`, `src/i18n/index.ts`, `src/i18n/climate.ts`, `src/i18n/how-to.ts`, `index.html`, `vite.config.ts`, `public/robots.txt`, `public/llms.txt`, `public/data/meta.json`, `src/data/relief-centers.json`, `functions/articles/[id].ts`, `functions/sitemap.xml.ts`, `functions/_shared/meta.ts`.

Live checks (2026-10-14, by this report unless noted):

7. `https://api.prod.verifiednepal.com/dispatches`, `/stories`, `/centers`, `/incidents`, `/projects`, `/ledger` → `{"items":[]}`; `/audit?month=2026-08|2026-09|2026-10` → `{"items":[]}`; `/needs` and `/coverage` → `incidentId required`.
8. `https://verifiednepal.com/feed.xml` → SPA shell; `https://verifiednepal.com/stories` → 200 (client Not Found); `https://verifiednepal.com/articles/nope` → 404; `https://www.verifiednepal.com/` → 200, no redirect.

Research notes (same folder) and the external sources they cite:

9. `audience_habits_and_demographics.md` — Q1–Q7; DataReportal Digital 2026: Nepal, https://datareportal.com/reports/digital-2026-nepal; Nepal Media Survey 2020/2022/2024 (Sharecast Initiative); CMR Nepal 2024 misinformation survey.
10. `audience_pain_points_reddit_forums.md` — KQ1–KQ7; r/Nepal and r/technepal threads 2020–2024; Hamro Patro Play Store reviews; academic clickbait study cited therein.
11. `disaster_civic_information_seeking.md` — KQ1–KQ8; Kathmandu Post, 18 Sept 2026 (Rasuwa ward chairs vs CDO; the "public record" hook, marked inference at the note's line 320); NDRRMA and Nepal Police Facebook pages; BIPAD portal.
12. `nepali_ui_ux_conventions.md` — §1–§8; Setopati/eKantipur/Onlinekhabar mastheads; Google Fonts subset sizes; MoCIT 2021 website directive; Dina TTS (UNICEF/ATscale, 3 Dec 2024).
13. `portal_traction_and_business_models.md` — KQ1–KQ9; Similarweb/Ahrefs estimates; RONB and Hamro Patro case studies; Kantipur digital subscription Aug 2026.
14. `publisher_journalist_moderator_side.md` — KQ1–KQ7; Online Media Operation Directive 2017; Press and Publication Rules amendment Nov 2025; PCN "Editorial Guidelines for Humane and Responsible Disaster Reporting, 2083" (4 Sept 2026); ETA 2063 s. 47; Freedom Forum 2025/2026 reports.

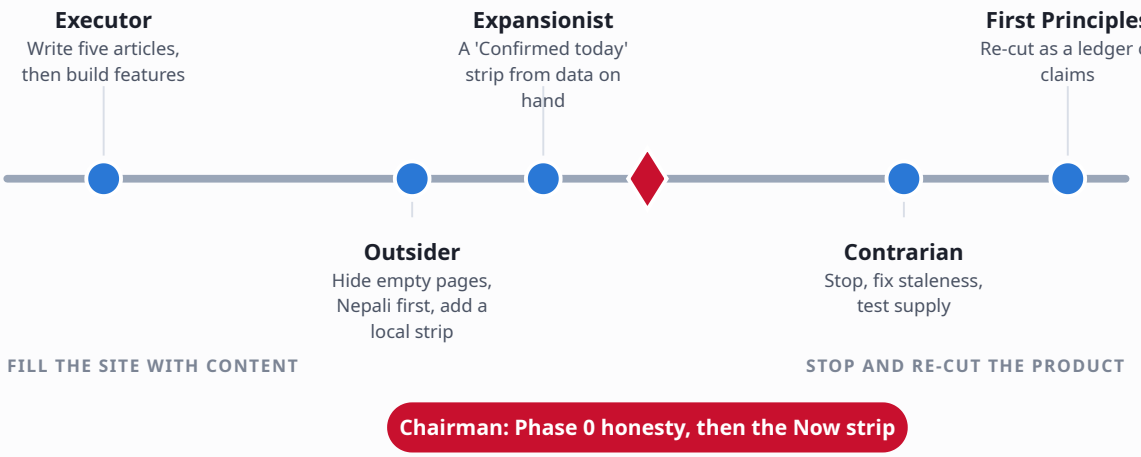
Where this report states a legal rule, it is restating the research notes' reading of secondary sources; the owner's decisions doc already records that official texts, fees and staffing rules must be confirmed with DoIB directly.

APPENDIX A

Council verdict: the public side of Verified Nepal (2026-10-14)

Chairman's synthesis of five advisors (Contrarian, First Principles, Expansionist, Outsider, Executor) and five peer reviews, judged against `docs/NEWS-PORTAL-DECISIONS.md` as updated 2026-10-14 (pre-moderation; VerifiedNepal registers with DoIB) and `verified_nepal_public_site_inventory.md`.

Figure 17. Where each advisor would start, and where the chairman landed



Positions summarise each advisor's first recommendation; they are not scores.

Where the Council Agrees

1. **Supply is zero and the empty room falsifies the brand.** All five, independently: prod returns `{"items":[]}` for articles, stories, projects, centres and incidents; `/stories` is a 404; `/articles` shows "Write an article" above "No articles match". A verification brand with nothing to check is a contradiction on first visit.
2. **The home page is frozen on 26 August.** NDRRMA snapshot `synced_at 2026-08-29`, centres `last_verified 2026-09-08`, `llms.txt` still a single-flood dashboard, while the status bar says "Live". C, E, B and D all call this the most urgent credibility leak; A implies it.
3. **The unique, defensible asset is the aid/transparency stack, not prose.** `/ledger`, `/coverage` (3W export), `/audit`, mandatory `Source:` lines, Live/Snapshot badge, "never handles money". C, D, E and A all list it; nobody else in Nepal tracks needs → delivery at ward level, and it cannot be forged with a logo.
4. **"Verified" must collapse to one meaning.** Five senses today (inventory §8); A, C, E and B each flag it.
5. **Do not build the full local-updates spec first.** A and D want step 1 / the "Now" strip only; C and E want none of it. Nobody endorses 753 locality pages before one municipality has content.
6. **Do not build** comments, push, dark mode, the AI writer, condolences or the ad-manager role now (A explicit; C, E by posture; no dissent).
7. **Nepali-first, dated, sourced, short, shareable** is the ideal item shape (B, D, E, A).

Where the Council Clashes

Magazine vs ledger. A would fill `/articles` with owner-written pieces and add a latest block, RSS, BS dates. C and E say stop spending on articles entirely and re-cut local updates as `kind: claim`. B wants empties hidden. D splits the difference: feed a "Confirmed today" strip from data the site already ingests. Reasonable advisors disagree because they weigh different bottlenecks: A sees a writing problem, C/E see a positioning and legal problem, D sees a distribution problem. Four of five reviewers backed D. The Chairman agrees: the unit of content is the dated, located, sourced *item*, not the article; articles survive only as evergreen explainers.

Stop vs ship. C says stop until a lawyer signs off and a 30-day supply test passes. Review 4's rebuttal is decisive: C's cure has the disease it diagnoses, since "stop" produces nothing citable and ward chairs are not users yet. Ship, but ship the honest minimum.

DoIB posture. A: register later when there is a month of content. C/E: a volunteer operation cannot register, so never be a portal. Owner: VerifiedNepal registers. Under the corrected facts, **C/E's moderation argument is moot** (pre-moderation chosen) and **their "never register" argument is overruled**, but one point survives intact: the 2025 rules need a company or firm with PAN/VAT, a qualified named editor, at least three employees and a written commitment to bank-paid salaries (publisher note KQ1). Registration is a legal entity and a payroll, not a Rs 5,000 form. A's "later" is therefore not a sequencing choice; until the entity exists, the pre-moderated, non-commercial, "local updates" posture is the only defence. That makes build-order step 4 (ad slots) the one item that must wait for registration: labelled ads on news-like items before registration is the worst of both positions.

Owner writes the content. A's step 1 is "write five articles yourself". Reviews 2, 4 and 5 object that it is online journalism by one anonymous person and reproduces the exact bottleneck that produced zero items. Both are right about different things: the owner should not be the news supply, but owner-written *explainers* (how relief works, how to read a bulletin, how to use the ledger) are the evergreen layer Review 4 asked for and carry no news exposure.

Blind Spots the Council Caught

- **The reader's intent is a question, not a feed**: "does my palika have X?" Nobody specified the query path. The picker needs Roman-Nepali input and Nepali-digit/spelling normalisation; cross-script person search returns nothing today (CONTRIBUTOR-TODO §2).
- **Performance for 360px/4G**: SW precaches 124 files including the 1.5 MB `rescued-persons.json` on first visit; Leaflet + Esri tiles on home; 0.5-0.9 MB of fonts. Only A touched fonts.
- **55% non-Nepali mother tongue, Madhesh (20% online news), women's literacy 69%, Dina TTS/TalkBack**: "default to Nepali" is necessary but not sufficient; audio or TTS-friendly markup matters.
- **Facebook and dark social are the distribution surface** (90% reach; 69-83% direct traffic). `Organization.sameAs` lists only GitHub; no owned page, no Viber share. The site wins as the citation target, not the destination.
- **Cadence**: a 6-11 pm daily bulletin, and an answer for Falgun when there is no flood. Relief delivery is not a daily beat.

- **The unused asset**: `/flood-impact` is the only non-empty, unique reading surface and nobody anchored on it.
- **The ledger's own exposure**: a public record that Ward 3 was not reached names a CDO; PCN now reaches non-media accounts (72 takedown orders, Aug 2026). Record deliveries as facts; never editorialise absence.
- **PCN 2083 guidelines and a corrections log**: cheap trust markers nobody proposed; the Desk rule card should carry them.
- **The Rasuwa ward-chair anecdote** is the sole evidence for the ledger pivot and the note marks the tool idea as inference.
- **Overstatements** (see last section).

The Recommendation

Verified Nepal's public side should become **Nepal's checked record**: a Nepali-first status board of short, dated, located, sourced items, backed by the ward ledger, distributed as cards into Facebook/WhatsApp/Viber, with "local updates" as the pre-moderated human layer feeding the same strip. Not a magazine, not a portal.

Sequence, for one owner plus volunteers:

Phase 0, honesty (this week, no new feature). Un-hardwire `/` from the August flood; show every date as relative time plus BS date, and label the snapshot as a snapshot. Hide `/articles`, `/projects`, `/incidents` from nav while their API returns zero (keep routes; move "Write an article" behind sign-in). Remove the `/stories` link. Cut the hamburger to six: Now, Get help, Give help, Find someone, Drop centres, Ledger. Default to Nepali on first visit. Rewrite the hero in shopkeeper words; delete the "explicit name search" sentence; fix the `/search` contradiction. Two words only: "Official source / आधिकारिक स्रोत" for OPMCM/NDRRMA items, "Checked / जाँच गरिएको" for anything that passed moderation. Link GOVERNANCE and MODERATION-GUIDELINES; add a corrections line and PCN 2083 checklist to the Desk rule card. Drop `rescued-persons.json` from the SW precache; self-host two Devanagari weights.

Phase 1 = build-order step 1 plus its public face. `kind: news` + validator + Desk queue as decided, and a home "Now" strip fed from four sources: OPMCM items already pulled, drop-centre verifications, ledger deliveries, and published `kind: news` items. Every row: place, happenedAt, source link, relative time, EN/ने chip. Each row renders as a PNG share card via the existing `ShareButton` pipeline, with Viber added to WhatsApp/Facebook. Open an owned Facebook page and post the cards at 6-9 pm daily. Promote `/flood-impact` and `/ledger` into the strip as standing entries.

Phase 2 = build-order step 2, gated on one municipality holding ten published items. The picker is where Roman-Nepali input lands.

Phase 3 = step 3 (reporter role) as decided.

Step 4 (ads) waits for the DoIB certificate. In parallel, starting now: confirm fees, editor and staffing rules with DoIB directly, and form the entity; this is the gating item for the words "news", "reporter" and for any ad.

Keep: hotlines, privacy page, no-money principle, `/ledger` `/coverage` `/audit`, `/flood-impact`. Demote: `/climate` and `/our-message` out of primary nav (owner to decide retire-or-keep explicitly). Stop: volunteer hours on climate-magazine articles; AI writer, condolences, ad manager, comments, push, dark mode, Nepali URLs/hreflang, SSR.

The One Thing to Do First

Replace the hard-wired August block on `/` with a dated, sourced "Now" strip fed from what the site already ingests (OPMCM items, centre verifications, ledger deliveries), one row per item with place, source link and relative time. It fixes the staleness lie, gives the first shareable card, and is the public face of build-order step 1 before a single reporter exists.

Factual corrections to carry into the reports

- **E**: "100 closing per year" is one year (2023) across all media, not an annual rate of online portals.
- **C**: The Record did not "die"; it announced an extended hiatus in July 2022 and its archive is live.
- **C, E, Reviews 1/2/5**: post-moderation, "Not yet checked" labels, tiers and strikes are dropped; local updates are pre-moderated. Arguments against post-moderation are moot.
- **C**: "the lawyer's opinion the owner already decided to get" is not in the current decisions doc; it now says confirm fees and editor rules with DoIB directly.
- **A**: DoIB registration is not "spend the Rs 5,000"; it requires a company/firm with PAN, a named qualified editor, at least three employees and bank-paid salaries.
- **E**: "A volunteer operation cannot legally be a news portal. Full stop." is overstated; the owner's chosen path (a registered entity with contributors) is lawful if the entity and staffing exist. The note's actual claim is that a *pure volunteer* operation cannot meet the salary commitment.
- **Review 4**: "/ledger, /coverage and centres are as empty on prod as /articles" is only confirmed for centres; the inventory does not record ledger or coverage row counts. Treat as unverified.
- **D**: `/search` is `noindex` and robots-disallowed deliberately for privacy; un-indexing it conflicts with PCN 2083 and the Penal Code consent concerns. "Beats the state" overstates a search over NDRRMA's own lists.
- **Review 1**: A's five articles were "from NDRRMA bulletins and Trishuli imagery", not "climate-magazine" pieces.
- **All**: the ward-chair adoption hook rests on one Kathmandu Post report and is marked as inference in the disaster note; present it as a hypothesis to test, not evidence.